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‘America Doesn’t Want My Children or Grandchildren’

The Cruz family spent years building a life in New York. Then the risks of staying became too great.

by Caitlin Dickerson



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The Cruz family was exhausted. It was two days before Christmas 2024, and Rachel was coughing from bronchitis, her body once again crashing into the holiday break as she finished her 17th year teaching public high school in

New York City. Irvi, her husband, was sleeping after his day shift at an upscale bistro on the Upper West Side, which had followed an overnight shift at a Latin dance club farther uptown, in Inwood. Between the two jobs, he'd dropped their daughters—Sara, 12, and Ana, 10—at their schools for gifted students, then rushed home to the Bronx to cook and do laundry.

For years, Rachel and Irvi had been hustling to make this routine work, hoping that American immigration policy would evolve and allow Irvi, who had spent half his life in the United States, to become a citizen. Raising two children in New York City was expensive. Each day felt like a marathon they didn't think they could finish. But the girls were thriving, and Rachel and Irvi were beloved at work. Every few years, they met with lawyers who urged them to hang on, so they did.

I [met the Cruz family in late 2016](#), when Donald Trump's election, and his contempt for immigrants, first made them think of moving to Irvi's hometown, in rural southern Mexico. But their daughters were just 2 and 4 then, and uprooting them was daunting. Four years later, Joe Biden's win made the Trump years seem like an aberration, and Rachel and Irvi thought, once again, that a solution to their problem was within reach. Then came 2024, when 77.3 million Americans voted for Trump. His campaign signs had called for [MASS DEPORTATION NOW](#)! To the Cruzes, the message was clear: Irvi should give up and go home.

The family had never been apart for long. The four of them linked arms or held hands when they walked down the street together, without seeming to notice they were doing it. [Separation was not an option](#). So they would go, all of them.

"We no longer have the faith that things will always be better here in the United States," Rachel told me that night in December, sitting at their dining table, cupping a Zabar's mug full of tea.

[From the September 2022 issue: Caitlin Dickerson's Pulitzer Prize-winning story about the secret history of family separation](#)

Drained from work, Irvi shuffled down the stairs in sweatpants. He had dark bags under his eyes but greeted me with his squinty smile. He sat down and

said he was excited to live freely for the first time in his adult life. He was also scared. The only story he'd known about his family—that they were proud New Yorkers—was about to end. Sara, who had been standing behind him, playing with his salt-and-pepper hair, ran into the kitchen to cry. Rachel hurried after her.

“What do you want?” Rachel asked softly. “Do you want to give Papá a hug?”

“No, I just want to go to my room,” Sara said. “I don't want to talk about this. I don't want to be here.”

“Well, if we get it out now, maybe it'll make you feel better later,” Rachel told her, unsure if that was true.

Their tentative plan was to sell the house and move in with Irvi's parents, 2,100 miles away. Irvi would go first, so he'd be out of the country before Trump took office. Rachel and the girls would join him seven months later, in August 2025, after finishing the school year and summer camp. They didn't know what they'd do for income in Mexico, or where the girls—who knew only a little Spanish—would go to school.



Sara packs up her New York life in July 2025. (Natalie Keyssar for *The Atlantic*)

Friends thought they were overreacting. Some were upset. After all, New York was a sanctuary city and Irvi was married to an American citizen. Rachel and Irvi found these reactions maddening. They saw their American friends as stubbornly naive about the system they had been battling for decades, and their undocumented friends as deluded for clinging to hope instead of reason.

Rachel's mother, Susan McCormick, had heaved and sobbed when she learned that the granddaughters she was helping to raise would be leaving New York. She and Rachel's father, Doug, were furious with the country for putting them in this situation. Their daughter was one of nearly [4.2 million American citizens and permanent residents in the United States with an undocumented spouse](#), and Sara and Ana were among 6.3 million children with an undocumented parent. How many were also choosing family over country? And what was the United States losing in the process?

By Christmas 2024, the McCormicks were trying to be stoic, to give Rachel and Irvi strength and to show the girls that everything was going to be okay. Doug had become a genealogy nerd in retirement and was reminding himself that their ancestors had made a move like this every few centuries: Irish farmers running from famine, Germans displaced by war, and Russian and Ukrainian Jews escaping pogroms. He even found ancestors aboard the Mayflower.

But all of these prior generations had found refuge here. “After 400 years in this country,” Doug told me, “suddenly America doesn’t want my children and grandchildren.”

Rachel, Irvi, and their daughters would be the first in their family to run from—rather than to—the United States.



The Cruz family in 2018 (Jeff Samaniego)

On September 11, 2001, Irvi was 19 years old and had recently arrived in upstate New York. He was working on a construction crew, remodeling a Chinese restaurant, when the Spanish music on the radio was interrupted by grave English he didn't understand. Terrorists had flown jets into the World Trade Center. George W. Bush's administration would soon abandon negotiations to grant legal status to undocumented Mexicans and instead create the Department of Homeland Security, with a mission to deport them.

But on September 12, Irvi's employer still wanted him to come to work as if nothing had happened. It was the kind of mixed message that would characterize his life in the United States. After a few more years of construction work, he felt homesick and returned to Mexico. But as soon as he touched down there, he felt he'd made a mistake. He had grown up in a one-room house without running water, dreaming of riding a motorcycle—a luxury that he could never afford if he stayed. He started making plans to go back to New York right away.

Irvi's parents, Lulu and Martín, were leery of his decision. Both were the children of peasant farmers and had grown up in homes made of adobe and sticks. But they never thought of joining the [more than 8 million Mexicans who'd moved north](#), starting with their parents' generation and [the U.S. government's Bracero Program](#) for temporary workers. American farmers got hooked on cheap labor and, after the program ended in 1964, continued to recruit Mexican workers, who now had to cross the border illegally.

[Read: The disturbing history of the Bracero Program](#)

Lulu, a street vendor, was afraid that discouraging Irvi would backfire. Martín, a bus driver on Mexico's dusty rural highways, couldn't hold back. "That country will eat you," he said of the United States. "Of course, here it's more work and less money, but you get used to it."

When Irvi told them he was going back, his parents knew they might never see him again. Martín thought to himself: *I don't have a son anymore.*

With his 16-year-old cousin, Irvi tried to sneak back across the border somewhere in Arizona. They got lost in the desert, and Border Patrol agents found them. Irvi's cousin started crying, and one of the agents gave them water, peanuts, and cookies. "Don't worry; you're safe now," the agent said in Spanish. "Tomorrow you can try again, and maybe you'll make it." After a few attempts, they were successful.

Back in upstate New York, Irvi returned to working in construction. He was determined to learn English, so he immersed himself in American music and television, especially *Chappelle's Show*.

Around that time, Rachel, who grew up in a wealthy suburb of Philadelphia, graduated from Vassar. She had studied abroad in Mexico and taken a class with the geographer Joseph Nevins, who gave lectures about the American government's complicity in a system that exploits immigrants for their labor but denies them the dignity of legal residency.

She and Irvi met on a sunny afternoon in 2006 while they were watching an outdoor soccer game in Poughkeepsie. She was hobbling around on crutches because of a sprained ankle, and he jumped up to help her. Rachel was swept away by Irvi's sweetness and exuberance. Irvi loved Rachel's intelligence and empathy. They talked about everything—their different upbringings, their jobs, their roommate drama. Soon he was visiting her on the weekends in Philadelphia, where she had gotten a job. On one trip, a police officer stopped him, saw that he was undocumented, and let him off with a warning. To avoid the risk of driving for visits, Irvi moved in.

Around 2009, they went to see the first of many lawyers, who said that Irvi wasn't eligible to apply for legal status, even if he married Rachel, because he had gone back and forth across the border after living for more than a year in the United States. The only work-around was for him to spend 10 years in Mexico and then apply for a waiver. But a Democratic Congress, with Barack Obama in the White House, appeared to be on the precipice of passing immigration reform.

Eventually, Rachel got a teaching job in New York, and they found an apartment in Harlem. Irvi started busing tables at the bistro on the Upper West Side, while Rachel taught overcrowded classrooms of low-income students. Despite the pressure and burnout, she felt like she was offering kids a chance at the American dream. *No matter where you come from, she believed, if you land in a public school, and if you get a teacher like me, you can make it.* On their third anniversary, Irvi proposed in a rowboat in Central Park.

Sara was born in 2012, Ana in 2014. Irvi was their full-time caretaker, toting them by subway to museums, the aquarium, the zoo, and story time at the public libraries. On weekends, he squeezed in five shifts as a busboy. He and Rachel made enough money to cover the essentials, and Rachel's parents helped with child care, but they went years without paying for a haircut or

buying new clothes. They sometimes fought when they were tired and felt like they hadn't seen each other in weeks, or when Irvi's spontaneity clashed with Rachel's need for order. But they could never stare each other down for long without cracking a smile.

Irvi's unresolved immigration status trailed them, usually from a distance. ICE agents once entered their apartment building looking for a neighbor; Rachel stood guard at the peephole while Irvi hid in the bedroom. A few years later, Irvi borrowed his in-laws' car to take the girls to Coney Island. As they approached the park, he spotted a police checkpoint at the entrance. He pulled over and had a panic attack, then tried to play it off by telling the girls that the car was breaking down.

Rachel and Irvi talked about what to do if ICE ever tried to arrest him while she was at work. Irvi would have to persuade the officers to wait long enough for Susan and Doug to pick up the girls. "You have to fight to make sure that our kids are safe," Rachel told him.

For years, Congress debated changes to the immigration system, including ones that would have helped Irvi. When Sara was old enough, she joined Rachel at protests with a sign that said Don't deport my dad. As part of a campaign called [Dream Across America](#), Rachel rode a bus to Washington, D.C., where members of Congress admitted to activists that they hadn't known that so many mixed-status families were in limbo.

Rachel was stunned by Trump's first election, but Irvi had expected it. Up to this point, Sara and Ana had only a vague understanding that their father was different from them, but they began to realize that he was in danger. Ana lost interest in playing with other children and asked her parents why the president hated her. She had nightmares and panic attacks, and had to see a therapist. Irvi distracted her and Sara with bedtime stories about Eddie Spaghetti, a caricature of himself, who fought battles against dragons and monsters inspired by rude customers at his restaurant.

As they did their best to block out national politics, their community embraced them. Rachel's students nominated her for a Big Apple Award, which recognizes the best teachers in the city, and she became the head of the department at her school that teaches English as a new language. Ana

and Sara became fixtures in their school plays and joined a children's choir that rehearsed at Riverside Church. At the bistro, Irvi was promoted to server and then manager. He took night shifts at the club in Inwood, and began bringing home more money than Rachel—enough to buy the motorcycle he had dreamed of.

They borrowed against Rachel's retirement savings for a down payment on a bright-blue townhouse in the Bronx's Little Italy. The house was far from a subway stop but had a spacious front porch that looked out onto a maple tree. The plumbing didn't work and some rooms had no windows; Irvi paid his construction-worker friends to help him fix it up. The family turned hiding their home's flaws into a giant art project, creating a mural out of postcards to cover up cracked walls and ornamenting the crooked old stairs with starburst wallpaper. Their American dream may have been spackled together with glue and construction paper, but it held.

Rachel was standing in the front yard with a rake in her hand when their next-door neighbor Cookie ran out and announced that the 2020 election had been called for Joe Biden. Rachel felt something new: optimism. She and Irvi daydreamed about finishing the basement and redoing the kitchen. They started to believe they would grow old together there.

During the summer of 2024, Biden announced a program, [Keeping Families Together](#), that would finally allow people like Irvi to become citizens through their American spouse. Rachel holed up in their home office one Sunday with the application, attaching hundreds of documents that illustrated the life they had built together. She paid the government's \$580 fee and clicked "Submit."

"It looks like Irvi might finally be getting legal protection," she texted me at the time.

The next day, [a federal judge put the program on hold](#) after 16 Republican-led states sued. A few months later, Trump was reelected and [the court terminated the program](#). Because of the application that Rachel had filed for Irvi, the incoming administration knew exactly who, and where, he was.

In January 2025, after the holiday break, Rachel stayed up late watching TV interviews with survivors of the Los Angeles wildfires. She found comfort in hearing people say that even though their home was gone, they still had their family, and that's all that mattered. The girls picked 10 family activities to do before Irvi left the United States. Sara wanted to go ice skating in Central Park. Ana requested a day at the American Dream mall in New Jersey, which has a ski slope and a water park. They found discount tickets for *Hairspray*, *Gypsy*, and *Annie*.

On Irvi's last day in New York, January 13, 2025, the whole family piled into the car for school drop-offs. Trump was planning to end a policy that made schools off-limits for immigration raids, so Rachel was carrying a trifold poster board explaining what to do in an encounter with ICE. Sara was finishing a homework assignment about the writers of the Declaration of Independence. "Let's say, all of a sudden, you're reading a story in English, and it's about a dad, and all of a sudden you're feeling really sad," Rachel asked. "Do you have an adult that you can talk to?"

"Yes," the girls said in unison.

Irvi bopped his head to La Mega, the Spanish-language radio station that he and the girls listened to each morning. For more than two decades, he had tried to be perfect—perfect at work, perfect in his marriage, perfect as a father and neighbor, as if playing a game that he could eventually win. He told me he had slipped, once, 22 years ago, when he was briefly charged with a misdemeanor for carrying a small amount of cocaine—a onetime mistake in his early 20s. Though the charge was dropped, and doesn't even come up in a background check, Irvi said he didn't want to hide anymore, in any respect. But honesty and character didn't seem to matter to the incoming president, who was conflating all unauthorized immigrants with the people he called "illegal monsters"—the small number who had committed heinous crimes.

"That's not what I've been working for," Irvi said. "That's not what I deserve."

Irvi made a final visit to a Bronx bodega that served as a hangout for Mexican immigrants. He would go there when he felt homesick, or when he

was tired of speaking English. His friends tried again to talk him out of leaving. Save more money first, they said, or talk to a lawyer—as if Irvi hadn't been talking to lawyers for years. He left angry but arrived home sad, knowing he might never see those friends again.

He tucked the girls in that night and waited for Doug, Rachel's father, to arrive. Around 3 a.m., the two men, along with Mango the cat, climbed into an SUV that Irvi had bought on Facebook Marketplace and then crammed with their belongings.

The three-day drive was smooth until they arrived at a gas station in South Texas that was swarming with Border Patrol agents. Irvi started panicking, and his face went gray. They stopped briefly at a family friend's house, where they had planned to stay the night, but Irvi's nervous system was telling him to get out of the country *now*. By Inauguration Day, he was in his hometown of San Lorenzo Cacaotepec. His parents had spent 20 years scraping together money to rebuild their house out of concrete and add a second structure—which meant there was now room for Irvi, his sister, and their families.

Irvi rose in the dark each morning and drove along a rocky dirt road to a small plot of land that his mother had inherited. There were no blaring car horns or subway trains roaring underground. Just birdsong and rustling leaves. Irvi was enchanted and unnerved by Oaxaca's clear blue skies, unmarred by skyscrapers. He spent hours hunched over outside each day, digging in his family's land, pruning and picking, and breaking a sweat as soon as the sun came up. Along with relatives, he planted tomatoes, peppers, and onions, and sold them at outdoor markets. He barely broke even. His father had been right—in Mexico, you work more for less—and Irvi was struggling to adapt. He had been able to get anywhere in New York City without a map, but in Oaxaca he felt lost. "I have to start over again," he told me. "It's like I wasted all that time in New York now that I'm here. Everything I learned doesn't apply."



Irvi harvests peppers in Oaxaca in November 2025. (Natalie Keyssar for *The Atlantic*)

He could not stand to watch the videos, flooding his phone, of armed ICE agents smashing car windows and wrestling fathers to the ground while their crying children watched from the back seat. The plan that he and Rachel had formulated all those years ago—for him to connect the girls with their grandparents before ICE could detain him—would never have worked. He would have been overpowered and dragged away. He hadn't been in control then, he realized, and didn't feel in control now.

It didn't help that his relatives worried that Rachel and the girls might never join him. They couldn't believe that U.S. citizens would trade the privileges of their home country just to be with Irvi. A cousin told him: "You're going to have to find a new wife."

Rachel never thought of abandoning Irvi—not since the rowboat in Central Park. But she often felt guilty that he had to bear the psychological burden of their relationship. Now she thought it was her turn to sacrifice to keep the family together.

Without Irvi to pick the girls up from school with homemade sandwiches, Sara and Ana learned to ride the subway, texting him regular updates in the family's group chat. As their friends studied for entrance exams to the city's competitive middle and high schools, Sara refused to talk about her feelings and retreated into her phone. Ana's nightmares returned. She was valedictorian of her fifth-grade homeroom class and teared up during her speech when she mentioned Irvi, who was watching over FaceTime.

Once school let out for the summer—and as ICE agents stormed immigration courthouses downtown—Rachel and the girls took apart their New York lives. The postcards and pictures came down, revealing the cracked walls underneath. Rachel became engrossed in Facebook videos of other moms who were documenting their families' self-deportation process and describing their relief to be out of the United States.

Sara had a final sleepover with friends. Two of them took her phone into a closet to record a message for her to listen to in Mexico. "You're an amazing friend," they said. "We're gonna miss you so much."

Rachel bought a trailer for the last of their belongings. Her co-workers threw her a surprise party. The goodbyes "were more like *See you later*," Rachel said. "They're not the same goodbyes as Irvi's." Her assistant principal told me that replacing a teacher of her skill level would take years.

Rachel found a private school in Oaxaca for the girls and secured a job for herself, at an annual salary of \$10,700—not nearly enough to live on, even in rural Mexico, and a pittance compared with her \$120,000 salary in New York. They had accepted an offer on their house in the spring, but the deal still hadn't closed by July. Rachel couldn't afford the bills without Irvi's income, and her debts were mounting. She told the girls they were leaving August 1, with or without the house money.

Rachel's father still couldn't believe it had come to this. "I'm heartbroken because I believe in this country in an almost religious way," Doug told me. But as a country, he said, "we fucked up."



Rachel, Ana, and Pinto the dog take a break from packing in July 2025.
(Natalie Keyssar for *The Atlantic*)

Rachel and the girls—plus Coleslaw the cat and Pinto the dog—had planned to stop at tourist attractions to say goodbye to the United States. But Rachel was so frustrated and anxious by the time they left that they stopped only to sleep. She sped to the border, her adrenaline pumping.

Irvi flew to northern Mexico to finish the two-day drive with them. Rachel spent the first night at his parents' house wide awake and in tears. She told Irvi she felt like she couldn't breathe. They reminded themselves that if Oaxaca didn't work out, they could try Mexico City. Or they could apply for visas to move to Spain or Canada.

As Doug had told them, "The whole world is open to you now, except for your home country."

Ana, now 11, put up a few Broadway posters in her new bedroom. Sara, now 13, hung birthday cards from friends in New York. They stuck their favorite *New Yorker* covers on the walls.

When I arrived to visit them in early November, three months into their reunion, Irvi was still going to the farm before sunrise, and Rachel and the girls would leave home at 6 a.m. for the bumpy ride to school, which involved driving through a creek to reach a paved road. Ana said the hardest part about the move was leaving her New York friends, because it had taken her many years to make them. She made one friend at her new school whose family had moved from Canada that year; they sat together at lunch, talking about what it was like to start over somewhere new. Meanwhile, Sara sauntered across campus in a swarm of girls, who delighted in practicing their English skills on her. Though the school was technically bilingual, their teachers mostly spoke Spanish. In class, both girls' eyes glazed over. They looked lost.

Sara and Ana did their best to hide their discomfort in front of Irvi. "I try to say to myself that I'm not the only one and I should be calm about this," Ana told me, "because people have done it before and I'm pretty sure they've turned out fine." Plus, she said, "I will have a great college essay."

But sometimes their anguish spilled out. They were used to excelling in school, and now they felt like they weren't learning anything. One night, when Sara was struggling with homework, she lashed out at her parents, yelling exactly what Irvi had been afraid to hear: "I didn't choose to move here!" She ran up to her room. Irvi stayed on the living-room couch. They cried, separately.

Outside those emotional swells, the family was relieved to be together, and free of the dread that had hung over them in New York. They relished the meals that Irvi's mother, Lulu, prepared for them: rich and tangy beef, chicken-and-vegetable stew, fluffy corn cakes piled with salsa and beans. With all of their children and grandchildren at home, she and Martín now felt that they could live out their lives in peace.

Sara and Ana told me they felt safer in Mexico. Rachel agreed, but worried about the friends and family they'd left behind. She thought they were too close to see what the United States was becoming.

Rachel taught English at her new school, mostly through songs. She had free time for the first time in her adult life, but felt bored. When their house in the Bronx finally sold, she bought a few luxuries to make their new home more comfortable: a refrigerator, an oven, and a washing machine, so they wouldn't have to scrub their clothes on the concrete washboard Irvi's mom used. They paid off their debts, and had surprisingly little money left over, even with Rachel tutoring children of wealthy Mexican families on weekends and after school.

They felt lucky to have had the freedom to immigrate to Mexico; no relatives in the United States relied on their care, and the sale of the Bronx townhouse funded the move. But it was still unclear how they would support themselves now that they were here. Rachel tried to be patient as Irvi figured out a plan. He had worked for so many years in the United States without a break, and he was clearly depressed. He knew he had to sell his motorcycle. He spent all day on the farm streaming Hot 97, an English-language radio station in New York. At night, he would scroll the social-media feed of the nightclub where he'd worked, telling Rachel which artists had performed and who had gotten into fights, until she snapped. "I don't care," she said, pleading with him to leave New York in the past.

They tried to distract themselves with excursions on the weekends, but every time they got in the car, Irvi would either go quiet or unravel, then beat himself up for days. Rachel was frustrated that he couldn't let them have a good time, until she realized that the only travel Irvi had ever done had been unpredictable and dangerous. He didn't know how to enjoy a trip with his family, because he'd never had the chance.

"I'm trying to be positive," Irvi told me, but he felt like a disappointment. He began to pull away from the girls. He seemed to miss the United States more as time went on, not less. In Oaxaca, another American family invited them over to celebrate their first Thanksgiving in Mexico. He took one bite of stuffing and burst into tears. But that same month, he saw on Instagram that ICE had raided his bodega hangout in the Bronx. One of his friends—a father who worked as a bike messenger for a Chinese restaurant—was taken away.

Irvi tried to reconnect with his relatives by attending birthday and anniversary parties. ("Half the town are his cousins," Rachel told me.) He took me along to one party, in a small house with a concrete floor. Plastic tables, with bowls of taco fixings, were set up in a long row that stretched from the kitchen into the living room.

I sat with two of Irvi's aunts, Chela Santiago and Blanca Méndez, who are in their late 60s and have spent their whole lives in San Lorenzo Cacaotepec. Their fathers traveled back and forth to the United States, first as Braceros, then as unauthorized farmhands. Since then, dozens of relatives have followed. Chela's brother went to New York in the 1990s and slept 10 to a room.

"What they say about the United States isn't true," he said when he returned. "They treat you like animals."

Without poor Mexicans, Blanca told me, the U.S. would not exist. "I would like for all the Mexicans in the United States to come here," she said, "and then let's see what the United States really is."

Though Irvi was only a few seats away, she offered another blunt assessment of those who choose to leave home: "Sometimes they go because they want

a life that isn't theirs. Here, we live authentically.”

Irvi was quiet. The United States was where he'd become a man, a husband, a father, a homeowner, a model citizen in every respect except the one that mattered to the U.S. government. Now he had done what his aunt wanted—what President Trump wanted—and he was beginning to live with that choice. Surrounded by family, he looked like a man without a home.



Irvi's father, Martín, places his hands on his son's shoulders at a family gathering in San Lorenzo Cacaotepec in November 2025. (Natalie Keyssar for *The Atlantic*)

People who migrate across borders leave pieces of themselves behind—pieces that don't fit neatly back into place, even upon return. Irvi had known this since he was 19. A year after the family decided to leave the U.S., Rachel and the girls were discovering it, too. They went to New York to visit Rachel's parents this past Christmas; right away, Sara bought frosted strawberry Pop-Tarts to bring back to her classmates in Oaxaca. She giggled on the phone at night with her new Mexican boyfriend. But Rachel had to pry her and Ana away from playdates with their New York friends. She

changed the subject when they asked about visiting again for spring break in a few months.

They ate traditional Chinese food in one friend's home, Russian in another, Dominican in another—the kind of New York experience that they were all realizing they missed. During one visit in Harlem, Rachel asked to speak with me alone, at a coffee shop nearby. When we sat together, she finally broke down. She felt guilty every time she heard her daughters say they were happy to be “home” for the holidays. She saw them falling behind their New York friends academically, so she bought an algebra book to teach them herself. Her old fear of ICE was coursing through her body, even though Irvi was safe in Mexico. And she had been stifling these emotions around her parents all week, because none of them wanted to be the first to cry.

“We tried so hard to make it work,” she told me. “I can’t think of anything else we could have done. And that’s the hardest thing about being here. We’re nice people. My kids are amazing. New York City would have been so lucky to have my kids.”

She told me that a few days earlier, she had gone to visit an uncle in her old neighborhood in the Bronx, but avoided driving past the bright-blue house. Cookie, their neighbor, had reported that another family moved in but left within weeks. The house was dark and empty. The gardens were a mess. An old couch was outside, rotting.

The Cruzes had poured themselves into that house. Now it looked like they had never lived there. Rachel couldn’t bear to see it.

This article appears in the [April 2026](#) print edition with the headline “Leaving the United States Behind.”

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The Pete Hegseth Exception

Nearly a year after a national-security scandal erupted on my iPhone, no one in the Trump administration has faced consequences.

by Jeffrey Goldberg



The Uniform Code of Military Justice serves as the criminal-justice framework for America's armed forces. It covers offenses recognized by civilian law as well as crimes and infractions unique to the military, from

insubordination to cowardly conduct. The code contains 158 articles; the *Manual for Courts-Martial* itself runs nearly 1,000 pages. It is an obvious truth that discipline, morale, and order can be maintained in military formations only if everyone—from four-star generals to the youngest “boot” privates—is held equally accountable for their actions.

A cursory review of recent courts-martial suggests that the enforcers of military discipline don't miss much. In December, a Marine private first class was convicted of “contempt or disrespect towards a noncommissioned or petty officer, and disrespect towards a superior commissioned officer in command.” The private was held in confinement for five days and was reduced in rank. In September, an Air Force lieutenant was convicted of engaging in conduct “unbecoming an officer” after drinking on duty and cursing superior officers. He was sentenced to 30 days of confinement and received a presumably career-ending reprimand. In November, a senior airman, a medical specialist, was found guilty of failing to “safeguard protected health information from unauthorized disclosure.” She was sentenced to one month of confinement, and received a temporary pay reduction and a reprimand. Also in September, an Army specialist was convicted of disrespecting a superior by “interrupting her when she was speaking and then walking away,” among other charges. A military judge reduced the specialist's rank and prevented her from leaving her military facility for 14 days.

Many soldiers are punished for infractions related to the handling of their weapons—the unfortunate Louisiana National Guardsman who [recently left his rifle in the bathroom of a hotel bar could face a court-martial](#). And members of the armed forces are also punished for mishandling information. The military is necessarily unforgiving of those who violate operational security—“loose lips sink ships,” in the age-old shorthand. That is why seemingly quotidian bits of information—the dates and times that units are moving from one base to another, for instance—are held so closely. According to the UCMJ's Article 92, the punishments for the release of unauthorized information vary, but could include two years' imprisonment. A unit commander, operations-security guidance states, must “protect from unauthorized disclosure any sensitive and/or critical information to which they have personal access.” In October of last year, a retired Army colonel, Kevin Charles Luke, who was at the time a civilian Department of Defense

employee, was [found guilty of sending a photo of a classified email to a woman he'd met online](#). The email contained information about an upcoming military operation. In early February, Luke was sentenced to two years in prison for his crime.

[Read: The Trump administration accidentally texted me its war plans](#)

It has been almost a year since the national-security scandal that came to be known, inevitably, as Signalgate erupted on my iPhone, and I've been thinking through its consequences. Michael Waltz, the official who invited me into a Signal chat group whose members included most of America's national-security leadership, was removed as the president's national security adviser. But he soon received (what is to my mind, at least) a promotion, and is now serving as U.S. ambassador to the United Nations. The Signal Foundation, the nonprofit organization that owns the messaging app, saw a dramatic increase in usage following the scandal. *The Atlantic* itself saw an unparalleled burst of subscription growth, and I personally managed to avoid prison *and* extract a brand-new iPhone from my employer. President Trump suffered no negative consequences from Signalgate. In fact, he found it professionally riveting, carefully studying the way in which *The Atlantic* temporarily dominated the news cycle. (He also [suggested to me](#), in an Oval Office meeting that took place as the scandal was subsiding, that he should receive more credit for *The Atlantic*'s success than I have granted him.)

As for Pete Hegseth, the secretary of defense who shared what were quite obviously military secrets in a discussion, held on a privately run messaging app, that he didn't even know included a journalist—well, more on him later.

Allow me to recount, as efficiently as possible, the sequence of implausible events here. On March 11 of last year, I was [invited to connect on Signal](#) by a user purporting to be Waltz. Soon after, I was invited to a chat called the "Houthi PC small group." *PC* refers to *principals committee*, which included people identified as Vice President J. D. Vance, Secretary of State Marco Rubio, Hegseth, CIA Director John Ratcliffe, and Tulsi Gabbard, the director of national intelligence.

I am suspicious by profession, and so I assumed that this was an entrapment scheme, or a foreign-intelligence-service operation, or a simulation beyond easy comprehension. But I know Waltz (please keep this fact in mind), and I have reported on national-security matters for decades, so the invitation wasn't entirely outlandish. (A reasonable guess is that my telephone number can be found—or could be found, before Signalgate—in the contact lists of seven or eight members of the 18-person “small group.”)

The chat itself was highly realistic, and fascinating. I watched as a substantive debate was held over whether the U.S. should immediately launch strikes against Houthi-terrorist targets in Yemen. The vice president, quasi-isolationist in outlook, argued against such strikes, noting that Europe—not his favorite continent—would benefit disproportionately. A little while later, the chat participant identified as Hegseth wrote, “Waiting a few weeks or a month does not fundamentally change the calculus,” though he added, “We are prepared to execute, and if I had final go or no go vote, I believe we should.”

The colloquy came to a sudden end when the user “S M,” whom I took to be the Trump confidant Stephen Miller, wrote, “As I heard it, the president was clear: green light, but we soon make clear to Egypt and Europe what we expect in return.”

That was that. Hegseth wrote, “Agree,” and the dissident vice president said nothing. And then came the day of the Yemen strikes. At 11:44 a.m. on Saturday, March 15, I was at a supermarket—a Safeway in the Chevy Chase neighborhood of Washington, D.C.—when the following alert came in over Signal from Hegseth: “TEAM UPDATE.” What followed was information that, had it been seen by an enemy of the United States, could have been used to kill American military and intelligence personnel. Hegseth promised that Yemen would be attacked within two hours.

I've seen strange things in my career, but nothing quite like this. I stayed in my car in the Safeway parking lot and waited. I took screenshots of the chat and searched X and other platforms for news of U.S. military activity. Hegseth had said in the chat that the first detonations would be felt at 1:45 p.m. eastern time. At approximately 1:55 p.m., credible news reports started appearing about an attack.

In the chat, congratulations began to pour in. Waltz posted three emoji: a fist, an American flag, and fire. Steve Witkoff, Trump's all-purpose, in-over-his-head global-conflict negotiator, responded with five emoji: two praying hands, a flexed bicep, and two American flags. Later, the Houthi-run Yemeni health ministry reported that at least 53 people had been killed in the attack (the number has not been confirmed independently). The Houthis are despicable terrorists, and in my opinion should be fought and defeated, but there was still something disturbing about the proliferation of emoji.



Proof that the chat was authentic forced me (and a growing number of advisers, sworn to secrecy) to make a choice. I was interested in exposing a security breach at the highest reaches of government; I was less interested in being accused of violating the Espionage Act. I would thus exit the chat later that same day. The Signal group would be alerted that I had left, so timing was important. That evening was the annual dinner of the [Gridiron Club](#), at which Washington journalists host senior administration officials and members of Congress and make mainly mild fun of them from the stage. I heard that Waltz might be attending. I didn't want the FBI raiding the dinner to seize my phone, so I waited until the end of the dinner to leave the chat. I spent the next hours awaiting recognition by the federal government that I was an apostate member of the "Houthi PC small group."

But, nothing.

As a reporter, I was relieved; as a citizen, I was appalled by the violation of the first commandment of digital hygiene: Thou Shalt Know Who Is in Thy Group Chat.

The next week rushed by as we prepared the story for publication. I decided not to include some of the key operational details shared by Hegseth, Waltz, and Ratcliffe, the CIA director. I wanted to expose their incompetence without releasing information that could hurt American troops. Early on Monday, March 24, I wrote to Waltz and Hegseth on Signal (of course) and then others by email, asking for confirmation and comment. I would learn that my requests set off a scramble in the White House. The National Security Council called an emergency meeting in the Situation Room, where the mood, as participants later described it to me, was one of incredulousness and anger. According to people who participated in the meeting, Alex Wong, who was then the principal deputy national security adviser, briefed officials, but he didn't have much information. The White House counsel, David Warrington, asked, slowly and repeatedly, "How. Did. This. Happen?"

To their credit, White House officials quickly responded to me and confirmed the authenticity of the chat, and we published our story. These officials publicly argued that nothing secret or sensitive had been disclosed in the chat, which was nonsense, though their argument was helped by my decision to keep actual operational details out of the story. It was my word against theirs.

There were two main worries in the White House that morning. The first: Who would tell the president? It is my understanding that Susie Wiles, the White House chief of staff, instructed Waltz to tell Trump. (Wiles, we would later learn, disliked Waltz, who treated her poorly.) The second worry was that Hegseth, who was then flying to Hawaii aboard the Pentagon's "Doomsday" plane, would be unable to muster a mature reaction to the story. Over the course of the day, officials spoke with him and texted him repeatedly while he was in the air, pleading with him to respond to questions by saying only that no classified information had been disclosed.

Temperament is destiny, and Hegseth [responded frantically and defensively](#). “You’re talking about a deceitful and highly discredited so-called journalist who’s made a profession of peddling hoaxes time and time again,” he told reporters when he landed. He was referring to my reporting, in 2020 and in 2024, that Trump had made various contemptible comments about American troops, including that [soldiers who fell in war](#) were “suckers” and “losers,” and that Trump had also said, “[I need the kind of generals that Hitler had](#).” (Multiple sources confirmed that Trump had made these comments, including [John Kelly](#), a former White House chief of staff and a retired Marine general.)



Former National Security Adviser Michael Waltz stands next to Jeffrey Goldberg at the French embassy in Washington, D.C., in 2021. (X / Bernard-Henri Lévy)

Waltz also responded in a juvenile manner, telling Fox News the next day that I am “the bottom scum of journalists. And I know him in the sense that he hates the president, but I don’t text him. He wasn’t on my phone, and we’re going to figure out how this happened.” Waltz went on to say, “Of course I didn’t see this loser in the group.” (I believe this is what is known

as “projection.”) And he made a comment that provided material for a week’s worth of late-night comedy. In explaining how I may have been added to the chat, [he said](#), “Well, if you have somebody else’s contact, then somehow it ... gets sucked in. It gets sucked in.” (I recently learned that Wiles ordered Waltz to turn his phone over to Elon Musk—at the time a kind of one-man Genius Bar for White House officials—who reported back to Wiles that my phone number did not get “sucked in” to Waltz’s phone.) Waltz also denied ever having met me, which is not true.

The ad hominem campaign by Waltz, Hegseth, Gabbard, the CIA, and White House Press Secretary Karoline Leavitt, combined with the assertion that no classified information had been included in the chat, presented me with a dilemma. I knew, of course, that the information I’d seen on my phone would ordinarily be judged top secret by the military, and I knew that the White House lies were meant to undercut the credibility of this magazine. I simply could not understand why the administration was goading me into releasing the full message chain, which would show that I was correct in stating that the information was highly secret.

We devised a plan: My colleague Shane Harris, who covers the intelligence community, and I would speak with leaders of the relevant government agencies and ask them if they objected to the publication of the rest of the messages. This written statement, from Leavitt, illustrates the sophistication of the administration’s response: “As we have repeatedly stated, there was no classified information transmitted in the group chat,” she wrote. “However, as the CIA Director and National Security Advisor have both expressed today, that does not mean we encourage the release of the conversation. This was intended to be a an [*sic*] internal and private deliberation amongst high-level senior staff and sensitive information was discussed. So for those reason [*sic*]—yes, we object to the release.”

[Read: Here are the attack plans that Trump’s advisers shared on Signal](#)

We published a [follow-up story](#) and included the operational messages from Hegseth and Waltz. Here is the key text from Hegseth: “TIME NOW (1144et): Weather is FAVORABLE. Just CONFIRMED w/CENTCOM we are a GO for mission launch.” Centcom, or Central Command, is the military’s combatant command for the Middle East. He continued:

“1215et: F-18s LAUNCH (1st strike package)”

“1345: ‘Trigger Based’ F-18 1st Strike Window Starts (Target Terrorist is @ his Known Location so SHOULD BE ON TIME)—also, Strike Drones Launch (MQ-9s)”

“1410: More F-18s LAUNCH (2nd strike package)”

“1415: Strike Drones on Target (THIS IS WHEN THE FIRST BOMBS WILL DEFINITELY DROP, pending earlier ‘Trigger Based’ targets)”

“1536: F-18 2nd Strike Starts—also, first sea-based Tomahawks launched.”

“MORE TO FOLLOW (per timeline)”

“We are currently clean on OPSEC.”

“Godspeed to our Warriors.”

It would have been more accurate to have written, “We are currently clean on OPSEC, except that I’m sending this information to the editor of *The Atlantic*.” To honestly believe that this information was not secret would require Hegseth to achieve Olympian levels of self-deception.

As all of this was happening, I was receiving messages from various military officials expressing disdain and anger that Hegseth refused to take responsibility. None of them went public with their outrage, however.

Other people did, including a modest number of Republicans. Senator Roger Wicker, the chair of the Senate Armed Services Committee, told reporters, “The information as published recently appears to me to be of such a sensitive nature that, based on my knowledge, I would have wanted it classified.” Wicker and his Democratic counterpart, Senator Jack Reed, asked for a Pentagon investigation. I doubted that this would occur, because the administration was dismantling the inspector-general system across the federal government. But an investigation was soon said to be under way.

Only two administration figures did not seem especially alarmed or defensive during the controversy. The first was the vice president, who, we would later learn, made one final joking addition to the “Houthi PC small group” chain late on the night after my first story appeared: “This chat’s kind of dead,” he wrote. “Anything going on?”



Signalgate became fodder for memes and late-night comedy. The Trump administration had violated the first commandment of digital hygiene: Thou Shalt Know Who Is in Thy Group Chat. (Bluesky / @kampfmitkette.bsky.social)

The other was the president himself.

I was worried that the Signal story would complicate already complicated efforts by my colleagues Ashley Parker and Michael Scherer to get an [interview with Trump](#). But instead—and this was somewhat predictable to those of us who have paid close attention to Trump over the years—he not only granted them an interview, but invited me to participate. He could not resist the temptation to troll us along the way, however. Three hours before our scheduled visit to the Oval Office, he posted the following message on Truth Social:

Later today I will be meeting with, of all people, Jeffrey Goldberg, the Editor of The Atlantic, and the person responsible for many fictional stories about me, including the made-up HOAX on “Suckers and Losers” and, SignalGate, something he was somewhat more “successful” with. Jeffrey is bringing with him Michael Scherer and Ashley Parker, not exactly pro-Trump writers, either, to put it mildly! The story they are writing, they have told my representatives, will be entitled, “The Most Consequential President of this Century.” I am doing this interview out of curiosity, and as a competition with myself, just to see if it’s possible for The Atlantic to be “truthful.” Are they capable of writing a fair story on “TRUMP”? The way I look at it, what can be so bad—I WON!

When we entered the Oval Office, Trump said, “This will be very, very interesting. You think Biden would do this? I don’t think so.”

(He was correct.)

“Thanks for announcing the interview on Truth Social,” I said.

“I wanted to put a little extra pressure on you,” he said. “But at the same time, you’ll sell about five times more magazines.”

I asked him, in the course of the interview, what he meant by “I will be meeting with, of all people, Jeffrey Goldberg.”

“Oh, you like that? I had to do that,” he said. “I had to explain to people. That’s my way of explaining to people that you’re up here, because most people would say, ‘Why are you doing that?’ I’m doing that because there is a certain respect.”

“Are you saying that Signalgate was real?” I asked.

“Yeah, it was real. And I was gonna put in something else, but I didn’t have enough time.” This led me to ask, out of sheer curiosity, “How long does it take you to write these?”

“Not long,” he answered. “I go quickly as hell. You’d be amazed. You’d be impressed. And I like doing them myself. Sometimes I dictate them out, but

I like doing them myself. What I'm saying is that it became a big story. You were successful, and it became a big story."

Me: "But you're not saying that it was successful in the sense that it exposed an operations-security problem that you have to fix?"

Trump: "No. What I'm saying is, it was successful in that you got it out very much to the public. You were able to get something out. It became a very big story."

I then asked him directly if there were any other possible lessons to be learned from the Signal breach.

The president answered, "I think we learned: Maybe don't use Signal, okay?"

[From the June 2025 issue: Ashley Parker and Michael Scherer on Donald Trump's return to the White House](#)

Months went by. We heard, again and again, that the Defense Department's inspector general would investigate, but nothing came of it. Finally, in December, the report was released. It found what had seemed obvious from the outset: that Hegseth's use of Signal to discuss bombing Yemen could have exposed U.S. tactics and endangered troops.

"The Secretary sent information identifying the quantity and strike times of manned U.S. aircraft over hostile territory over an unapproved, unsecure network approximately 2 to 4 hours before the execution of those strikes," the report reads. "If this information had fallen into the hands of U.S. adversaries, Houthi forces might have been able to counter U.S. forces or reposition personnel and assets to avoid planned U.S. strikes. Even though these events did not ultimately occur, the Secretary's actions [created a risk to operational security](#) that could have resulted in failed U.S. mission objectives and potential harm to U.S. pilots."



Rubble in Saada, Yemen, after a U.S. air strike. According to the Houthi-run Yemeni health ministry, the attacks discussed in the “Houthi PC small group” are believed to have left at least 53 people dead. (Naif Rahma / Reuters)

The report concluded, however, that because the secretary of defense possesses “original classification authority”—meaning he has the power to declassify secrets at will—he wasn’t technically in violation of any rules governing secrecy, only rules banning the use of private messaging apps for official Pentagon business.

Hegseth claimed that the report cleared him of all wrongdoing. “No classified information,” he posted on social media. “Total exoneration. Case closed. Houthis bombed into submission. Thank you for your attention to this IG report.”

He had not always been so forgiving when it came to matters of operational security. In 2016, at the height of the furor concerning Hillary Clinton’s email server, Hegseth, then a Fox News host, said, “How damaging is it to your ability to recruit or build allies with others when they are worried that

our leaders may be exposing them because of their gross negligence or their recklessness in handling information?”

The U.S. is now engaged in another bombing campaign, larger and more sustained than the strikes on the Houthis. Every day, hundreds of aviators are ordered into the airspace above Iran. Their lives depend on the operational security that the military’s culture of accountability is designed to safeguard.

The Department of Defense employs nearly 3 million people, uniformed and civilian. All are subject to rules and regulations governing many aspects of their behavior. Any one of them would have faced serious consequences for announcing, on an insecure messaging app, that the U.S. was about to send its pilots over enemy territory.

All except one.

**Lead-image sources: Mandel Ngan / AFP / Getty; Tom Williams / CQ Roll Call / Getty; Andrew Harnik / AFP / Getty.*

This article appears in the [April 2026](#) print edition with the headline “The Unbearable Lightness of Signalgate.”

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The Forgotten Female Pilots of World War II

The WASPs risked their lives flying for the Army. But for decades, the U.S. government refused to recognize their military service.

by Ellen Cushing



The author's grandmother Patricia Perry joined the Women Airforce Service Pilots in 1943. (Courtesy of the Robinson/Cushing Family)

Recently, I stood in an airfield in Sweetwater, Texas, and looked up. I was wondering what it would have been like to take off from there in a small plane, flying into the dust of West Texas and the chaos of World War II, as my grandmother had. The land around me had the palette of a well-used watercolor set and the topography of a paper towel: gray and brown, flat forever. It is dry all year round, except when it suddenly pours. The wide, featureless landscape makes for big, blustery winds and difficult orientation. Also, [it is famous for its rattlesnakes](#).

During World War II, Sweetwater's Avenger Field was the primary home of a program that trained women to fly military planes. They were called [Women Airforce Service Pilots](#)—WASPs—and they were the solution to a high-stakes problem: The war needed pilots, and men were dying quickly. From 1942 to 1944, [these women volunteers](#) engaged in just about every aspect of military flight operations except combat—ferrying aircraft, testing planes, transporting cargo, training new pilots—so that the men would be free to fight in Europe and the Pacific. More than 25,000 women applied to the program, fewer than 2,000 were accepted, and 1,074 completed training.

By the time the program ended, the WASPs had risked—and in some cases given—their lives to save male pilots a cumulative 60 million miles of flying. But during the war, they were classified as civil servants, no different in the eyes of the government from the female federal employees who typed memos or cooked on bases. After the war, they were ineligible for veterans' benefits, and kept out of both the military and commercial cockpits. For decades, the WASPs lobbied to be recognized as service members. Today, they are still largely unknown. Soon, they will all be gone.

Patricia Perry, my Grandma Pat, was born in 1921, an only child. She grew up in Auburn, a small town in Northern California's Sierra foothills. This was farm country—stone fruit and grapes—and when she was in high school, Pat learned to fly a friend's parents' crop duster. She was high-achieving, sheltered, patriotic, and eager to please—always, according to my mom, “trying to be the son her father never had as well as the daughter her mother insisted on.” In 1941, she moved two hours southwest to study political science at UC Berkeley. Instead of joining a sorority, she lived in the International House, where she was surrounded by students from all over the world, including many who had fled the war in Europe.

After graduation, she'd planned to attend law school at Berkeley, where she would have been one of just a few women, but deferred her admission to join the WASPs. She met the criteria: 5 foot 4 or taller, at least 21 years of age, high-school diploma, extensive flying experience. On July 5, 1943, [when Pat was 21](#), she began her training in Sweetwater. She had never left California before.

With a few exceptions, the women at Avenger Field were white, but they came from a variety of backgrounds and professions—one was a Broadway actor—and from all over the country. Some were still essentially children; others were in their 30s, married with a family, or widowed by a husband who had already been killed in the war. The wealthier among them had learned to fly for fun when aviation became an expensive diversion in the years between the world wars. Hundreds had gone through the Civilian Pilot Training Program, which had been founded a few years earlier to train men to fly and occasionally accepted women. Pat, like many of her fellow WASPs, had felt called to service. A large number just really loved to fly, and looked for any opportunity to do it.



Members of the Women Airforce Service Pilots program, wearing flight gear and parachutes (WASP Archive / Texas Woman's University)

Before she joined the program, [Marion Schorr Brown](#) was making \$90 a month as a schoolteacher and spending \$6 an hour for flight time. [Nell Stevenson Bright](#) took her first recreational flight at the age of 8, when her father paid a dollar for her to ride in a World War I biplane, and never stopped thinking about being in the air after that. [Cornelia Fort](#) was an airplane fanatic and a flight instructor who happened to have been flying with a student over Pearl Harbor on December 7, 1941, when she was 22. She saw the bombs exploding in the sky, and then she emergency-landed her plane as Japanese military aircraft rained bullets down on the tarmac. Ten months later, she became the second woman to sign up for what would become the WASP program.

The women paid their own way to Texas. They were told to pack light, and to buy life insurance. Once they got there, they were given men's flight suits; [in photographs](#), they look like children playing dress-up, heavy fabric pooled at their feet. They covered lodging costs themselves, \$1.65 a day. The windows on their barracks were painted black, for modesty. They trained for four to seven months, learning physics, Morse code, and military law, and accumulating hundreds of flight hours: everything male pilots learned, except gunnery and formation flying. (They also learned how to examine their cockpits for rattlesnakes.) Every morning, they [did calisthenics in bobby socks](#) as military planes flew loud and low overhead. In the evenings, they wrote letters home, played Ping-Pong in the rec hall, and produced a newspaper, *The Avenger*.

In Sweetwater, locals received them with some suspicion, at least until program leaders encouraged them all to go to church, even the Jewish ones. In the country at large, to the extent that the public was aware of the WASPs, the general attitude seems to have been one of amused gratitude. A [cover story about the program in Life magazine](#)—headline: “[Girl Pilots](#)”—called the women “very serious about their chance to fly for the Army at Avenger Field, even when it means giving up nail polish, beauty parlors, and dates for a regimented 22 ½ weeks.”



WASPs doing calisthenics at Avenger Field, in Sweetwater, Texas. Locals received the trainees with some suspicion, at least until program leaders encouraged them to go to church. (WASP Archive / Texas Woman's University)

After training, the women received a pair of silver wings and a few days off. Then they scattered to their next assignment: Schorr Brown to Detroit, Stevenson Bright to El Paso, Fort and Pat to different parts of Southern California, the rest to airfields and Army bases around the country. There, they taught male cadets how to fly; moved supplies between factories and bases; flew paperwork, planes, and pilots wherever they needed to go; and generally engaged in what the pilot Jacqueline Cochran, one of the program's founders, was fond of calling "aerial dishwashing"—the tedious stuff, work no one else wanted.

[Read: Night Witches, the Soviet female fighter pilots of World War II](#)

Each WASP was typically one of only a handful of women among hundreds or thousands of men on base, and the historical record suggests that they were treated, at best, like zoo animals. An unspoken but widely understood

part of the job description, Pat recalled, was to entertain their male counterparts: She packed a ball gown in her luggage along with her flight suit. The women were skipped over for certain flying assignments, evaluated more harshly than the men, and [reportedly told by one base commander](#) that both they and the planes could easily be replaced. For a while, many were grounded during their period. Rumors of sabotage by male pilots spread. Cochran was said—but never confirmed—to have found traces of sugar in the engine of a plane that had crashed and killed a WASP.

Even under the best conditions, the flying itself was difficult and dangerous. The planes were tiny, many of the cockpits completely open to the air. (In Sweetwater, I saw four of them, dinky little tin-can-looking things, and I thought about how I require a glass of wine and a Xanax to get on a 737.) They had rudimentary instruments and no radar or GPS—often, the women would navigate by sticking their head out the window. Schorr Brown once accidentally got so close to the Statue of Liberty while flying from Montreal to Newark that it “scared the living daylights out of her.” Not at all infrequently, a WASP’s assignment was to test a plane for airworthiness, or to transport a damaged one to be repaired, or to tow a target over a practice area while not-fully-trained men on the ground did their best to shoot at it with machine guns. Women were allowed to opt out of this last duty, but no one did.



WASPs at the Romulus Army Air Base, in Michigan. The women were typically outnumbered on base by hundreds or thousands of men. (WASP Archive / Texas Woman's University)

On March 21, 1943, Cornelia Fort was ferrying a BT-13 from Long Beach to Dallas when one of the recently trained male pilots she was flying with accidentally clipped her wing. She nose-dived so hard that her plane's engine was later found buried two feet underground. Fort was the first woman pilot in American history to be killed while on active duty for her country. The military did not pay for her funeral.

Thirty-seven other WASPs died in service, either during training or on assignment. Each time, their remains were sent home at the expense of their families—the women at Avenger got used to passing around a hat, collecting donations. Their caskets were not permitted to be draped with the American flag, but sometimes their families did it anyway.

Almost the entire time the WASP program existed, its leaders fought for it to be made an official part of the military, with all the attendant benefits.

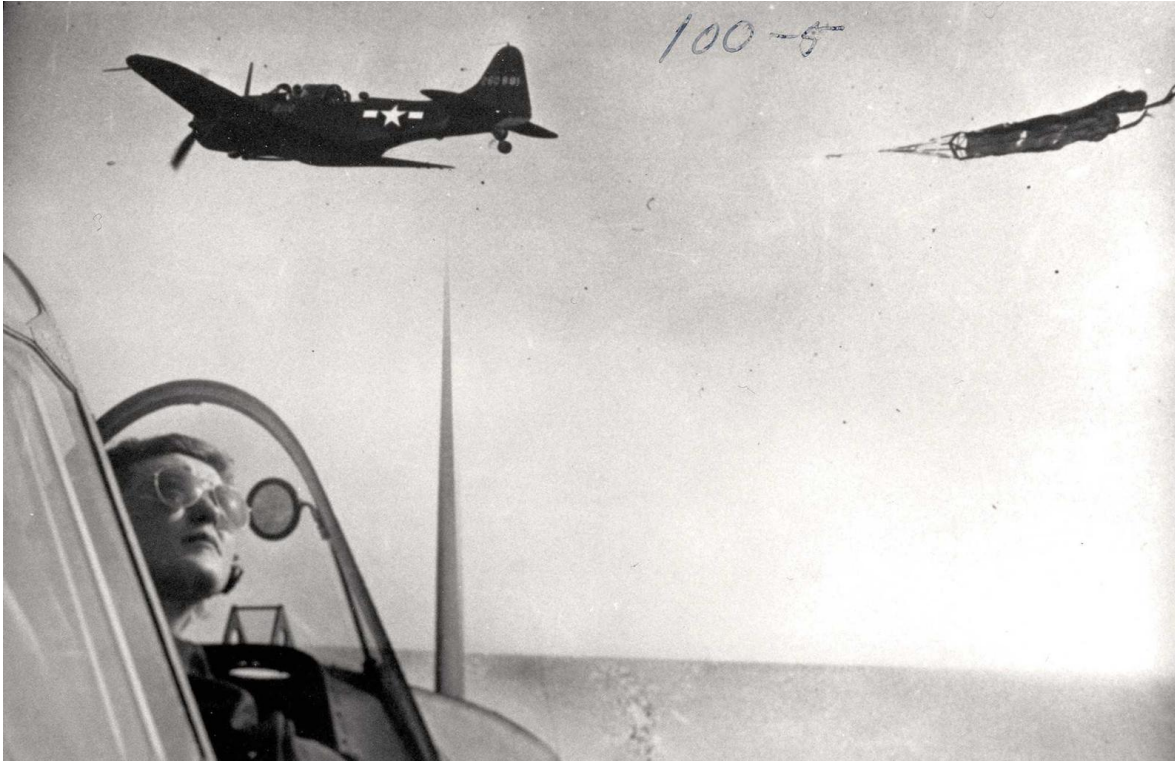
Almost the entire time, they were met with resistance from male pilots. In 1944, as an end to the war appeared to be in sight and the pilot shortage eased, the government ordered the cancellation of a flight-instruction program for men. A group of male teachers began petitioning elected officials and writing to the press: Why should women have these jobs when they couldn't?

[Read: Why women weren't allowed to be astronauts](#)

Soon enough, public sentiment toward the WASPs started to shift. "Women: Unnecessary and Undesirable?" [a headline in Time magazine asked](#). A government report found the program to be expensive and wasteful, especially when so many male pilots were available. A bill that would have provided the WASPs with full military status was narrowly defeated in the House of Representatives. By October, it was all over: The program was to be disbanded by the end of the year.

On December 7, 1944, it graduated its final class. "The WASP have completed their mission," [General Henry Arnold said at the ceremony](#). "If ever there was a doubt in anyone's mind that women can become skillful pilots, the WASP have dispelled that doubt." The pilots he was addressing would never get to put their skills to use. The ones currently on base were sent home.

And so the WASPs scattered back to their lives. They finished school, bred Pekingese dogs, won bowling competitions, sold encyclopedias, had babies, devoted themselves to their families. A number of them applied to be commercial pilots and were rejected, though occasionally an airline would suggest that they were perfectly qualified to become stewardesses.



Even under the best conditions, flying was difficult and dangerous. The planes were tiny, and many of the cockpits were completely open to the air. (WASP Archive / Texas Woman's University)

Marion Schorr Brown married a civilian pilot and settled down in Columbus, Ohio, staying home to raise her children. Nell Stevenson Bright began a career in finance, and eventually became one of the first female stockbrokers in Phoenix. And Pat went back to Northern California, only to find that the law school she'd been admitted to before volunteering had dramatically reduced operations, on account of the fact that there weren't enough men around to fill a class.

She instead enrolled at a different, less prestigious school. After graduation, despite having job offers in Los Angeles, she returned to Auburn at her parents' insistence and married a local war hero—my grandfather. She joined him in working at his family's law firm, which didn't allow Pat to bill clients or appear in court. On the ground as in the sky, it seemed she was expected to use her many talents in order to help the men around her, without being too bothersome or visible about it.

When she had my mom, in 1951, Pat left the firm for good. Twelve years later, she and my grandfather divorced. He quickly remarried, and she moved to Monterey with my mom and my uncle, then 6. She had graduated from an elite college, flown warplanes, and passed the bar, but as a divorcée in 1963, the best job she could find was working the reception desk at a hotel.

By then, the WASP program had been all but erased from public memory. Like so many who had served during the war, the WASPs themselves generally tried their best to move on afterward. Margo Thurman, Nell Stevenson Bright's daughter, told me that she'd been unaware of her mom's service until she was in her 20s. Pat did tell her young children about it, but she didn't say much: She was proud of what she had done, but it was a closemouthed kind of pride. At some point, she threw away her uniform.

Because they'd gone their separate ways after training, and the internet did not exist, and most of the women had changed their name, many of them lost touch. Most WASPs had little to no contact with the only people who had shared in, and could validate, their experience. Records of the program were classified, and the military didn't publicize it after it ended. What, after all, would be the point? "No one even knows about us," [one WASP told her local paper in the 1970s](#). "They say I'm nuts when I mention it."

Starting in the early 1960s, WASPs organized various efforts to gain veteran status. They all failed. Then, in 1976, when the Air Force began accepting female recruits for combat, newspapers, working off military press releases, ran articles about the "[first women pilots to fly military airplanes](#)." By this point, the women's-rights movement had gained momentum, and the nation, having just lost an ethically murky war, was inclined to glorify World War II and its veterans. Many of the WASPs, including Nell Stevenson Bright, began organizing anew, hoping that this time, the conditions were right for them to actually be heard.



Nell Stevenson Bright would go on to become one of the first female stockbrokers in Phoenix, Arizona. (WASP Archive / Texas Woman's University)

Stevenson Bright turned 104 in June. In late fall, she spoke with me over Zoom from her assisted-living facility in Salt Lake City. She wore cherry-red lipstick and a cable-knit sweater; behind her sat a flower arrangement with a small American flag in it. She talked about the fight for recognition the same way she talked about flying an airplane: matter-of-factly, and with little interest in questions about how it felt. While living in Arizona, she had become friendly with Senator Barry Goldwater, she told me, and shortly after she and other WASPs pleaded their case to him, he “got to work” on a bill—simple. In 1977, the women were finally, formally recognized as veterans and made eligible for benefits.

The recognition effort helped many of the remaining WASPs get back in touch with one another. A few had gathered casually for years, but now they began to have larger, more formal reunions. “We’d just sit around and yak,” Stevenson Bright recalled. They began making the rounds at air shows, setting up a booth and trying to talk with as many people as they could—for starters, they wanted everyone to understand that 1976 was not the first time women had flown military planes. They began considering what else they might want to do to make sure they wouldn’t be forgotten.



Stevenson Bright, now 104, befriended Senator Barry Goldwater, who in 1977 sponsored a bill that granted WASPs veteran status and made them eligible for benefits. (Elliot Ross for *The Atlantic*)

In 1992, the [WASPs established an archive at Texas Woman's University](#), in Denton, about 45 minutes north of Dallas. A few years later, one of the women and her daughter began advocating and raising money for a museum. It [opened in 2005 at Avenger Field](#), 62 years to the day after the first WASP class graduated. As of this spring, 18 WASPs have had their ashes scattered there, with one another instead of their husbands, under the big gray sky. In 2009, after an extended lobbying effort, the women were awarded the Congressional Gold Medal for their service. A few years later, the family of a WASP named Elaine Danforth Harmon [fought to bury her](#) at Arlington National Cemetery, [and won](#).

[Read: A woman pilot receives the military funeral the Army denied her](#)

Pat died in 1995, when I was 7. My sense of her is arrested at the second-grade level: All I remember is that she loved golf, had bright-red hair, and gave me age-inappropriate books about the economy for Christmas, because she thought it was important for little girls to understand how money worked.

I wish I could ask her what she thought of it all—the archive, the medal, the long battle for recognition, the question of whether it’s even possible to win a fight you never should have had to wage in the first place. I know that she was interested in justice, on a philosophical and professional level as well as a personal one, but I also know that her feelings about being a WASP were complicated. When Pat’s children asked her about the war, mostly what she told them was how terrifying it was, how cold she was in the cockpit. She did not make enduring friendships in the program. It did not grant her greater opportunities later in life, or a sense that women could accomplish whatever they set out to do. She died angry at the U.S. military, and terrified of snakes. My mom believes that she did not want to think being a WASP was the most exciting thing she had ever done or would do. She also believes, as she told me recently, that Pat’s life was full of disappointments, often because of her gender, and that her experience as a WASP—during, but especially after, the war—“was the first, and the biggest.”

Recently, pop culture has developed an interest in history-makers and hidden figures—in stories about spunky women who clopped around institutions that didn’t respect them in fabulous high heels, doing math or playing chess, glamorously but silently moving humanity forward. Part of the appeal of these narratives is that they flatter the present simply by virtue of its not being the past: You consume them and think, *Thank God we’re not like that anymore*. They are stories about discrimination and hardship that are designed to make their audience feel good, as though progress is always linear and justice is always served.

[Read: Why are there so few cultural portrayals of women in combat?](#)

Many of the women I spoke with for this story have wondered why no one has made a big Hollywood movie about the WASPs. I have a theory. I think it’s because their story does not neatly represent the beginning of anything. A thousand American women were flying planes during the biggest and

deadliest conflict the world had ever seen, and then they were back on Earth, wives and mothers, their contribution forgotten before the war even ended. They did not integrate the military or significantly alter the general public's understanding of what women were capable of—women weren't allowed to fly military planes again for another generation. As of 2024, just 7.3 percent of this country's licensed pilots were women; the [government report I found this figure in](#) is titled "U.S. Civil Airmen Statistics." Meanwhile, Secretary of Defense Pete Hegseth [recently declared](#) that the military must be returned "to the highest male standard only," and ended a 74-year-old committee created to support women in service.

The WASPs hurtled into a hard wall and it didn't break. If their story offers a lesson for the women of my generation or the girls of the next, it's not a particularly uplifting one.

In November, my mom and I paid a visit to Texas Woman's University. Twenty-first-century women crisscrossed campus in tiny shorts or enormous cargo pants, carrying fat textbooks on physics and Eastern philosophy. At an information desk inside the administrative building that houses special collections, a student worker stared at me blankly when I asked about the WASP archive. "Like ... wasp?" she said, moving her finger in the air like an insect.

We got there eventually. The archive shares space with the Texas First Ladies Historic Gown Collection, and one of the world's largest collections of cookbooks—a news crew had recently been there to film a segment on the cookbooks, and the WASP memorabilia had been moved out of the way. We sat on soft chairs and talked with Corynthia Dorgan, the archive's WASP expert.

In the months before I arrived in Texas, the Trump administration had embarked on a large-scale effort to purge government materials of references to women, people of color, and various other marginalized groups. (Two months after my trip, Texas A&M University would [abruptly end its women's- and gender-studies program](#).) Simply acknowledging the existence of certain individuals, facts, and concepts had become a political act. The United States seemed to be in the middle of a mass experiment designed to test just how durable the reality of the past really is.

In some ways, the WASPs and their long, halting fight for status are a perfect example of Americans' perennial willingness to [elide entire histories](#) and people for the sake of convenience or ideology. And they have been subject to this great erasing themselves. Shortly after President Trump started his second term, the [Air Force Times reported that at least a dozen pages related to the WASPs](#) and other female pilots had been removed from Air Force websites.

[Read: What the female veterans in Congress think about women in combat](#)

Recently, Dorgan told me, she and her colleagues had pulled as many PDFs of government webpages about the WASPs as they could, as a precaution. They have also subtly reframed the way they talk about the program publicly, emphasizing its role in Texas history more than women's history. "You do the little things," Dorgan said, in order to protect the truth. You do your best to tell the story you care about in a way that will make people want to listen, in the moment you are telling it.

This is something that the WASPs became good at. They started the archive where Dorgan now works, she told me, because "they knew what they did was unique, and it was hidden, and they thought it shouldn't be." They created a museum because they felt that they should have a museum. It is still there for anyone who wants to visit; on a recent Wednesday, a group of teenagers was being led around on a tour. The WASPs spent their 80s traveling the country talking about their experiences because they thought those experiences mattered. They talked to anyone who would listen. History, they understood, isn't something that's ordained impartially or fixed in position—it's whatever people decide is worth repeating over and over.

This article appears in the [April 2026](#) print edition with the headline "The Women of Avenger Field." It has been updated to reflect that Patricia Perry moved two hours southwest, not southeast, to study at UC Berkeley, and that July 5, 1943, is when she began training in Sweetwater, Texas, not the date she arrived there. The article has also been updated to clarify that the remarks attributed to a base commander were not a direct quote, and to correct the verb tense in the quote from Pete Hegseth.

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Inside the Dirty, Dystopian World of AI Data Centers

The race to power AI is already remaking the physical world.

by Matteo Wong



Three Mile Island's cooling towers have until recently served as grave markers for America's nuclear-power industry.

As we drove through southwest Memphis, KeShaun Pearson told me to keep my window down—our destination was best tasted, not viewed. Along the way, we passed an abandoned coal plant to our right, then an active power plant to our left, equipped with enormous natural-gas turbines. Pearson, who directs the nonprofit Memphis Community Against Pollution, was bringing me to his hometown’s latest industrial megaproject.

Already, the air smelled of soot, gasoline, and asphalt. Then I felt a tickle sliding up my nostrils and down into my throat, like I was getting a cold. As we approached, I heard the rumble of cranes and trucks, and then from behind a patch of trees emerged a forest of electrical towers. Finally, I saw it—a white-walled hangar, bigger than a dozen football fields, where Elon Musk intends to build a god.

This is Colossus: a data center that Musk’s artificial-intelligence company, xAI, is using as a training ground for Grok, one of the world’s most advanced generative-AI models. Training these models takes a staggering amount of energy; if run at full strength for a year, Colossus would use as much electricity as 200,000 American homes. When fully operational, Musk has written on X, this facility and two other xAI data centers nearby will require nearly two gigawatts of power. Annually, those facilities could consume roughly twice as much electricity as the city of Seattle.

To get Colossus up and running fast, xAI built its own power plant, setting up as many as 35 natural-gas turbines—railcar-size engines that can be major sources of smog—according to imagery obtained by the Southern Environmental Law Center. Pearson coughed as we drove by the facility. The scratch in my throat worsened, and I rolled up my window.

xAI’s rivals are all building similarly large data centers to develop their most powerful generative-AI models; a metropolis’s worth of electricity will surge through facilities that occupy a few city blocks. These companies have primarily made their chatbots “smarter” not by writing niftier code but by making them bigger: ramming more data through more powerful computer chips that use more electricity. OpenAI has announced plans for facilities requiring more than 30 gigawatts of power in total—more than the largest recorded demand for all of New England. Since ChatGPT’s launch, in November 2022, the capital expenditures of Amazon, Microsoft, Meta, and

Google have exceeded \$600 billion, and much of that spending has gone toward data centers—more, even after adjusting for inflation, than the government spent to build the entire interstate-highway system. “These are the largest single points of consumption of electricity in history,” Jesse Jenkins, a climate modeler at Princeton, told me.

Even conservative analyses forecast that the tech industry will drop the equivalent of roughly 40 Seattles onto America’s grid within a decade; aggressive scenarios predict more than 60 in half that time. According to Siddharth Singh, an energy-investment analyst at the International Energy Agency, by 2030, U.S. data centers will consume more electricity than all of the country’s heavy industries—more than the cement, steel, chemical, car, and other industrial facilities put together. Roughly half of that demand will come from data centers equipped for the particular needs of generative AI—programs, such as ChatGPT, that can produce text and images, solve complex math problems, and perhaps one day inform scientific discoveries.



Colossus, Elon Musk’s data center in Memphis, can consume as much electricity over the course of a year as 200,000 American homes. (Landon Speers for *The Atlantic*)

To power AI, energy and tech companies are turning to fossil fuels, which they regard as more reliable and readily available than wind, solar, or nuclear. Asked where the energy for data centers should come from, OpenAI CEO Sam Altman [has repeatedly said](#), “Short-term: natural gas.” (OpenAI and *The Atlantic* have a corporate partnership.) A Louisiana utility plans to build three natural-gas plants for a Meta data center that, upon completion, will be among the largest in this hemisphere. The lifespans of coal plants, too, are being extended to power new data centers. And the IEA estimates that data-center emissions could more than double by 2030—becoming one of the fastest-growing sources of greenhouse gases in the world.

The optimist’s case is that, by then, advanced nuclear reactors will have obviated many of the new fossil-fuel plants, and AI tools will have invented technologies that can solve the climate crisis. That may well happen. But today, “the market has converged on *Add gas now, and then add nuclear later*,” Jenkins said. In other words, if natural-gas turbines seem to offer the most expedient path to an AI-enhanced future, then clean air may have to wait.

A data center is a planet of contradictions: heat without motion, shelter without bodies, light without sky. “The lifeblood of the internet is essentially flowing through these sites,” Jon Lin, the chief business officer at Equinix, one of the world’s largest data-center companies, told me in an Equinix facility in Loudoun County, Virginia. Behind Lin, someone in a green hoodie fiddled with computer chips shelved in a row of humming, refrigerator-size cabinets on the data-center floor. There were no windows, to keep the facility secure and to guard against the sun’s heat. As we walked along a corridor of cabinets, motion-activated lights illuminated the way. Farther ahead, only faint blue lights and blinking computer equipment pierced the darkness.

Ever since the first data centers were built, in the mid-20th century, their [purpose has remained constant](#): pack computer equipment close together to store and send information as efficiently as possible. But their scale has grown dramatically. The original data centers were simply large rooms housing mainframe computers. With the rise of the internet, in the 1990s, backroom computers gave way to entire buildings, such as the one Lin and I stood in—facilities that enable us to stream movies, trade stocks, store

medical records, manage supply chains, and make military decisions. Now the AI race is requiring vastly greater computing power, which has led to even bigger data centers, ones filled with computer chips that are much hungrier and run much hotter.

[Read: The lifeblood of the AI boom](#)

In a traditional data center, the cabinets are cooled by industrial fans—as we walked through the Equinix facility, I felt a constant breeze on my cheek—and rooftop cooling towers eventually expel the heat. The cabinets in a generative-AI data center use dozens of times more electricity. Lin showed me a row of AI-specialized cabinets used by Block, the firm that owns Square and Cash App, which radiated enough heat to make me break a sweat; to cool them, water runs into special metal plates that sit atop the chips inside the cabinets. AI data centers are filled with similar equipment, and cooling thousands of cabinets [can require a lot of water](#). Public records from the Memphis water utility, for instance, show that the address for Colossus used more than 11 million gallons in September alone, as much as 150 homes use in an entire year. When a data center’s cooling equipment malfunctions, spiraling heat combined with humid air has yielded that rarest of meteorological events: indoor rain.

Placing servers in the same or neighboring buildings allows them to exchange information seamlessly and quickly, and Loudoun County has the highest concentration of data centers in the world, with 199 already operating and another 30 or so on the way. According to one report, 13 percent of global data-center capacity is squeezed into the county’s 520 square miles. One particularly dense stretch is called “Data Center Alley.”



Cabinets of computer chips at a data center in Loudoun County, Virginia
(Landon Speers for *The Atlantic*)

Northern Virginia offers a glimpse into what the AI rush may bring to the rest of the nation. Loudoun is running out of space, but new data-center hubs are popping up in Phoenix, Atlanta, and Dallas. Amazon and Meta are building AI data centers in Indiana and Louisiana, respectively, that will each require more than two gigawatts of electricity, dozens of times more than standard facilities. OpenAI has proposed that the U.S. establish “AI Economic Zones”: little Loudouns everywhere.

As I drove into Data Center Alley with Julie Bolthouse, the director of land use at the Piedmont Environmental Council, she explained how to distinguish data centers from warehouses: cooling towers on the roof, dozens of backup diesel generators to one side, no windows (or false ones, decorative glass panels backed by a wall of concrete). There didn’t seem to be any warehouses, though, and I gave up counting data centers within minutes, unable to tell where one facility ended and the next one began. Bolthouse helps run a coalition aiming to slow data-center development throughout Virginia, but in Loudoun, it is too late. So many data centers are

under construction just north of Dulles International Airport that hills of freshly dug dirt loom over roads and orange dust tints the air. Should Musk successfully colonize Mars, the early stages of terraforming might look like this.

The architect of this labyrinth is Buddy Rizer, Loudoun's longtime executive director of economic development. Rizer has courted data centers with regulatory and state tax incentives, and when we met in his office, he told me that since 2009, at least one has been under construction at any given time. Data centers are typically operated by only a few dozen staff members, but building them has produced a steady source of employment. They also provide nearly 40 percent of the county's budget, helping to pay for police, schools, and parks for a population that has grown steadily since 2010.

Within a 1.5-mile radius of us, Rizer said, were 12 substations: small jungles of metal poles and wiring that convert high-voltage electricity into a form you'd use to charge your iPhone or, in this case, run a data center. All around us were towering utility poles strung with high-voltage transmission lines that carry raw electricity from power plants to those substations; they hang over Loudoun like a canopy, or a cobweb. Follow any one cable far enough, and you're likely to reach a data center.

For years to come, the AI race is projected to be the main force driving roughly 2 percent annual growth in U.S. electricity demand, which has been stagnant for nearly two decades. Nationally, this is not a crisis; regionally, it may be. Dominion Energy, the major electrical utility in Virginia, predicts growth of 5.5 percent each year, with overall electricity demand doubling by 2039. Aaron Ruby, a spokesperson for Dominion, told me that the company is preparing to meet that surge, though he was frank about the challenge: "We are experiencing the largest growth in power demand since the years following World War II." By the end of the decade, training the industry's most powerful AI model could require as much electricity as millions of American homes.

In China, hundreds of data centers have been announced since 2023, and additional facilities are planned for [beneath the ocean](#) and [in the desert](#). China's biggest advantage in the AI race is not the talent of its software engineers or the quantity of its data centers, but its abundance of energy: In

2024, the nation produced nearly as much electricity as the U.S., Europe, and India combined.

President Trump has declared that the nation is in an “energy emergency,” and been vocal about the need to build more power plants for the U.S. to win the AI race. A senior executive at OpenAI told me that the U.S. needs to activate every resource at its disposal—solar panels, natural-gas turbines, nuclear reactors. And Anthropic, OpenAI’s top rival, published a report arguing that the U.S. should streamline permitting for data centers and power plants in order to keep pace with China.

But an internet-driven energy crisis has failed to materialize before: As fiber-optic cables were being laid in Loudoun in the 1990s, energy companies built more coal- and gas-fired plants. “Dig More Coal—The PCs Are Coming,” [read a 1999 *Forbes* headline](#). When the demand didn’t arrive, the nation was left with a glut of gas plants and multiple bankrupt energy companies.

The generative-AI boom, too, could prove to be a bubble. The technology remains extraordinarily expensive, largely because of the cost of advanced computer chips, and no AI firm has presented a convincing business model. One path to profitability might be more efficient algorithms—which would preclude the need for the new natural-gas plants. And if AI doesn’t turn out to be as transformative a technology as experts predict, swaths of data centers could be left unused or unfinished—ruins from a future that never came to pass.

Either way, the rush to power data centers as fast as possible has already pushed the U.S. to expand its reliance on fossil fuels.

Behind her one-story brick home in southwest Memphis, Sarah Gladney grows tomatoes, and when the vines wilted early last summer, she had a suspect in mind. “When the wind comes up early in the morning, I can smell it,” Gladney told me, nodding in the direction of Colossus. One of her neighbors, Marilyn Gooch, told me the data center’s turbines have made her uncertain about whether she should let her grandchildren visit.

Their neighborhood, Boxtown, is named for the railway boxcars that formerly enslaved people used to build homes, and is still almost entirely Black. Virtually every heavy industry has set up nearby—a wastewater facility, an oil refinery, a coal-fired power plant. Colossus itself, which is next to a steel mill and a trucking and rail yard, occupies the hull of an old oven factory. Life expectancy in and around Boxtown is more than five years below the national average, and the cancer risk in southwest Memphis is four times higher. What KeShaun Pearson and I smelled may not have been Colossus itself; xAI had chosen an area so besieged by heavy industry that any exhaust from the facility's turbines would mix in with a pervasive smog.



In Boxtown, a neighborhood in southwest Memphis, many residents and elected officials were unaware that Colossus was being built until the project was well under way. (Landon Speers for *The Atlantic*)

Colossus was built so quickly that many Boxtown residents and elected officials didn't know what was happening until the project was well under way. Construction began in May 2024, and the project was announced the following month. Gladney, Pearson, and his younger brother Justin—who represents the district in the Tennessee General Assembly—found out about the project that day in June. By Labor Day weekend, less than three months after the press conference, Colossus was up and running.

The company installed its own gas turbines because that was faster than waiting on the local grid, and argued that it did not need a permit to do so because the turbines would operate for less than a year, a claim that the Southern Environmental Law Center, representing the NAACP, contested in a letter threatening to sue the company. (xAI has since received a permit for 15 turbines, and is reportedly operating 12.) Meanwhile, residents report that they have had respiratory issues flare up since xAI moved in.

Last June, when an analysis commissioned by the city of Memphis found “no dangerous levels” of pollutants in Boxtown and at two other test locations, the SELC criticized the study's methods. Using satellite data, [researchers at the University of Tennessee at Knoxville found](#) that levels of nitrogen dioxide—which causes smog and is associated with asthma and other respiratory problems—near Colossus have been substantially elevated since its public announcement. (xAI [says on its website](#) that it will install technology to reduce the pollution from its turbines. The company, the Shelby County Health Department, and the Memphis mayor's office did not respond to a list of questions about Colossus's environmental impacts and xAI's presence in Memphis; the Greater Memphis Chamber of Commerce declined to comment.)

Fossil fuels have become the default for data centers around the country. OpenAI's first Stargate data center, in Texas, also has its own gas-fired power plant. Chevron and Exxon are angling to hook natural-gas facilities directly into data centers, and the world's three major manufacturers of natural-gas turbines all advertise their products as convenient energy sources

for data centers. Michael Eugenis, the director of resource planning at Arizona Public Service, the state's largest utility, told me that because of the demand from data centers, the company is adding more fossil-fuel capacity than it otherwise would have; natural gas will help power Microsoft, Amazon, and Oracle data centers, too.



Transmission lines, like these in Memphis, carry electricity throughout the grid—including to data centers. (Landon Speers for *The Atlantic*)

In early 2025, a company affiliated with xAI purchased a former warehouse and nearly 200 acres south of Colossus to set up another data center,

Colossus II. On a weekday afternoon, the road near the site was dense with traffic—not dump trucks and forklifts, but sedans lining up outside the adjacent public school for pickup. An xAI affiliate bought a retired Duke Energy plant about a mile away in Mississippi that is likely to power this facility, and filed an application to operate 41 natural-gas turbines on the site. Those turbines could emit more carbon dioxide annually than the city of San Jose.

On an island in the Susquehanna River, just south of Harrisburg, Pennsylvania, I saw another way to power the AI boom. Above me loomed four beige hourglass-shaped structures, each some 365 feet tall: the cooling towers for Three Mile Island, the site of the worst nuclear disaster in American history. On March 28, 1979, the facility was only a few years old, and nuclear-energy reactors were being built across the country. But a series of mechanical and human errors caused the core of one of the reactors, Unit Two, to rapidly overheat and leak radioactive material. The effects on human health and the environment were negligible, but together with the catastrophe at Chernobyl seven years later, the partial meltdown turned public sentiment strongly against nuclear power.

Three Mile Island's Unit One went undamaged and continued operating, after a brief pause, until 2019. By then natural gas was too cheap, the regulatory environment was too unfriendly, and the losses—hundreds of millions of dollars—were too great for Constellation Energy, which owns Unit One, to keep the plant running.

[From the March 2023 issue: Jonathan Rauch on the real obstacle to nuclear power](#)

Nobody has ever resuscitated a fully shut-down U.S. nuclear-power plant, but in fall 2024, Constellation announced plans to do just that. Microsoft had agreed to purchase electricity from Unit One to power its data centers over the next two decades, a guarantee allowing Constellation to spend the \$1.6 billion needed to restart the plant. It was the ultimate bellwether of the AI age: Experts have long argued that we need clean nuclear power to reduce the grid's existing carbon footprint. Instead, Three Mile Island will help offset a new source of emissions from a single company.

Constellation is now reversing the steps it took to decommission the reactor: renewing its license, restoring equipment, retraining personnel. Dave Marcheskie, a community-relations manager, explained this to me in a conference room overlooking the nuclear core, which is housed in a building that resembles a large grain silo. Behind him, a clock counted down the time to launch: 650 days, zero hours, 42 minutes, and one second.

As the need for carbon-free electricity grows more urgent, Americans are [having to reckon with nuclear energy again](#), and the AI boom has provided the industry with wealthy backers and an army of tech cheerleaders. Meta and Amazon are buying electricity from large nuclear-power plants, and nearly every major data-center company is investing in experimental nuclear technologies—especially small modular reactors, which in theory will make fission cheaper and easier to deploy.

[Read: A new reckoning for nuclear energy.](#)

Nuclear energy has its downsides, of course. The waste is radioactive and must be stored almost indefinitely, and the meltdown at Japan's Fukushima plant in 2011 was a reminder of how spectacularly dangerous nuclear reactors can be. But the dangers posed by the burning of fossil fuels are far more imminent.

At Three Mile Island, Marcheskie led me down a hall and into the actual power plant. Pipes, tubes, and hulking machines lined the floor and ceiling; a trefoil sign warned that a large tank potentially contained radioactive materials. The elevator was broken, so we walked a few stories up to the stadium-size room from which all of Three Mile Island's electricity will flow. Scaffolding and shipping containers were scattered around a row of pistachio-green semi-cylinders. Once the plant restarts, uranium atoms ripped apart in the adjacent core will generate immense amounts of heat, vaporizing water into steam that will spin blades inside those cylinders 1,800 times a minute, which will in turn produce hundreds of megawatts of electricity.

This will be orchestrated from a nearby control room, where hundreds of lights and switches line muted-green walls. The shift manager, Bill Price, explained that one half of the main panel controls the nuclear core, while the

other half controls the turbines. In the middle is the most important control of all: a red button that shuts down the reactor, and above it an identical button that serves as a backup. In the event of an emergency, Price said, you'd press both. I put a finger on each button and pushed.



The original control room at Three Mile Island Unit One will become operational again when the reactor restarts. (Landon Speers for *The Atlantic*)

A small amount of the electricity generated here will support the plant itself. Microsoft [is buying the remainder](#) through a power-purchase agreement, a mechanism companies use to buy carbon-free electricity to match whatever their facilities draw from the grid. Power generated at Three Mile Island will help offset the energy used by data centers in Virginia and Illinois; Microsoft says it purchases enough clean energy to match all of its electricity consumption, as do Google, Amazon, and Meta. These companies are also investing in hydropower, geothermal plants, and solar panels; Google is exploring building a data center in space, to enable cloud-free access to the sun.

[Read: For now, there's only one good way to power AI](#)

Still, tech firms insist that nuclear and other clean technologies cannot be deployed quickly enough to meet their needs. President Trump has signed an executive order to accelerate permitting for natural-gas and coal-fired plants to support data centers. Yet China's energy advantage in the AI race comes from nuclear reactors and solar panels, not coal and oil; the country is building nearly two-thirds of the world's new solar and wind capacity.

The U.S. could still catch up, thanks to private investments by the likes of Google and Microsoft. A majority of planned electricity generation in the U.S. will be carbon-free, and running data centers on renewables can be done, Jenkins, the Princeton climate modeler, told me. Meanwhile, natural-gas turbines are so far back-ordered that acquiring one in the next few years will be virtually impossible.

For now, using existing power sources more wisely, rather than building new ones, may be all the AI industry needs. Electrical grids are designed for periods of peak demand—cooling on summer afternoons, heating on winter mornings—but mostly they run well below maximum capacity. Researchers at Duke University have shown that if data centers reduced their electricity consumption during some of those peaks, it would free up enough electricity to accommodate the country's planned data centers for years. Google and xAI have already entered agreements to do so.

That strategy would allow tech companies to continue building more data centers without waiting for utilities to expand the grid. And time, not dollars or electrons, is the AI industry's primary currency. Google, Microsoft, and their competitors can afford to spend historic sums without near-term financial returns, but they cannot afford to slip behind one another.

Time is also the biggest problem for Microsoft's deal with Three Mile Island, which is taking years to restart. As we left the facility, Marcheskie led me south, past the beige towers and through a fog that had settled over the river. At one point we passed a cluster of concrete barrels that had escaped my attention on the drive up. Marcheskie told me that they contained all of the nuclear waste from Unit One's 45 years of operation. Perhaps one day such casks will also line the perimeters of Colossus and Stargate.

AI may well overhaul how humans think and work, but it's also pushing us toward another inflection point. We can unlock the promises of this technology by doubling down on the energy systems of the past, or we can seize the opportunity to push the grid into a carbon-free future. To get there, an industry that likes to move at warp speed will have to develop a quality it severely lacks: patience.

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The City Where Coetzee Is God

Searching for the Nobel laureate in Cape Town, the city he left behind

by Gary Shteyngart

When I arrived in Cape Town, South Africa, in October, at the windy end of spring, setting foot on African soil for the first time in my life, it wasn't to indulge in the animal voyeurism that wealthy newlyweds tell me will change my life. The prospect of being stuck in a jeep watching wildebeest pour through the veld did not intrigue me. Instead, I was on a hunt for traces of one of the world's strangest writers, J. M. Coetzee, in the city from which he had emerged, a city that he'd intermittently written about—without revealing much of it—and then left, in 2002. The 86-year-old author's legacy, I'd been told, stirred the kinds of passions that have gone extinct pretty much everywhere else on the planet. Here was my chance to witness not a band of rutting gnu but something I had not imagined could still exist: a communal literary obsession in a postliterary age, at the center of which is a man whom acolytes call, simply, "God."

I had first encountered Coetzee's books during my formative years as a writer, in the late '90s and early aughts. Every second that I wasn't drinking or abusing drugs or lamely trying to seduce someone or sleeping at a desk job or reworking my first novel, I was reading Toni Morrison, Salman Rushdie, Don DeLillo, a young woman out of London with the chipper name of Zadie—experimental, social-realist, modernist, travelogue, memoir. I probably read at least three books a week, a thought that both inspires and depresses me today.

Of course I read Coetzee. Nobody could make you feel as cultured and literary in the space of some 200-odd pages as the stoic and writerly looking man from Cape Town. I read the second of his two Booker Prize–winning novels, [*Disgrace*](#), when it came out in 1999, at a time when I was experimenting heavily with ketamine, and then went to the back catalog, the novels of the apartheid era, including [*Waiting for the Barbarians*](#) and the other Booker winner, 1983’s [*Life & Times of Michael K*](#). In 2003, he [*won the Nobel Prize in Literature*](#)—the second South African writer to do so.

[From the June 2020 issue: J. M. Coetzee’s unsettling trilogy about a possibly divine boy](#)

I mention the ketamine not to sound au courant, but because the dissociative properties of the drug tracked nicely with what I perceived to be the interior mood and tenor of the novels, or at least of their protagonists. David Lurie, the disgraced literature professor at the center of *Disgrace*, and the titular Michael K, a simple gardener, are as different as can be in class, education, and race. But as I read their stories, they both felt cut in two: one part of their character acting, suffering, surviving; the other observing from above or below. They are inhabiting and yet also floating through their worlds, untethered to place and people. Many of Coetzee’s characters feel landless; they’ve left home (*Disgrace*), or are homeless themselves (*Michael K*), or have relationships with the homeless that sometimes bleed into a kind of intimacy (*Waiting for the Barbarians*, [*Age of Iron*](#)). Many of them are swaddled in the privilege of their white skin, yet they yearn for a kind of absolution from the sins of their circumstances (an idea not unfamiliar to the liberal-minded white reader living in Donald Trump’s America). For them, the past is freighted with guilt—a sense, implicit or explicit, that their “presence was grounded in a crime, namely colonial conquest, perpetuated by apartheid,” as Coetzee writes in his 2009 semi-fictional memoir, [*Summertime*](#), part of a trio he called [*Scenes From Provincial Life*](#). As for the future: In Coetzee’s pages, it generally promises catastrophe.



J. M. Coetzee, 2003 (Leonardo Cendamo / Getty)

The ketamine sensibility wasn't all that drew me to him. I am [no stranger to writing about dystopia](#), or to the subject of homelessness; emigration is a loss of home. Coetzee decamped for Australia the year before he won the Nobel Prize. I left my native St. Petersburg at the age of 7, and I dream of it perhaps once a week (given the political situation, a visit isn't likely anytime soon). I couldn't help wondering if Coetzee dreams of Cape Town after the sun sets over Adelaide. Somewhere in the novels I read was a moody African city of rainy skies that seemed so different from the cities in the works of [Chinua Achebe](#) and [Ngũgĩ wa Thiong'o](#), and even the Johannesburg of Nadine Gordimer, who won South Africa's first literature Nobel. Yet Coetzee's Cape Town was always blurry. A very large mountain, flat-topped like a table, sometimes made its presence known in his pages, but this writer seemed to want to keep the drama internal, or to reach past the particular for the universal parable.

I visited the city he left behind because I was curious to figure out what Cape Town may have meant to him, how it might have shaped him, perhaps why he'd moved away. Maybe I wanted to understand a little better the mind of the man floating above the work, more in control of his sentences and his plots, more godlike, in a way, than just about any other writer I had read. And I wanted to discover, too, how he could remain godlike in certain circles—to some a Kafka whose portrayals of alienation gave his once-pariah state a passport to a wider world, to others a false prophet of doom who had abandoned the “Mother City” right when it was starting to prove his dire predictions wrong.

I came armed with an essay by my friend Imraan Coovadia, himself a novelist of some note and the head of the creative-writing program at the University of Cape Town. Titled “Coetzee in (and out of) Cape Town,” it appeared a decade and a half ago in a relatively obscure cultural journal in the Philippines, and its sweeping criticisms of Coetzee, painting him as a difficult colleague and his work as socially regressive, had set Cape Town's literary community on fire. Various friends of Coetzee's warned me not to trust Coovadia, because he was shunned by most Coetzee scholars, and one of them told me that the writer had been deeply hurt by the essay—the work of a former student, no less. Coetzee had been something like a mentor to Coovadia in the '90s, when the future apostate was an undergraduate at Harvard and Coetzee was a visiting professor.



Imraan Coovadia, the head of the creative-writing program at the University of Cape Town, roiled the city's literary community with his essay about Coetzee. (Kent Andreassen for *The Atlantic*)

Coovadia's essay is still shocking to read, and it hasn't been forgotten in some Capetonian precincts. Coetzee, a writer I had regarded as a distant

mystery, a subject of graduate papers and bland prize tributes, comes across as a contentious figure, a politically evasive writer who sought “to insert his own name onto the bookshelves beside Conrad and Dostoyevsky.” He also inspired wild rumors of varying credibility, including the tale that he’d once locked a rival in the trunk of his car. Coovadia doesn’t lend credence to such allegations, and I didn’t have the desire or journalistic wherewithal to investigate them. But I could examine Coetzee’s legacy up close, in the city that lays the greatest claim to him—a backdrop for his dark prophecies of social decay and civil strife that has instead become a cosmopolitan tourist destination, where farm-to-table delicacies, natural splendors, and seaside resorts beckon, but its greatest writer is nowhere to be found.

When you see Table Mountain—its scale, its dominance of the sky—everything changes. The mountain’s backside, the one so many Capetonians prefer to its city-facing side because it receives more rainfall and is hence more verdant, commanded the windshield of my taxi on the highway from the airport, just as the road left behind one of the impoverished townships of the surrounding Cape Flats, its corrugated roofs glinting atop informal piles of brick. This strange double vision mirrors so much of Coetzee’s work: poverty close enough to feel, the salvation of nature far in the distance, likely beyond the reach of his morally and often physically struggling characters.



A view of the City Bowl of Cape Town, looking toward Table Mountain
(Kent Andreassen for *The Atlantic*)

There are cities like Los Angeles, ringed and cut by mountains, and cityscapes that are punctuated by outcroppings such as Rio de Janeiro's Sugarloaf Mountain, but I have never seen an urban place as thoroughly ensconced within stony promontories as Cape Town. The city lies in an urban bowl surrounded by Table Mountain, by the fearsome Lion's Head, and by the lion's posterior, known as Signal Hill; some of Cape Town's prime beachside real estate crouches beneath the Twelve Apostles, a range of (actually 18) similar peaks. St. Petersburg was built by Peter the Great to make its inhabitants feel small in comparison with the ornate might of its imperial architecture; here, one is cut down to size the moment one looks up and sees a blank cliff face that refuses to stare back, or Table Mountain when it's covered by a run of wispy clouds that the locals call a "tablecloth."

My companion for the next 10 days, the photographer Kent Andreassen, met me at the Taj Cape Town hotel in the city's center, about a block away from Parliament, shortly after I'd checked in. We immediately charged up Lion's Head in the trail-ready Toyota that everyone seemed to drive around there. "Mongoose! Mongoose!" he cried as we nearly ran over said animal. I recalled my childhood love of [Rikki-Tikki-Tavi](#), the mongoose hero of a Kipling story, which had become a popular animated film in the Soviet Union.

Throughout my visit, Capetonians kept intimating that although I had finally made it to Africa, I hadn't really—that their city and most of its inhabitants existed apart from the rest of the continent. The sources of this exceptionalism were both physical and spiritual: first, its rare natural beauty, and second, a (more Coetzeean) sense that it was a remnant that had broken away from some other world entirely and drifted down to the edge of Africa.

In the cultural musings of Coetzee's white characters, that world is Europe—Lurie, for example, spends much of *Disgrace* planning to write an opera about Lord Byron. And Coetzee took his literary cues from European modernists: Kafka composing his parables; Dostoyevsky shaking his fist at God (or perhaps vice versa); Conrad seeking truth at the edge of empire. For all of the region's surface attractions, Coetzee's continental brand of allegorical realism was what put Cape Town, a city closer to Antarctica than to London, on the global literary and intellectual map. Was the author, like the city itself, in Africa but not quite of it?

"Cape Town is showing off for you," Andreassen said as the city below us shone prismatically, the way it never would in a Coetzee novel. The Cape's notorious wind had decided to take a rest. In the distance, we could see the loading docks of the massive port stocked with colorful Lego—Chinese shipping containers. Closer was something approximating the skyline of a modest Canadian city, the downtown where I was staying. Closer still, the vividly painted buildings of the Bo-Kaap, a neighborhood of mostly Muslim residents of the Cape Malay subgroup. And in the middle of the bay, Robben Island, where Nelson Mandela was imprisoned for nearly two decades, rebuked all of this beauty with history.



Cape Town's stony beauty is rebuked by history: Beyond Lion's Head and Signal Hill, the frigid waters of Table Bay surround Robben Island, where Nelson Mandela was imprisoned for nearly two decades. (Kent Andreassen for *The Atlantic*)

Next to a Muslim shrine where we'd paused at the top of the hill, a family of three lay sheltered in the shade of an anemic-looking bush. "You guys want some apples?" Andreassen asked the disheveled patriarch, who shook him off with an explanation for his refusal that could have come from *Michael K* or *Age of Iron*: "It's because I got no teeth." The rest of the family accepted the fruit.

We headed down the other side of the hill toward Camps Bay and instantly found ourselves, visually, at least, in Malibu or Sydney's Bondi Beach. We passed the street where the current South African president, Cyril

Ramaphosa, has a home. White villas, fearsomely armored against intruders, were stacked up and down the hill. Despite the tense security situation—Cape Town’s homicide rate is among the highest in the world—the city has become a magnet for foreigners. Andreasen (who had recently suffered a brutal attack) noted that crime, and the frigid waters (he is, like many residents, a surfer), are all that keep Cape Town from being completely overrun. [*The Telegraph*](#) rated it the best city on Earth in 2025. So did [*Time Out*](#): “Locals and visitors alike can hang out with a colony of African penguins, taste world-class wines, stroll Blue Flag beaches, enjoy views from atop one of the New 7 Wonders of Nature”—Table Mountain—“and visit one of the world’s coolest neighborhoods, East City, all in one day.”

Driving past Camps Bay, we came to Sea Point, a traditionally Jewish neighborhood fronting the beach. Here was my first chance to contrast the scenes of a Coetzee novel with what I could see on the ground. In *Michael K*, the eponymous character finds himself trying to survive in a civil war. The first part of the novel involves a journey he undertakes with his ill mother, who’s been working as a domestic for a “retired hosiery manufacturer” in Sea Point, which is portrayed as an abandoned shell under martial law. He’s trying to convey her by means of a jury-rigged wheelbarrow to her native Prince Albert, at the southern edge of the semiarid region known as the Karoo, so that she can die peacefully on the land where she was born.

Michael K repudiates the feverish world building that pervades a lot of dystopian fiction. The combatants in the civil war are never named, nor is the reason for the war; characters’ races are (as in the rest of Coetzee’s fiction) mostly unspecified. But city landmarks get slipped in, as do racial clues, at least for locals who can recognize them. Michael K wheels his mother “across Beach Road and on to the paved promenade along the seafront,” a quiet scene that later gives way to mob violence on the road. Because his mother is a servant, readers have assumed that they are “Coloured.” (To preempt the American reader’s justified ire: *Coloured*, in the South African context, refers to most people of mixed-race heritage.) Now I walked down the same paved promenade, past absurdly fit young men engaged in push-up competitions (squint and you’re on Miami’s Ocean Drive), past swimmers’ bodies glinting in gorgeous beachside pools, past housewives speed-walking away the afternoon.



The Sea Point Promenade runs alongside one of Cape Town's most affluent neighborhoods, an area portrayed as an abandoned shell under martial law in Coetzee's novel *Life & Times of Michael K*. (Kent Andreassen for *The Atlantic*)

The incongruity between the grim dystopia that Coetzee conjured and the booming post-apartheid reality of Cape Town is terribly relevant to the way he is perceived, and puzzled over, by South Africans today. Forty years ago, the strangeness of his settings stirred debate too: How to read this lofty writer's views of his country's actual anti-apartheid struggles? "The unique and controversial aspect of this work," Nadine Gordimer wrote in her review of *Michael K*, "is that while it is implicitly and highly political, Coetzee's heroes are those who ignore history, not make it." Admiring his fierce vision of human oppression, she also detected "a revulsion against all political and revolutionary solutions": Rather than join a band of guerrillas, Michael K, a

harelippped loner raised in a state home for the “unfortunate,” sticks to his gardening.

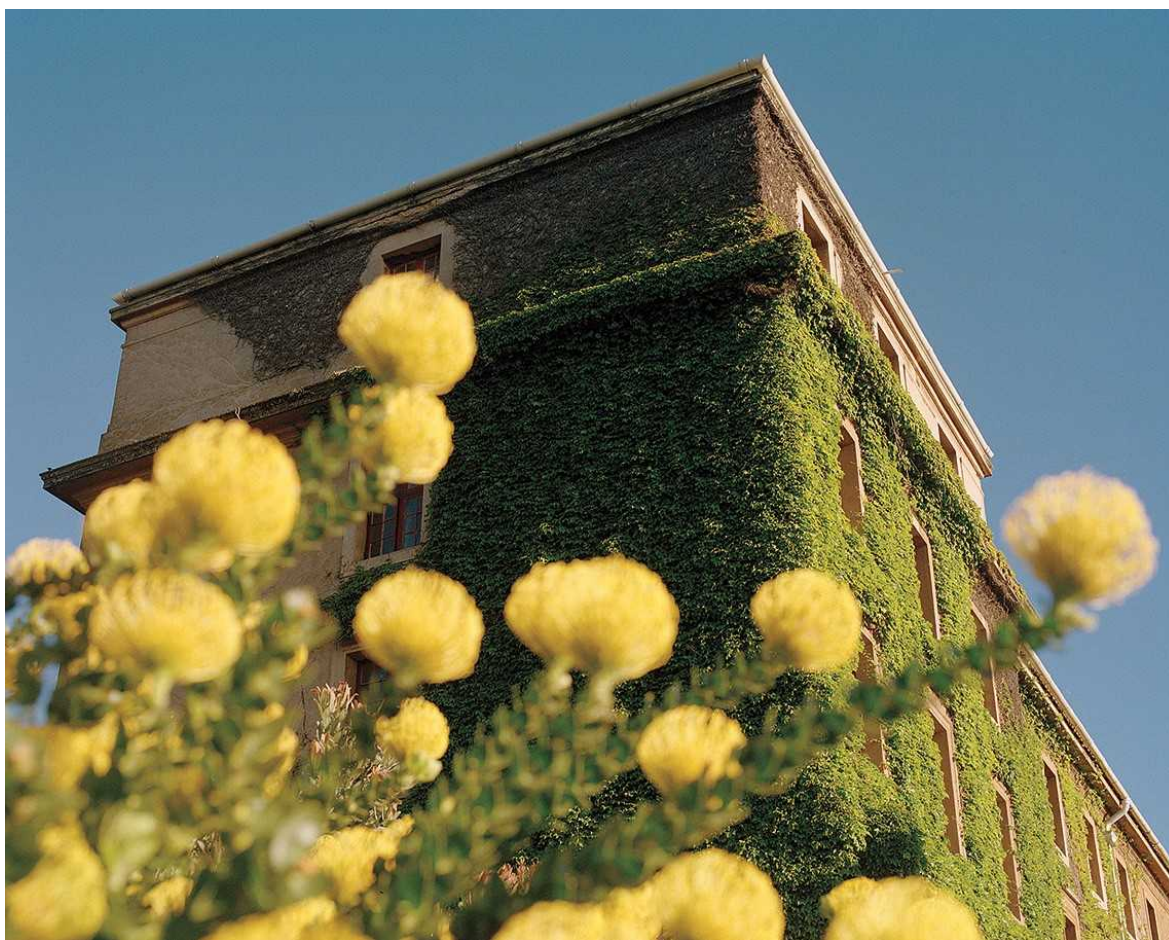
Allegory can open many interpretive doors, as it has for Coovadia. In his essay, he cites *Michael K* as an example of a narrative that speaks to the white South Africans who fled the country in anticipation of a bleak future under Black rule. “You could ask,” Coovadia writes, “whether Coetzee was offering a warning or something which has more the quality of a wish”—a justification for the decision to flee. Bolstering this critique was Coetzee’s own post-apartheid departure.

Coovadia’s insider reading, an uncommon one, hadn’t occurred to me. I had imagined the many checkpoints through which *Michael K* had to pass on his journey as being manned by white soldiers from warring factions. Coetzee, for his part, bridled at hearing his novels “discussed as political statements dressed up as fiction,” he once wrote in a letter; he was frustrated by the failure to read “them as they were written: as accounts of the possible lives of possible people.”

In any case, I wondered if Coetzee would argue for his self-exile on moral grounds, as a colonizer whose “presence there was legal but illegitimate,” as a character in *Summertime* says. “We had an abstract right to be there, a birthright, but the basis of that right was fraudulent.” To which the daughter of *Disgrace*’s white protagonist, who is gang-raped at her farm, adds: “Why should I be allowed to live here without paying?” Her father himself experiences a harrowing downfall. When the novel came out, half a decade after the euphoria of the 1994 democratic elections in South Africa, its portrayal of a cycle of brutality and resignation as white dominance ebbs fueled yet more debate over Coetzee’s political stance, or the lack of one.

By this point, Coetzee was a towering figure at his alma mater, the University of Cape Town, and had been on its faculty since 1972—but he was also an intermittent presence. He was in demand as a visiting professor in the United States, where he’d earned his Ph.D. 30 years earlier, and he traveled a lot. He seemed eager to put some distance between himself and his home. I will mention that the university has a beautifully situated and landscaped campus, its classical buildings draped in a Princeton’s worth of ivy. I discovered this when I dropped in on Coovadia, a tall man with a

luftmensch air about him, as if his mind is always processing the unseen and unsaid—not exactly an obvious provocateur type.





Top: The classical buildings of the University of Cape Town. *Bottom:* A statue of Nelson Mandela stands at the entrance to Robben Island. (Kent Andreason for *The Atlantic*)

In *Disgrace*, critics like Coovadia have seen an attempt to vindicate the white South Africans who warned that chaos would fill the power vacuum they were leaving behind. The African National Congress, the ruling party at the time it was published, attacked the novel for promoting racial stereotypes

of the country's Black population. For Coetzee's acolytes, it can be seen as a parable about how the wages of colonialism spare no group. François Verster, a South African filmmaker at work on a movie about the writer, made the case to me that Coetzee's avoidance of race and ethnicity is designed precisely to subvert stereotypes—"a refusal to replicate the linguistic terms of apartheid power structures," much as the absence of scenery defies Europeans' habit of "reveling in and poeticizing the beauty of the lands they were stealing."

In my first, rapt reading of *Disgrace* decades ago, perhaps influenced by my history as a child of a failed totalitarian regime, I had felt depleted by the constant, horrific conflict between personal and political choices playing out in its pages. Now I couldn't help wondering what rereading the novel would be like—how would Coetzee's vision of a country's moral core under pressure and its institutions cracking strike an American these days? But I'd get to that later. For the moment, here I was in Cape Town, and I had traces of the writer himself to pursue in places I'd never been—places from which he'd always felt estranged.

I arranged to take a trip with a true expert—"the dean of Coetzeeans," as Coovadia had called him. Hermann Wittenberg is an English professor at the University of the Western Cape, a longtime acquaintance of Coetzee's, and the editor of [*J. M. Coetzee: Photographs From Boyhood*](#), a collection of pictures taken by Coetzee as a teenager living in the Cape Town suburb of Plumstead. The chiaroscuro selfie on the book cover—the young Coetzee looking impishly ominous in the shadows—is jarring if you've seen Coetzee only on stately novel jackets. It hints at a more playful nature than the one to be found on the page decades later. (Some of Coetzee's acolytes tried to convince me that in addition to his many other talents, he is a funny writer; they are wrong.) Wittenberg has the grown-up version of the familiar Coetzee mien: slightly bearded, a bit awkward, hopelessly cultured.

South Africa's history, as I'd learned by now, has its share of intrawhite tensions, less warping than oppression along lines of color, but socially salient. According to the rough archetypes that have evolved over the years, the Afrikaners, descendants of the original Dutch settlers, are considered more working-class and blood-and-soil in spirit than the British latecomers,

who are portrayed as wealthier, more effete, and less tied in with the politics of apartheid.

[From the March 1986 issue: Conor Cruise O'Brien on what can become of South Africa](#)

Once asked what he would call himself, Coetzee answered, “A doubtful Afrikaner, perhaps.” His parents were both of Afrikaner descent, Wittenberg explained, and I knew that a farm in the Karoo, *Voëlfontein* (“Bird Fountain”), had been passed down by his grandfather to his paternal uncle. But Coetzee’s immediate family was somewhat distanced from that heritage, not least by speaking English at home—and he described himself as feeling particularly ambivalent, starting young. At school, he was more comfortable with the outsiders—Jewish and Catholic kids—than the Afrikaner students and teachers, who feature as bullies in his memoirs. In adulthood, he often seemed ill at ease in conventional social and cultural precincts—a man at the margins of the party.

“He can sometimes be difficult to engage with and doesn’t suffer fools lightly,” Wittenberg said. “He may sometimes say abrupt things which don’t allow his interlocutor to save face. He has the strength of cutting right to the core, but for some people, this can sometimes feel antagonizing.”

I thought of Coetzee’s own gloss on his adolescent self in the interview included in the photo book. As a budding photographer, he’d been “interested in being present at the moment when truth revealed itself, a moment which one half discovered but also half created,” he told Wittenberg. At the same time, he recognized that he wasn’t attuned “to other people’s experience. I was too wrapped up in myself, which was not unusual at that age.” In [*Boyhood*](#), another of Coetzee’s semi-fictional memoirs of provincial life, the young protagonist longs to be a “normal boy,” yet he also proudly stands apart from peers, whom he considers crude Afrikaners.

Nearly everyone I talked with, admirers of Coetzee or not, emphasized a kind of emotional remoteness. In *Summertime*, a former lover describes the Coetzee stand-in this way: “In his lovemaking I now think there was an autistic quality. I offer this not as a criticism but a diagnosis, if it interests you. The autistic type treats other people as automata, mysterious automata.”

In my conversations, a startling number of people quietly speculated about Coetzee perhaps being on the spectrum, and his fans sometimes spoke of him as a godly invalid or, if you want to go full Dostoyevsky, a holy fool.

By this point in our tour, you won't be surprised to learn that Coetzee's family story is an unsettled one—and that the places where he grew up have changed. His father held an assortment of jobs, and, despite having a law degree, he ran into legal trouble along the way (among other things, he embezzled trust funds). The Coetzee family “was marginally middle-class,” Wittenberg said as we headed for Plumstead, where the downwardly mobile arc of his boyhood landed him before he left home. “That's why he had the ambition to succeed,” Wittenberg said, “and why he's always been careful with money.”

We stopped by the Catholic school that Coetzee attended before university—a “last resort” for those shut out of the fancier private schools for the English elite. From there, Wittenberg drove us to where the Coetzees lived at the time, explaining that it had then been very close to a Coloured area, with halal shops and a mosque; he pointed out the “cheap postwar housing.” What I could see of the Coetzee house, mostly obscured behind a sturdy-looking gate and fencing, reminded me of the kind of anonymous place my family lived in a few years after arriving in America; I suppose one could call it lower-middle-class but striving mightily. Coetzee had practiced cricket here, while his emotionally inaccessible father drank himself into oblivion.

In one of the photos that the young Coetzee took, his mother stands out front, a slight smile on her face, a dog in her arms—a snapshot of homey rootedness, in sharp focus: exactly what's left out of his fiction. On our drive, I brought up the way the entire region tends to hide in the deep background in Coetzee's work. Wittenberg told me that Coetzee applies a kind of filter to the stunning landscapes provided by the city and its environs. He cited a character in Coetzee's 1986 novel, *Foe*, an author who muses on “a ripple in the glass” as he gazes out of an attic window. This sense of a “distortion in the visual field” is key, Wittenberg said, to Coetzee's “complicated realism.” Any strand of joy that a character happens to catch comes from deep within his mind, and is connected mostly to the intellect, sometimes to love, or, on rarer occasions—reaching across the

divides drawn by colonialism and apartheid—to an understanding of another human. For Coetzee the outsider, fiction dwelled in the interior.

Four years before the Coetzees settled in Plumstead, the family interrupted their suburban existence and left the city behind. The preteen Coetzee was miserable when the family moved to Worcester, not far from where the Karoo starts. “After an hour outdoors there is a fine red dust in one’s hair, in one’s ears, on one’s tongue,” he wrote in *Boyhood*. “Worcester is only ninety miles from Cape Town, yet everything is worse here.” It was hard to say no to a ringing endorsement like that. So one early morning, I set off to visit this part of Coetzee’s past, joined by Andreasen and Coovadia. (Lest one think of Coovadia as a thoroughgoing Coetzee antagonist, he did tell me at one point that his former teacher “is still the greatest living South African writer.”)

The drive up to the Karoo was as beautiful as one could hope. Every few minutes, a new stage set presented itself: landscapes of increasing aridity backed by mountain ranges that fanned out into eternity, or poked up into ochre skylines, or presented as what the locals call a “witch’s hat.” If a small dinosaur instead of the customary baboon had dashed across the road, I would not have been surprised.

We stopped by a traditional *padstal*, a rural roadside farm stall crowded with kitschy examples of what Wittenberg had called “Boer chic”—wooden plows and the like. Dozens of farmers had gathered there for lunch, many in T-shirts that stretched over their monstrous torsos and celebrated various kinds of tactical weapons. I ate a springbok carpaccio that tasted silky with blood (this would not end well for me on a gastric level). Before hitting Worcester, we took a detour: Andreasen drove us to the so-called Gateway to the Karoo, the railroad town of Touws River, which he had been photographing for a project. We passed all forms of cinematic desolation: abandoned schools, sad-looking liquor stores (“Boredom in South Africa means drinking,” Andreasen said), salvaged train seats piled up on people’s porches. “This is the poorest town I’ve ever been in,” Coovadia said, although as a former Soviet I found the alcoholic vibe familiar: It felt like Russia with sun.



The author in Worcester, 90 miles from Cape Town, where Coetzee lived as a preteen and a memorial plaque now honors his literary contributions (Kent Andreassen for *The Atlantic*)

We circled back to Worcester, which, after the poverty of Touws River, appeared to be a veritable Palm Springs, the main street bustling with coffee shops and wealth managers, though the dismal place that Coetzee described was not thoroughly transformed. The house he lived in is now a one-story ranch with a garage and a corrugated roof with a skylight. An old white man, aided by a walker, was ambling over to a woman next door as barefoot kids ran down the street and a dog barked and whined. (The boy in *Boyhood* stands out for always wearing shoes.) We rang the doorbell; no one answered.

But the view! Every time Coetzee left his *Boyhood* home, he'd be greeted by a mountain range—perhaps minor by Western Cape standards, but terribly

impressive by anyone else's—that towered above the humble homes. A park in front of his house only heightened its grandeur. How did that not make it into Coetzee's work? Then again, postcard vistas are not selling points in novels about the core of existence—any more than a gift for mingling is to be expected from their author.

Later in the week, Coovadia threw a *braai*, or barbecue, at his grand but lovingly cluttered home in the suburbs, with an Afrikaner minding the lamb, which was charred to perfection and perhaps even tastier than its New Zealand counterpart. The expert griller presented me with a book in Afrikaans that traced 300 years of the Coetzee family's lineage in South Africa; he himself, he told me, was distantly related to the writer. A friend of Coovadia's, a woman of South Asian heritage, recalled her time at the University of Cape Town when Coetzee taught there. She mentioned, not without some pride, that her “ex-husband sold a bicycle to him”—and that “lots of people I fell in love with were Coetzeean fanatics.” It was she who told me that whereas foreign students addressed him as John, “South African students referred to him as ‘God.’”

I thought of how many parties and *braais* must have taken place in Cape Town's southern suburbs over the years, in academic households such as this one, with the conversations focusing on Coetzee; some, perhaps, on his actual work, others on his aloofness, his love interests, his bicycles. In his essay, Coovadia writes that in the decades after apartheid, Coetzee became more than a writer to a contingent of Cape Town intellectuals. He became a religion, which made their African outpost a kind of mecca.

As my time in the city drew to a close, Andreassen and I rushed around town on a scavenger hunt, list in hand of stray lines from Coetzee's novels that mentioned Cape Town's particulars. I began to realize that Coetzee hadn't been as unaware as I'd thought of the fact that he lived in one of the world's most beautiful places. “Cape Town,” Lurie reflects in *Disgrace*, “a city prodigal of beauty, of beauties.” Scenes crop up of sad seductions and near intimacies: His characters stare down from a height at one of the beaches below or struggle through a harborside meal in a picturesque suburb like Hout Bay. And, yes, as Lurie says during a class lecture in *Disgrace*, climbing up Table Mountain can lead to “one of those revelatory, Wordsworthian moments we have all heard about.”

[From the May 2024 issue: Gary Shteyngart cries himself to sleep on the biggest cruise ship ever](#)

Before I left the city, I met the author Justin Fox, a half Afrikaner who traveled along the route taken by Michael K for his book [Place: South African Literary Journeys](#). “So many South African writers are bred of the Karoo, this ancient landscape where dinosaurs roamed,” he told me at an L.A.-style casual restaurant by the waterfront, a kind of anti-Karoo. “My English roots are only 150 years old, but my Afrikaner roots are 300 years old, so the pull is deeper, and so I think it is for Coetzee.”

In a public conversation last year in the Netherlands, Coetzee said that as he was “nearing the end,” he felt more and more like an imposter when he spoke English: “I am a lighter—a more lighthearted—and a better person in Afrikaans.” It might seem a strange thing to say, considering the leading role Afrikaners played during apartheid, and if *Boyhood* is to be believed, the young Coetzee had been panicked at the prospect of being consigned to classes taught in Afrikaans at school. I grew up speaking Russian and reading the classics in that language; now, given [its political uses](#) in the atrocities perpetrated in Ukraine, I shudder every time I have to speak in the tongue of Pushkin. Yet Coetzee’s homecoming to his parents’ language might well be a sign of his needing to reconcile with his origins, no matter how complicated they are.

“He has mentioned that he wants his ashes scattered on the grounds of his family farm,” Fox told me. Does this mean that God in fact intends to return, if only in death? Fox couldn’t say: “I’ve known him for 50 years, but I’ve never known him, because, in a way, he’s unknowable.”

Travel Notes

Leo’s Wine Bar

A hipster district has formed along Bree Street, at the edge of downtown and at the foot of the colorful Bo-Kaap. Leo’s, which serves bagels by day (under the name Max Bagels) and wines and snacks by night, felt spunky and cool and diverse, a little bit like Brooklyn before my generation

destroyed it. I ate slices of organic raw-milk cheese from the Karoo, and drank a cold glass of grenache gris from a nearby region. Matthew, the young owner, grew up in Plumstead, and was happy I was on Coetzee's trail. "He's very deliberate," Matthew said of the author. "He doesn't use words unnecessarily. I think he'll go down as one of the greats." To further extend the Brooklyn analogy, Matthew gave me a collection of his own poems, which proved not half bad.

[Shop 28, De Oude Schuur, 120 Bree St, Cape Town, 8001, South Africa](#)

ANTHM

This Japanese-inspired cocktail joint reminded me of one of the best bars that New York City has ever known, Angel's Share, which was sadly forced to leave its longtime East Village home in 2022 before relocating further west. I thought I recognized ANTHM's owner; naturally, he had worked at Angel's Share, and had brought an approximation of its sophisticated drink menu to Cape Town.

[63 Loop St, Cape Town City Centre, Cape Town, 8000, South Africa](#)

Bodega Ramen

Situated in a former mortuary just off Bree Street, Bodega Ramen served the best version of *karaage*, or Japanese fried chicken, that I have had outside Japan. The Gin Bar, downstairs, has a cocktail menu of "house remedies" that promise to cure you of a variety of modern ailments: pessimism, depression, heartache, jealousy. My favorite, The Ambition, will finally rid you of impulse buying, arrogance, and "big car" syndrome.

[64A Wale St, CBD, Cape Town, 8001, South Africa](#)

Giovanni's Deliworld

Adjacent to Jewish Sea Point, this classic deli features ancient machers with golden *Chai* symbols around their necks still making deals over coffee and sandwiches. Despite much of its clientele, Giovanni's, as you may have

guessed, is not a Kosher establishment. I had no objections; the prosciutto del capo made my morning.

[103 Main Rd, Green Point, Cape Town, 8051, South Africa](#)

Table Mountain

Because you've spent half the day looking up at it, you might as well take the cable car to the top. In fact you really should, because this might be the most transcendent urban view on the planet, one that even hundreds of chattering tourists can't spoil.

[5821 Tafelberg Rd, Table Mountain \(Nature Reserve\), Cape Town, 8001, South Africa](#)

South Yeaster Bakery

In the picture-perfect suburb of Hout Bay, on the south side of Table Mountain's enormous nature preserve, is the kind of happy seaside place I imagine you can find in Coetzee's new Australian homeland, but I bet this one is much, much better. The kimchi-and-Gruberg-cheese croissant shouldn't work, but it does. The sandwiches, which make liberal use of local cheese, crème fraîche, arugula, and focaccia, inspire awe.

[4 The Promenade, Hout Bay, Cape Town, 7806, South Africa](#)

This article appears in the [April 2026](#) print edition with the headline “The City Where Coetzee Is God.” When you buy a book using a link on this page, we receive a commission. Thank you for supporting The Atlantic.

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Dispatches

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- [**My Tesla Was Driving Itself Perfectly—Until It Crashed**](#)
- [**The Republican Party Has a Nazi Problem**](#)

The Impossible Predicament of the Uninsured

My aunt couldn't afford to go to the hospital. She ended up there anyway.

by Jenisha Watts



This article was featured in the One Story to Read Today newsletter. [Sign up for it here.](#)

The day after Thanksgiving, I got a voicemail. A woman identified herself as a doctor at the University of Louisville hospital: “I believe I may have one of your family members here.”

The message was hard to understand. Most of my family lives in Kentucky, so I didn't know whom the doctor was referring to. I called the hospital, but kept getting put on hold. Then I tried my aunt—if someone was in trouble, she'd be the one to know. But she didn't answer.

A few hours later, her son got in touch with me. My aunt was the one in the hospital. She'd had an aneurysm on the right side of her brain, and it had burst. The drainage tube the doctors used to stop the bleeding kept slipping loose; after three tries, they finally got it to stick. Only then could they do surgery. My cousin FaceTimed me afterward, from the ICU. "Are you ready?" he asked. He angled the camera down to my aunt's face, and I started sobbing like a sudden rainstorm.

A few days later, I got on a plane from Washington, D.C., to Kentucky and went straight to join my family at the hospital. We had always called my aunt "The Glamourina." She wore feathered hats with sparkly shirts and experimented with different hairstyles: a butterscotch-blond cropped cut, an afro, a bob streaked with highlights. She paid for my first real manicure, when I was in high school. We wore matching striped shirts to the salon, and used an eyeliner pencil to draw fake moles above our lips, like Marilyn Monroe.

She is 58 now, and raised two kids as a single mother. She always treated me like one of her children, and I grew up to look more like her than like my own mom. When I'd talked with her the week before she ended up in the hospital, she'd asked me to play our favorite song, "I'm So Proud of You," by Julie Anne Vargas. Now the top half of her head was shaved and staples ran in a ladder across it. IVs were taped to each arm, and a machine next to her bed was helping her breathe. She couldn't speak. When she opened her eyes, they rolled.

Her older son was especially alarmed by how quickly she'd declined. He wanted the doctors to come into her room so they could explain what had happened. But one of our older relatives stopped him, saying that we couldn't afford to make demands, let alone trouble, because "she don't have a lick of health insurance."

We knew that the hospital couldn't deny her care, but we understood the tightrope you walk when you don't have money. All she could afford to be was grateful.

We don't know what caused my aunt's aneurysm, but she'd had persistent headaches for months, and she'd been worried. Once, when she was driving, the left side of her body turned numb and her toes curled up. She pulled over but didn't go to the hospital; she couldn't afford it.

My aunt worked as a hair stylist at a salon for years. Most recently, she was the overnight caregiver for an elderly woman, but she had opted out of her employer-sponsored health insurance because she couldn't afford the premium. She'd occasionally had coverage in the past, but it never guaranteed that she'd actually be able to afford health care. She called me once, defeated, because she was trying to fill a prescription at Walgreens and the pharmacy had flagged an issue with her insurance. She would need to pay out of pocket, and she didn't have the \$134.89. She was often frustrated by spending long spells on hold with insurance agents, and was overwhelmed by the complexity of the plans.

[Annie Lowrey: Annoying people to death](#)

My aunt's experience with the health-care system is familiar to many Americans. In [a 2023 survey by the Kaiser Family Foundation](#), nearly a quarter of adults said signing up for a plan was simply too confusing. Even those who have coverage may [decide to delay or skip treatment](#) because they can't afford the out-of-pocket costs, resulting in emergency-room visits and hospitalizations that could have been prevented.

Some years, my aunt made so little money that she might have qualified for Medicaid, but not recently—the income cutoff if you're single in Kentucky is \$1,835 a month. Some years, she bought coverage through the Affordable Care Act's exchanges, but eventually she decided it was too expensive.

Many more people are now making that same decision. In 2025, the Republican-controlled Congress voted to let Biden-era subsidies in the ACA, which had [helped some 22 million people afford their coverage](#), expire. Within just two weeks of the cutoff, at the end of December,

enrollment had [dropped by 1 million people](#). According to [one group's estimate](#), families are paying \$200, \$300, or \$1,000 more a month; many have seen their premiums double.

[Read: The coming Obamacare cliff](#)

In January, President Trump released his proposal for a “Great Healthcare Plan,” which suggests that savings from the former subsidies could be sent directly to “eligible” Americans. But who would be eligible? [The proposal](#) makes no mention of the many people who don’t have coverage. Then, in February, the Trump administration released [a list of 43 prescription drugs](#) that Americans can buy for reduced prices. But some of these were already available at those prices or in generic forms, and they make up a tiny fraction of the drugs Americans need; the prescription my aunt couldn’t afford, for instance, is not listed.

Nothing about Trump’s pronouncements changes the fact that millions more Americans will soon be stuck where my aunt was: in the middle—sometimes insured, sometimes uninsured, but always too poor to get the care they need.

As I stared at my aunt in the ICU, I noticed that her eyebrows were freshly waxed, and her nails had bleach-white French tips. Only the week before, she’d texted me about getting her nails done. It was an indulgence she rarely allowed herself: “Woo this pedi feels good. I haven’t had one since last year.” When I rubbed Vaseline on her chapped feet, I discovered her ruby-red toenails.

She could not have known that the decision to finally splurge a little on herself would be a conversation starter with the nurses, who complimented her on her nails and eyebrows. Her grooming signaled to them that she was someone who took care of herself, someone who deserved their attention and respect.

I drove to her house later that week to meet her younger son. We’d planned to check on her bills—to see if we could find her bank PIN or account information to make sure that her finances stayed on track. I found notebooks coated with her handwriting, a list of numbers down each page

that looked like an unsolved equation. These, I realized, were her monthly expenses, along with details such as the confirmation codes for bills she'd paid. Stuffed inside one notebook was a pawn-shop notice, announcing its full ownership over an item she'd traded in.

For years, not having enough money nibbled at my aunt's health. She texted me about having severe pain in her back and breasts. She wrote that she had a "knot" in one breast—"I'm thinking just polyps." She lost a lot of weight and said she was feeling depressed. I suggested reaching out to a psychiatrist to ask for antidepressants. She wrote back: "That cost. That's why I need insurance." She was tired of pretending to be okay. After paying for her mortgage, water bill, Wi-Fi, car insurance, and other necessities each month, she'd usually be out of money. She was always transparent with me about her struggles, and sent photos of bills with disconnect notices: a letter from the energy company; an available checking balance of -\$59.70; a past-due payment, with the amount owed in bold. *Shutoffs have resumed. Make a \$172.75 payment today to get your account back on track.* She had small wins, such as finally paying off her car. But she still went back and forth to the payday-loan store.

As I sat next to her in the hospital, I couldn't help but feel guilty. For years, I had been sending her money when she asked, but sometimes I didn't. I would listen to her struggles and then go on with my life. I was grateful to be financially stable, but frustrated by being the financial rescuer for family members. I wanted to create boundaries, and to escape from the transactional, lopsided part of these relationships.

[From the October 2023 issue: Jenisha from Kentucky.](#)

But I had not thought enough about how much she gave me—in every way she could. She posted about my accomplishments on Facebook no matter how small I considered them. She filled voids for me: self-esteem booster, cheerleader, second mother. In 2014, she used all the money she had to fly to New York to see me graduate from Columbia. She was the only member of my family there. When my name was called and I walked across the stage, she cried so much that someone had to hand her a tissue.

A few months ago, my son turned 4, and my aunt was determined to send him a gift. A manila envelope arrived at my apartment: She had mailed him five individually wrapped Hot Wheels cars and a Spider-Man birthday card. I recorded a video as my son stuffed his hand inside the envelope, pulling out each toy, saying, “Oh, wow. This is awesome.” That night, I sent the video to my aunt. She wrote back at 2 a.m.: “Up looking at videos over n over. He was so excited.” She was always trying to give to others, even though she never had enough for herself.

As individuals, and as a country, we tend to pay attention only when it’s too late. Americans who want to cut health-care spending don’t seem to understand that access to preventive care saves not just lives, but also money. Perhaps my aunt’s hospital stay could have been avoided if she’d been able to call a doctor and make an appointment, an option that so many of us take for granted. What is a life like my aunt’s worth in America? Unfortunately, that determination has been made.

[Jonathan Chait: Obamacare changed the politics of health care](#)

My aunt hasn’t sat up or spoken since the aneurysm, and no one knows if she will again. In January, she was transferred from the hospital to a nursing home. She’s supposed to go home soon, to be cared for by the family, who can’t possibly give her the round-the-clock care she needs. She’s not capable of worrying about health insurance at this point, but if she were, she wouldn’t have to: Now that she’s completely disabled, she qualifies for Medicaid.

This article appears in the [April 2026](#) print edition with the headline “The Cost of Not Having Health Insurance.”

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My Tesla Was Driving Itself Perfectly—Until It Crashed

The danger of almost-perfect tech

by Raffi Krikorian

This article was featured in the One Story to Read Today newsletter. [Sign up for it here.](#)

The smell was strange. Sharp. Chemical. Wrong. The concrete wall was too close. My glasses were gone. One of my kids was standing on the sidewalk next to our car—not crying, just confused.

The seat belt had held. The crumple zone had crumpled. The airbag had fired. Everything designed to protect bodies had done its job. But the car, a Tesla Model X, was totaled.

One Sunday last fall, my kids and I were on a drive we'd done hundreds of times, winding through the residential streets of the Bay Area to drop my son off at his Boy Scouts meeting. The Tesla was in Full Self-Driving mode, driving perfectly—until it wasn't.

What happened next, I've had to piece together. My memory is hazy, and some of it comes from one of my sons, who watched the whole thing unfold from the back seat. The car was making a turn. Something felt off—the steering wheel jerked one way, then the other, and the car decelerated in a way I didn't expect. I turned the wheel to take over. I don't know exactly what the system was doing, or why. I only know that somewhere in those seconds, we ended up colliding with a wall.

You might think I'd have known what to do in this situation. I used to run the self-driving-car division at Uber, trying to build a future in which

technology protects us from accidents. I had thought about edge cases, failure modes, the brittleness hiding behind smooth performance. My team trained human drivers on when and how to intervene if a self-driving car made a mistake. In the two years I ran the division, we had no injuries in our early pilot programs.

With my own Tesla, I started out using Full Self-Driving as the default setting only on highways. That's where it makes sense: You have clear lane markers and predictable traffic patterns. Then, one day, I tried it on a local road, and it worked well enough to become a habit.

Despite the accident, we were lucky. I walked away with a stiff neck, a concussion, a few days of headaches, and some memories I can't shake. The kids climbed out unharmed. Still, you could say I was crushed in what the researcher Madeleine Clare Elish [calls the moral crumple zone](#). Some parts of a car are specifically designed to absorb damage in a crash, to protect the people inside. But when complex automated systems fail, Elish argues, it's the human users who take the blame. My car's Full Self-Driving mode logged flawless miles for three years, but when the accident happened, it was my name on the insurance report.

And the car has evidence. While you're at the wheel, it logs your hand position, your reaction time, whether you're keeping your eyes on the road—thousands of data points, processed by the vehicle. After crashes, Tesla has used these data to shift blame onto drivers. Following a fatal collision in Mountain View, California, in 2018, [the company released a statement](#) in which it noted that “the vehicle logs show that no action was taken.” (Tesla did not respond to a request for comment.)

While Tesla can access these records, it's not so easy for drivers. They can request their data, but some say they've received only fragments—and have had to go to court to get more. When [plaintiffs in a Florida wrongful-death case sought key evidence](#) of how one of Tesla's driver-assistance systems had failed, the company said it didn't have the data. The plaintiffs had to hire a hacker, who recovered them from a computer chip in the crashed vehicle. Later, Tesla stated that the data had been sitting on its own servers for years, and that the company failed to locate them by mistake. (A judge

did not find “sufficient evidence” to conclude that Tesla had sought to hide the data.)

For now, the legal principle is simple: You’re responsible. Though Tesla originally called its technology “Full Self-Driving Capability,” the system is officially classified as “Level 2” partial driver automation, which means the human must remain in control at all times. Last year, a judge in California [found Tesla’s original name “unambiguously false”](#) and misleading to consumers; Tesla now uses “Full Self-Driving (Supervised).” When a Tesla using a version of the technology [killed two people in California in 2019](#), the car’s own logs were used to prosecute the driver for failing to prevent the crash—not the company that designed the system. The company was held accountable in a major verdict for the first time only last year, when a jury found Tesla partly liable in the Florida wrongful-death case and awarded \$243 million to the plaintiffs.

A similar pattern is emerging everywhere algorithms are asked to work alongside humans: in our inboxes, our search results, our medical charts. These systems are building toward full automation, but they’re not there yet. Computers still regularly make mistakes that require human oversight to avoid or fix.

Full Self-Driving works almost all of the time—Tesla’s fleet of cars with the technology logs millions of miles between serious incidents, by the company’s count. And that’s the problem: We are asking humans to supervise systems designed to make supervision feel pointless. A machine that constantly fails keeps you sharp. A machine that works perfectly needs no oversight. But a machine that works almost perfectly? That’s where the danger lies. After a few hours of flawless performance, research shows, drivers are prone to start overtrusting self-driving systems. After a month of using adaptive cruise control, drivers were more than six times as likely to look at their phone, [according to one study](#) from the Insurance Institute for Highway Safety.

Tesla’s description of Full Self-Driving on its website warns, “Do not become complacent,” and I didn’t think I was. Before my accident, I had my hands on the wheel. But I was driving the way the system had conditioned me to: monitoring instead of steering, trusting the software to

make the right call. The familiarity curve bends toward complacency, and the companies building these systems seem to know it. I certainly did. I got lulled anyway.

Psychologists call this the vigilance decrement. Monitoring a nearly perfect system is boring. Boredom leads to mind-wandering. [The research is unforgiving](#): Drivers need five to eight seconds to mentally reengage after an automated driving system gives control back. But emergencies can unfold much faster than that. The driver's physical reaction might be instantaneous—grabbing the wheel, hitting the brake. But the mental part? Rebuilding context, recognizing what's wrong, deciding what to do? That takes time your brain doesn't have.

The driver in the 2018 Mountain View accident had six seconds before his car steered itself into a concrete median. He never touched the wheel. That same year in Tempe, Arizona, sensors in an Uber test vehicle [detected a pedestrian nearby with 5.6 seconds of warning](#). The safety driver looked up and took the wheel with less than a second left. By then, it was just physics.

In my case, I did take action before my accident. But I was asked to snap from passenger back to pilot in a fraction of a second—to override months of conditioning in the time it takes to blink. The logs would show that I turned the wheel. They wouldn't show the impossible math.

I don't know enough about what actually happened during my accident to say that Tesla's technology crashed the car. But the problem is bigger than one company's self-driving system. It's about how we're building every AI system, every algorithm, every tool that asks for our trust and trains us to give it. The pattern is everywhere: Condition people to rely on the system. Erode their vigilance. Then, when something breaks, point to the terms of service and blame them for not paying attention.

My car didn't warn me when it was confused. Chatbots don't, either; they deliver their results in the same confident voice, whether they're right or hallucinating. They perform expertise, even when the sources they cite are dubious or fabricated. They use technical language in an authoritative tone. And we believe them, because why wouldn't we? They've been right so many times before.

Cars train us mile by mile; AI trains us week by week. In week one, you read a chatbot's output carefully. By week three, you're copying and pasting without reading. The errors don't disappear, but your vigilance does. So does your judgment, until one day you realize that you can't remember which ideas in a memo were yours and which were generated by AI. What does it say about us that we've [handed over our thinking](#) so willingly?

[Read: The people outsourcing their thinking to AI](#)

When my car failed, it was immediate and palpable. With chatbots, the failure is silent and invisible. You find out about it later, if at all—after the email is sent, the decision made, the code shipped. By the time you catch the mistake, it's already out there with your name on it. When the system works, you look efficient. When it fails, your judgment is questioned, sometimes with catastrophic consequences. In 2023, a New York lawyer [was sanctioned for citing six cases that didn't exist](#). ChatGPT had invented them, but he'd trusted it, and the court blamed him, not the tool. Because a chatbot never gets fired.

We're experiencing an uncanny valley of autonomy. Computer systems aren't just almost human; they are almost capable of working on their own. When they fail, someone has to absorb the cost. Right now, [that someone is us](#). But when we pay for a self-driving car or an AI tool, we think we're buying a finished product, not signing up to test a work in progress.

This “almost” phase isn't a brief transition. It's the product—one that will be with us for years, maybe decades. So it's important to notice the patterns. When an AI system never admits uncertainty, or when a car's marketing says “self-driving” but the fine print says “driver responsible,” that's a warning sign. When you realize that you haven't really been paying attention for the past 10 miles, or the past 10 auto-composed emails, that's the trap.

Things don't have to be this way, but they won't change unless consumers see the situation clearly and refuse to accept it. We should reject the deal we've been handed—the one where the terms of service become a shield for companies and a sword against users. We should demand that

companies share the risk they're enticing us into taking. If they design for complacency, they should get some of the blame when their product fails.

This isn't a utopian goal. In July 2025, the Chinese carmaker BYD announced that it would pay for the damage caused by crashes involving its self-parking feature, sparing the driver's insurance and record. It's only one company, and only one feature, but it proves that accountability is a choice. Other businesses can be persuaded to opt in, too.

My kids were in the back seat when I had my car accident. One day, they'll have their own cars and use AI in ways that I can't even imagine yet. The systems they inherit will be built either to elevate them or to lull them and blame them when things go wrong. I want them to notice when they're being trained. I want them to ask who absorbs the cost, and the damage.

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The Republican Party Has a Nazi Problem

How did the GOP become a haven for slogans and ideas straight out of the Third Reich?

by Tom Nichols



Over the past few months, during his agency's chaotic crackdowns in Chicago and Minneapolis, the U.S. Border Patrol chief Greg Bovino has worn an unusual uniform: a wide-lapel greatcoat with brass buttons and stars along one sleeve. It looks like it was taken right off the shoulders of a Wehrmacht officer in the 1930s. Bovino's choice of garment is more than

tough-guy cosplay (German media noted the aesthetic immediately). The coat symbolizes a trend: The Republicans, it seems, have a bit of a Nazi problem.

By this, I mean that some Republicans are deploying Nazi imagery and rhetoric, and espouse ideas associated with the Nazi Party during its rise to power in the early 1930s. A few recent examples: An ICE lawyer linked to a white-supremacist social-media account that praised Hitler was apparently [allowed to return to federal court](#). Members of the national Young Republicans organization were caught in a group chat [laughing about their love for Hitler](#). Vice President J. D. Vance shrugged off that controversy, instead of condemning the growing influence of anti-Semites in his party. (In December, at Turning Point USA's conference, Vance said, "I didn't bring a list of conservatives to denounce or to deplatform.")

Even federal agencies are [modeling Nazi phrasing](#). The Department of Homeland Security used an anthem beloved by neo-Nazi groups, "By God We'll Have Our Home Again," in a recruitment ad. The Labor Department hung a giant banner of Donald Trump's face from its headquarters, as if Washington were Berlin in 1936, and posted expressions on social media such as "America is for Americans"—an obvious riff on the Nazi slogan "Germany for the Germans"—and "Americanism Will Prevail," in a font reminiscent of Third Reich documents.

Trump, of course, openly pines to be a dictator. In his first term, he reportedly told his chief of staff, General John Kelly, that he [wished he had generals who were as loyal as Hitler's military leaders](#). (The president was perhaps unaware of how often the führer's officers tried to kill him.) More recently, the White House's official X account supported Trump's pursuit of Greenland by posting a meme with the caption "Which way, Greenland man?" That is not merely a clunky turn of phrase; it's an echo of *Which Way Western Man?*, the title of a 1978 book by the American neo-Nazi William Gayley Simpson, a former Presbyterian minister who called for America to expel its Jewish citizens.

[Read: 'I need the kind of generals that Hitler had'](#)

The people pushing such trash are offended by the accusation that they are pantomiming Nazis. “Calling everything you dislike ‘Nazi propaganda’ is tiresome,” a DHS spokesperson told *Politico*. But when even Laura Loomer—conspiracy theorist and ardent Trump supporter—says on social media that “the GOP has a Nazi problem,” *then perhaps the GOP has a Nazi problem*.



The U.S. Border Patrol chief Greg Bovino in Minneapolis on January 15, 2026 (Octavio Jones / AFP / Getty)

As a former Republican, I’m aware that the American conservative movement has spent generations fighting off intrusions from the far right, including the John Birchers and the Ku Klux Klan. But I am still surprised and aggrieved by how quickly 21st-century Nazism has found a home in the party of Lincoln. In 1991, President George H. W. Bush repudiated the former Klan leader David Duke, who was running as a Republican to be Louisiana’s governor. Today, Trump and his party haven’t bothered to even pretend to be appalled by the degenerates gathering under the GOP aegis.

So how did a major American political party become a safe space for such people?

When I first joined the GOP, in 1979, the party around me did not seem hospitable to Nazis. A liberal Black Republican, Edward Brooke, had just finished two terms as our junior senator from Massachusetts; the liberal Republicans Lowell Weicker and John Chafee represented Connecticut and Rhode Island, respectively. In college, I worked in the Massachusetts state House for our hometown representative, a young and principled working-class Democrat (my GOP membership was not a disqualifier; imagine that). I got to know Republican legislators on Beacon Hill because they were close friends with my Democratic boss. Party affiliations were about political disagreements among Americans, not markers of antithetical worldviews.

I was, like many people then, a resolute ticket-splitter, voting often for local Democrats but always for Republican presidents, because I believed the national GOP was a moderate institution. Ronald Reagan, for example, disappointed the far right and his evangelical base by reducing nuclear weapons, leaving abortion rights largely untouched, and granting mass amnesty to undocumented immigrants (something I objected to at the time).

I first encountered the fringe elements of the conservative base in 1990, when I went to work in the U.S. Senate for John Heinz of Pennsylvania. I remember fielding an angry phone call from a constituent who grilled me about whether the senator was part of a globalist one-world-government conspiracy.

[From the November 2018 issue: McKay Coppins on the man who broke politics](#)

The country and the GOP were in the hands of Bush, the ultimate moderate, but extremists were making inroads to power. The populist demagogue Pat Buchanan, crusading against modernity and multiculturalism, challenged Bush in 1992 and [garnered 23 percent of the Republican-primary vote](#). Bush, in turn, gave him the stage at the Republican National Convention in Houston. Buchanan's speech, which envisioned a "religious war" for the country, shocked many Americans.

A few years later, Representative Newt Gingrich of Georgia carried Buchanan's culture war into the House speakership. For Gingrich, politics was [solely about winning](#); his scorched-earth approach treated opponents as enemies and compromise as treason. He wanted votes, and wasn't concerned about who was animated by his viciousness.

Gingrich was eventually driven from the speakership; Buchanan left the Republican Party to run under the Reform Party, and then faded from public life. But an example had been set of welcoming extremism (extreme ideology, extreme tactics) for the sake of winning.

Later Republican presidential nominees—good men such as John McCain and Mitt Romney—represented the moderate coalition that had brought people like me into the party. As they stood in the center of the GOP tent, they began to see who was now lurking in the back. In 2008, the nation saw too, when McCain had to defend Barack Obama as a “decent family man” to a delusional town-hall participant who had obviously imbibed racist right-wing propaganda.

[From the October 2022 issue: Kim Phillips-Fein on the long unraveling of the Republican Party.](#)

Soon after McCain's loss to Obama, the Tea Party movement barreled into American politics. I was among those appalled by the Tea Partiers' juvenile public behavior and anti-government nihilism; others believed they represented a new grassroots movement and the future of the party. In the end, their revolt against government bailouts soured into a giant yawp of anger at the first Black president. By the time Romney was running against Obama, in 2012, Trump had launched his political career by pushing the “birther” lie, which capitalized on racial animus toward the 44th president. Rather than try to push Trump out of the tent, Romney accepted his endorsement. McCain came to be viewed as a traitor by the Republican base; Trump made that permissible by mocking his war-hero status.

In his third run for office, Trump expanded his vote share despite embracing fascist themes of xenophobia, nationalism, and glorification of violence. I didn't want to see what was happening to the Republican Party, until the durability of Donald Trump made it impossible to ignore.

Was this a radical, unpredictable metamorphosis, or was a fascist tendency latent in the DNA of the party? To better understand the GOP in the years before I joined it, I arranged a Zoom call with Stuart Stevens, a native Mississippian and former Republican operative. Stevens, several years older than I am, joined the Republicans in his youth rather than the segregationist local Democrats, then bolted from the party because of Trump. I asked Stevens to tell me when and where the GOP went wrong, and whether the devolution into a haven for Nazis was inevitable.

For Stevens, racism is the original sin of the modern Republican Party. White voters were alienated by the passage of the Civil Rights Act in 1964 and the violence around the 1968 Democratic primaries. As Black voters deserted Republicans, the segregationist George Wallace proved with his '68 presidential run that white southerners were up for grabs. Richard Nixon made a cunning and cynical calculation to sweep up those disaffected white voters, using appeals to “law and order” to stoke racial anxiety. By the 1970s, the GOP was the de facto white party in the United States.

Nixon and Reagan held racist views, as did many men of their generation. (Nixon was also an anti-Semite.) But they did not govern as racists, and they certainly weren't Nazis; neither was Gingrich, Buchanan, or any national Republican over the past half century. But years of racial pandering had created a too-big tent, enlarged in the name of electoral expediency, that offered dark corners for despicable ideologies.

Political realignment also made the GOP vulnerable to extremism. Democrats became appealing to wealthy suburbanites. Republicans, whose voters were now less educated and more working-class, gained among white voters in rural areas and the Rust Belt. Gerrymandering helped turn red districts redder and blue districts bluer. Democrats' more diverse constituencies were a built-in trip wire against politicians who cozied up to extremists, while Republican-primary candidates—influenced by the rise of talk radio, Fox News, and the Tea Party—were not subjected to serious moderate challengers. Unprincipled and bizarre candidates could now thread a path to victory in ruby-red districts.

Critics of the GOP have long argued that something like the Trump movement, and the emergence of a new American Nazism, was inevitable—

that conservatism, as a belief system, inevitably decays into fascism. Stevens, when he left the party, wrote a book with a bitter title: [*It Was All a Lie*](#). When I told him how often people quote his title to argue that conservatism itself was a lie, he rolled his eyes. “We conservatives were right about everything,” Stevens told me. “Especially about the importance of character.”

I asked the writer Geoffrey Kabaservice, who has chronicled the decline of Republican moderates, whether the fall of the GOP was preordained, and why conservatism, once a moralizing movement, became so vulnerable to figures without moral character.

“I don’t happen to believe that conservatism is one of those doctrines that is flawed from the get-go,” Kabaservice told me, “and certainly not in the American context, in which conservatism is a variation on core liberal principles.” In that sense, he said, Reaganism, the strongest vehicle of 20th-century American conservatism, didn’t lead directly to Trumpism—not least because Trump’s vulgar populism is “a repudiation of conservatism.”

But Reagan’s dominance of the party may have indirectly set the stage for Trump. Kabaservice brought up the Prussian statesman Otto von Bismarck, who created a balance-of-power system that worked only because it relied on Bismarck’s personal influence and political genius; it collapsed without him. Likewise, Kabaservice argued, Reagan enjoined his party to leave room in the tent for moderates and to avoid ideological litmus tests, but the GOP needed Reagan’s “personal magnetism” to keep his followers from spiraling into hyper-partisanship, or even political fratricide.

Without Reagan, the Reaganite coalition began to dissolve in the face of Buchanan’s angry populism and Gingrich’s cold opportunism. The Republican Party, as an institution, weakened over time, until it could be hijacked by an aspiring dictator. Republican leaders who warned against Trump in 2016—senators such as Ted Cruz, Lindsey Graham, and Mike Lee—soon discarded conservative principles to protect their jobs. Their eager amorality has allowed extreme elements to use the GOP as a vehicle for bigotry and rage. Racism and hate are now structural parts of the Republican Party, replacing consensus, compassion, and compromise. Trump started his second presidency by pardoning the insurrectionists who’d wanted to

unlawfully extend his first. Little wonder that fascists and other miscreants feel welcome.

Conservatives will complain that Democratic Party leaders have often tolerated their own extremists. People on the right point to radical professors lionizing Angela Davis, a Communist Party figure who was once on the FBI's most-wanted list, or a future president socializing with Bill Ayers, who co-founded a Marxist militant organization and participated in bombings of the U.S. Capitol and the New York Police Department headquarters. Ayers may have casually socialized with a 30-something Barack Obama, but he did not get an office in the West Wing 15 years later. And no one on the left has shown up to work dressed like a conquering Nazi general swanning through the streets of Smolensk, the way Bovino did in the Midwest.

Some Republicans lament these developments and still hold fast to conservative principles and policy ideas. But their party has laid out a welcome mat for an ideology that Americans once had to defeat in combat, at the cost of millions of lives. If wannabe Nazis now confidently roam the halls of power—and the streets of American cities—it is because Republican leaders have made them feel at home.

What can Americans do in the face of moral rot in a major political party? The only short-term answers are shaming, shunning, and mockery—and punishment at the polls. Decent citizens must ostracize those among them who toy with Hitlerism. Americans—especially journalists—should resist becoming inured to fascist rhetoric. No one should rely on euphemisms about “extreme” comments or “fiery” speeches. Call it what it is: Nazi-like behavior.

When a [Gen Z Republican focus group](#) has 20-somethings talking about how Hitler “was a great leader,” even if “what he was going for was terrible,” something is amiss not only in the Republican Party but also in America's homes, schools, and neighborhoods. Some of these trolls are merely pasting swastikas on their nihilism, but their ideological sincerity is irrelevant. As Kurt Vonnegut wrote in [Mother Night](#), his 1961 novel about a man posing as a Nazi: “We are what we pretend to be, so we must be careful about what we pretend to be.”

Whatever their intentions, some Americans are expressing or abetting ancient hatreds, smirking at the mention of Hitler, and plastering public spaces with images that Allied soldiers once tore from the walls of destroyed German cities. Political leaders who encourage or tolerate such scoundrels should be driven from office.

The Republicans have a Nazi problem, yes. But this means that the United States also has a Nazi problem. The responsibility for defeating it in the 21st century falls, as it did in the 20th, to everyone—of any party or creed—who still believes in the American idea.

This article appears in the [April 2026](#) print edition with the headline “That 1930s Feeling.” When you buy a book using a link on this page, we receive a commission. Thank you for supporting The Atlantic.

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The Midlife Crisis Comes for Millennial Pop

**On her first album in eight years,
Robyn reckons with motherhood
and midlife desire.**

by Spencer Kornhaber



Once upon the '90s, a teenage girl named Robin Miriam Carlsson was crowned a pop princess. Her crystalline voice and secretive smile caught the attention of the Swedish record industry, whose producers and songwriters helped her create the swooning global hits "Show Me Love" and "Do You

Know (What It Takes).” But Carlsson, first discovered at age 13, realized she didn’t want to be a singing automaton, a mere vessel for the pop machine. She turned down a deal from the U.S. branch of Jive Records, which then set out to find an American version of her—and landed on Britney Spears.

By then, Robin Carlsson had become Robyn. A few years later, in 2005, she founded her own label to make her own kind of music. Her new sound combined firm dance beats, campy hip-hop flourishes, and synth riffs that spiraled and tessellated like the instruments in a Bach fugue. Her lyrics declared independence from clingy lovers and assorted social expectations, often through analogies inspired by technology. To simply quote her song titles from 2010’s *Body Talk*, a now-classic album, she was an “Indestructible” “Fembot” warning, “Don’t Fucking Tell Me What to Do.” Beneath the metallic veneer, though, her songs had the tenderness and precision of a homily. The effect was to make solitude sound sexy, sad, and hopeful at once.

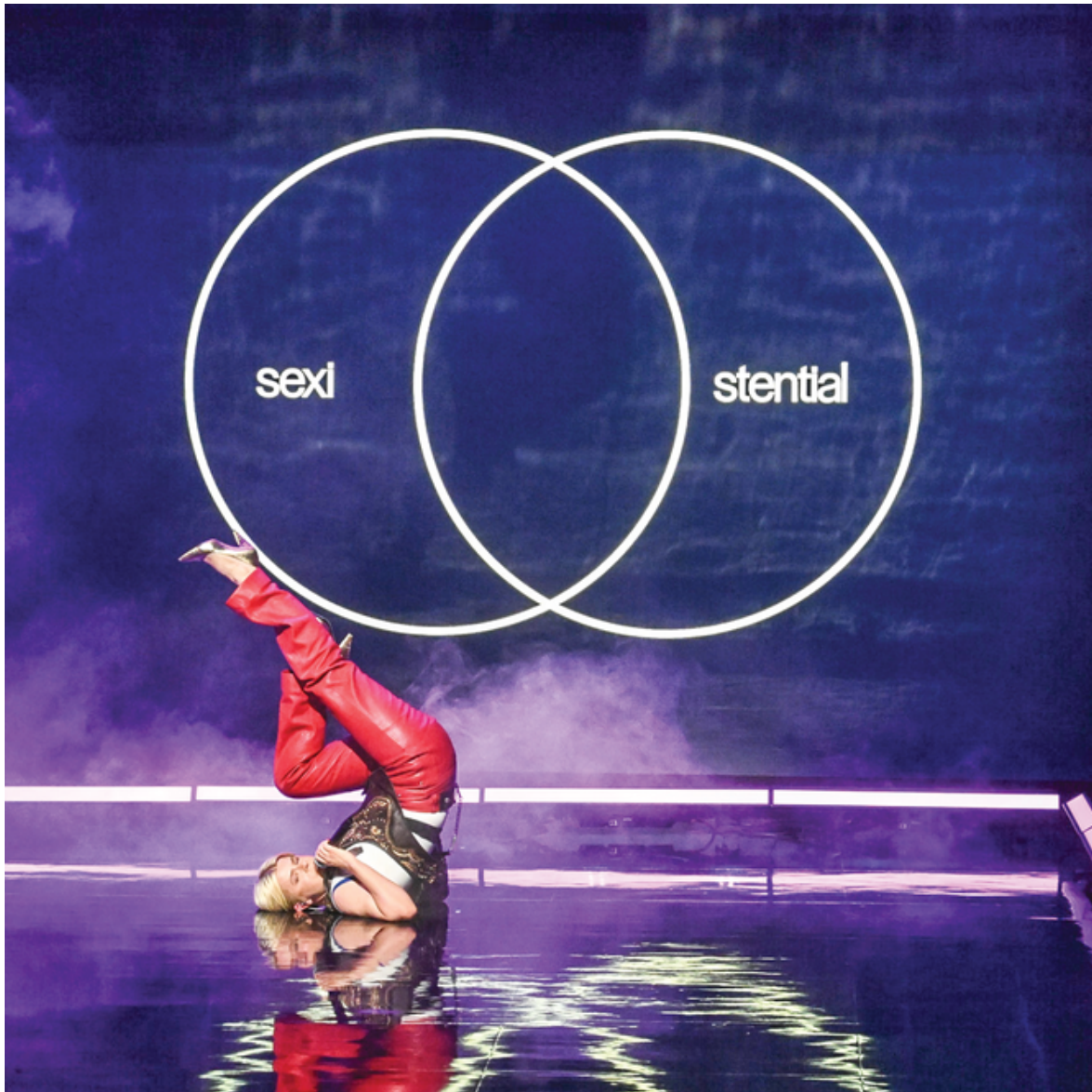
The timing had been right for her to liberate herself. The traditional music business was collapsing, as the internet cut into CD sales while letting listeners elevate their own niche idols. Mainstream pop was going maximalist by overloading its production with digital whizbangery; indie rock had risen as a rawer alternative. Robyn split the difference. She expressed a rebellious worldview in a sleek and organized way, like a manifesto in a well-formatted Word doc.

That manifesto was one that 21st-century pop culture wanted to hear. Spears had become a cautionary tale: The girl who gave her youth to the record industry ended up losing her legal sovereignty (via the establishment of a conservatorship in 2008 that remained intact until 2021). Robyn did not become nearly as famous, but her emo bangers pointed the way for the likes of Lorde, Ariana Grande, and even Taylor Swift once she started playing with keyboards. Poptimism, the ascendant belief that a genre ruled by formulas and artifice can contain plenty of originality and humanity, made Robyn its mascot. And with time, her outlook on music came to seem like an insight into life itself.

Or at least, that's how many Millennials felt. Though Robyn is Gen X, she captivated my generation of idealists, who were out to upgrade the world that our parents had built and express ourselves in the process. Young adults in the early earbuds age used her songs as fuel for runs, laptop work, Tinder hookups, and the solitary, self-reflective mornings after. We also bopped along to her with our friends. HBO's *Girls* cemented her status [in a legendary scene](#): Hannah Horvath carefully drafts a killer tweet in her bedroom, then starts jumping around to Robyn's defining single, "Dancing on My Own." Her roommate, back from her yuppie adventuring, walks in and joins the party.

The assurance of being yourself and being liked, fulfilling your purpose while climbing life's rungs, has obvious appeal in youth, before compromises and obligations start to pile too high. But Robyn is now 46 and back with her first album in eight years. She is somehow singing the same song—even if the fable it spins seems more fantastical than ever.

Many pop stars mellow into stately eminence in middle age, as Madonna (temporarily) did in her late 30s with 1998's *Ray of Light*. Robyn appeared to be trending that way with her last album, 2018's *Honey*—a dreamy beatscape that signaled appreciation for the mid-range of life after chasing many highs. Anthemic action was giving way to chill mantras, as if to regulate the ever noisier, ever more distracting world.



Robyn performs “Sexistential” on *The Late Show With Stephen Colbert* in January.
(Scott Kowalchyk / CBS)

But *Sexistential*, released in March, pushes in the opposite direction, toward starry-eyed excess and abandon. The cover art shows Robyn screaming and topless. The title track features her rapping the word *boner*. Echoes of earnest 2000s indie pop, including from Robyn’s own catalog, abound. When she humped the air during a performance on [*The Late Show With Stephen Colbert*](#) in January, much of the internet snickered: Had the coolest girl in pop finally become cringe?

[Read: Robyn's *Honey*: The thrill is gone, and that's okay.](#)

Perhaps so—cringe appears to be the fate of anyone older than 25 in the TikTok age. And pop culture has rarely allowed its female stars to grow older without mockery. But *Sexistential* may discomfit listeners for reasons other than ageism. After *Honey*, Robyn broke up with her on-and-off partner of more than a decade and then had a son through IVF. To judge by the disorienting sound of this album, middle-aged motherhood for her has been less an experience of setting down roots than of ripping them up. The title song sets her pregnancy saga—scrolling through dating apps amid doctor visits and hormonal spikes—to fast-paced club music while filtering her voice for cartoonish effect. “Blow My Mind” is a cover of her own song from 24 years ago, but this version rewrites lyrics about romantic infatuation into ones about finding your baby to be ridiculously cute. On the final track, “Into the Sun,” distorted bass roars like a rocket engine—evoking her many previous sci-fi references—as Robyn propels herself into the unknown: “Look what I’ve done / So brave and dumb.”

The music amplifies both her giddiness and her uncertainty. *Sexistential*’s production judders and glitches in ways that call to mind ’80s synth experimentalists such as Art of Noise and the rowdy sample collaging of the Beastie Boys in the ’90s. Its messiness is also in step with 2020s hyperpop—scruffy, topsy-turvy electronic music that seeks to harness, not counteract, modern overstimulation. The wooziest moments sacrifice Robyn’s easy-listening appeal for the sake of surprise. On the album opener, “Really Real,” a shattered-glass sound effect rings out before she sings, “We’re splitting up reality / And I slip out through the crack in between it.”

What makes this chaos delightful rather than annoying is Robyn’s unshakable sense of control, grounded in pop principles and thoughtful craft. *Sexistential*’s many catchy melodies bounce atop bright, blocky synth lines. Its psychedelic interludes exist to snap back into satisfying rhythms. Its lyrics brim with depersonalized language (“This is where the shared experience ends”), self-help real talk (“Fuck a therapist, it’s not mental / I need philosophy, this shit is existential”), and biological determinism (as in the lead single, “Dopamine”). She’s mapping out the way that even life’s strangest chapters unfold logically.

The album, Robyn has said, was partly inspired by hearing [André 3000](#), of the hip-hop duo Outkast, explain that he'd pivoted to instrumental music because no one wants to hear a 48-year-old man rap about his colonoscopy. In Robyn's view, the unglamorous milestones of middle age are plenty deserving of pop treatment. Two years ago, a 33-year-old Charli XCX dominated pop culture with a similarly unruly album called *Brat*. It dwelled on the question of whether Charli would ever give up her hard-partying ways and settle down with kids. Robyn is now arguing that the choice is a false one.

That argument is certainly upbeat in its implications—but the sound of *Sexistential* suggests the limits of maturing hedonistically. As I've been playing the album on repeat, savoring its intricate details and humming its candied choruses, I've felt a little self-conscious: *Sexistential*'s childlike glee raises the specter that Robyn and her listeners still have some growing up to do.

But I've also felt grateful for how playfully she's engaging with midlife vertigo. The generation that grew up listening to Robyn is full of people whose blend of careerism and individualism has made them delay or skip marriage and children. Have we compromised too much, or not enough? Is there time for a reset? These sorts of questions are timeless rites of passage at the end of youth. Barreling ahead, Robyn is yet again modeling how to find meaning in the conventional—by doing it our own way.

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The Last Days of Franco

Montserrat Roig's classic novel captures Barcelona on the cusp of unimaginable change.

by Colm Tóibín



Montserrat Roig's classic novel, *The Time of Cherries*, captures a sort of still point in the history of Barcelona—a moment that came before great change. When the novel ends, no one has any idea that within 18 months, Francisco Franco, the old dictator, will be gone. *The Time of Cherries* was originally published in Catalan in 1976, [the year after Franco died](#). Half a century later, Roig's excavation of family life in a period of historical flux is now available in English in the United States for the first time.

[*The Time of Cherries*](#) became an essential book in post-Franco Catalonia. It appeared at a time when there were few images of the culture whose youth had cast off Franco long before 1975. The novel is infused not only with an array of vivid characters but also with a sharply detailed vision of middle-class Barcelona before democracy was restored. The book revolves around Natàlia, once a student activist and now nearly age 40, as she deals with unfinished business: her conservative brother and her fearful and neurotic sister-in-law, her father, her old friends, and, more than anything, the stifling political atmosphere that she had abruptly run away from 12 years earlier. Soon after its publication, the novel became available in a cheap paperback and was on sale in the newspaper kiosks that dotted downtown Barcelona.

When I first encountered Roig's novel, in the 1980s, I was struck by the freshness of her tone—and by the fact that Natàlia's generation was being depicted in a fearless and dramatic way. There was, for example, a sexual frankness in the book that came as a relief in a country where many films had been censored or banned for their sexual content. When Roig portrays characters from the older generation, many of them emotionally and spiritually maimed by the long years of the dictatorship, she is careful to make the gap between them and the new generation complex and ambiguous rather than simple or easy to predict.

The middle class in Barcelona had remained, for the most part, undisturbed by the First and Second World Wars, and even by the Spanish Civil War. Its members held on to their spacious apartments in the Eixample, the area of the city that was developed in the late 19th and early 20th centuries by Modernista architects, including Antoni Gaudí. Their innate conservatism persisted; they kept their heads down and looked after their affairs during the dictatorship. Things were [ripe for a revolt by the generation that came of age in the 1960s](#).

Roig was born into a middle-class family in Barcelona in 1946, to parents who had already staged their own revolt. Her father was a lawyer and writer deeply embedded in the world of Catalan politics and culture. Her mother, also born into this middle-class milieu, was a feminist writer and suffragist. While Roig was growing up, her parents' apartment was a gathering place for writers and those involved in progressive politics.

In her late teens, Roig began writing about current affairs in the magazine *Triunfo*, which was becoming a pro-democracy force. Before going to university, she trained as an actor. During these years, she got to know the feminist writer and left-wing activist [Maria Aurèlia Capmany](#), almost 30 years her senior, who introduced her to the writings of Simone de Beauvoir. Capmany, even when I met her in the last years of her life while I was writing my book [Homage to Barcelona](#), was what might be called an indomitable spirit—witty and sharp, loud when she needed to be, radical. Like Roig herself, Capmany became one of Barcelona’s prominent cultural figures in the 1980s. She was an energetic and visionary head of culture on the Barcelona city council when I knew her. Much of her is there in the figure of Harmonia, Natàlia’s older friend in *The Time of Cherries*.

Roig uses the trope of the returned daughter, in this case one who has bathed in the freedoms of England, as she herself had done in the early 1970s before coming home to Barcelona as both insider and outsider. The novel explores the strange way that time’s passing makes some aspects of family dynamics subtly different and allows other aspects to stay the same.

Political life is disorienting too. The dates in *The Time of Cherries* are carefully chosen. Natàlia’s exile to England and France begins with the arrest, in 1962, of the Communist Julián Grimau, who was [executed by the Franco government a year later](#); it ends with the [execution of the militant Catalan anarchist Salvador Puig Antich](#), in 1974. Natàlia was born in March 1938, the month the Coliseum theater in Barcelona was bombed by Italian fascist forces during the Spanish Civil War. Both her father and her brother, Lluís, were born in important years in the history of Catalan nationalism.

According to her biographer, Betsabé Garcia, Roig spent three years planning *The Time of Cherries* (the title is a reference to a famous French revolutionary song, a favorite of Natàlia’s silly Communist boyfriend at university). She then wrote the book in 26 days, thus placing it among the masterpieces of 20th-century literature created at speed, including Kerouac’s *On the Road* and Faulkner’s *As I Lay Dying*.

Although Roig wrote about her own city and historical moment, she insisted that her novel was not drawn directly from her life: “I have learned to laugh

when it is called autobiographical. If only they knew how it lied!” She noted that three obsessions dominated her imagination: death, sex, and growing old. All of these themes surface in *The Time of Cherries* as Roig explores shifting elements of the culture in which she grew up. She worried that if she gave her novels a working-class setting, “they would not be convincing.” Rather, she would dramatize “the world that I know,” bourgeois Barcelona, aware that Balzac and Proust had written about a similar class.

While her novel evoked Natàlia’s interior life, it also portrayed a Barcelona, parts of which were about to disappear. In 1974, the airport bus did indeed go as far as Plaça d’Espanya. Rich people did indeed shop for domestic goods at Vinçon. Catalans did indeed look to Switzerland as their ideal state. “Switzerland was the dream,” Roig writes. Men bought their hats at Can Prats, drank a brandy called Torres 10, and had dinner in a restaurant called 7 Portes. To own paintings by Ramón Casas and Isidre Nonell, two 19th-century Catalan painters, was a point of pride. People traveled to Perpignan, just over the border in France, to watch banned films. Intellectuals gathered amid the neoclassical elegance of the Catalan cultural hub, L’Ateneu.

Middle-class kids who had been brought up in the Eixample loved the seedy beauty of downtown Barcelona, as Natàlia does: “What she missed was a certain aroma, a street, the laughter of friends strolling down La Rambla in waves, the shadows around Santa Maria del Mar, the chilly mornings, the leaves of the plane trees when they fell in autumn.” Anyone who knew Barcelona in those years will recognize the “bar on Carrer de Banys Nous where grizzled card sharks and students drank wine and ate olives around barrels that doubled as tables” as El Portalón, and “the old textile-warehouse lobby” near Santa Maria del Mar, now a “large, drafty hall” where “a pair of thick velvet curtains separated two open-plan rooms,” as Zeleste, the nightclub for progressive young Catalans of that time.

The time of cherries, of youthful revolt, was not far away from a time of fear. When the novel came out, a great many citizens of Barcelona had experienced baton charges and vicious police attacks—assaults that were ongoing even as the book was being written and when it was published. But no one had yet written about them. There was no free press. Roig’s account of police violence against students who were protesting the Franco regime,

among them Natàlia and her friends, has a sense of urgency that came from her own experience as a young activist.

Roig had taken part in one of the most famous sit-ins in Catalonia during the years before the end of the dictatorship, La Caputxinada. In 1975, when she wrote *The Time of Cherries*, the memory of that event in 1966 still felt fresh. More than 400 intellectuals and students had demonstrated against the regime in a Capuchin monastery on the outskirts of Barcelona and were surrounded by police for two days.

Though other novelists later wrote about what it was like to navigate these repressive years in Barcelona, no one else described a protagonist having a backstreet abortion in the city. Once again, Roig's novel broke a silence.

A powerful ghost hovers over the book, that of Puig Antich, the anarchist, who was executed using the *garrote vil*, whereby the victim is slowly strangled. At the time, no one could tell whether this execution was the regime flexing its muscles or emitting one of its last gasps.

The execution causes one of the family arguments in *The Time of Cherries*. When Lluís, Natàlia's brother, refers to Puig Antich as a thief, he gets interrupted by his son: "He wasn't a thief, Dad." Lluís then calls Puig Antich a moron. And then, more weakly: "In any event, those zealots are going to make a mess of things and ruin our chances of joining the Common Market." Lluís is an embodiment of a kind of pragmatism that reigned in those years among the Catalan bourgeoisie.

For others, the execution was chilling. Natàlia's friend Harmonia blames the Communists for the stalled revolution. Another character sums up the bleak situation: "None of us wants to admit just how powerless we are," he says. "It's been years and we're getting old. Nothing has changed." The change came later. No one in this novel could have imagined that in the future, a Barcelona street would be named after Maria Aurèlia Capmany and a square on the city's outskirts would pay tribute to Salvador Puig Antich. A neighborhood park named after Montserrat Roig, who died in 1991, honors her contribution to the reimagining of Barcelona on the brink of change.

This article was adapted from Colm Tóibín's introduction to the Modern Library edition of [The Time of Cherries](#). It appears in the [April 2026](#) print edition with the headline "The Last Days of Franco."

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A Novel About a Secret No One Wants to Know

The wildly popular Norwegian novelist Vigdis Hjorth returns to a dark past.

by Honor Jones



Vigdis Hjorth, one of Norway's most famous novelists, is best known for writing about the sexual assault of a child by her father. She's published more than 20 books since the 1980s, a number of which take up the same material—a woman trying to remember something that's too dangerous to

remember; a family with a secret. Her writing tends to be classified as *virkelighetslitteratur*, or “reality fiction,” and for good reason. Hjorth makes Norway sound like a small town—the sort of place where your neighbors know you’re home if they can see your footsteps in the snow—and the overlap between her life and work has more than once been the literary version of tabloid news there.

In 2016, she published [*Will and Testament*](#). The novel was a hit, won the Norwegian Critics Prize for Literature, and made her family furious. Her sister Helga [accused Hjorth of using their family members’ correspondence](#) in the book; Hjorth said she had permission. Helga then wrote her own novel, about a woman whose sister lies about being raped by their father. Unlike her fellow Norwegian writer Karl Ove Knausgaard, Hjorth doesn’t give her characters real people’s names. But if anyone had doubts concerning how close the family in *Will and Testament* came to reality, Helga’s response seemed [perfectly crafted to dispel them](#). That people talk about the book the way they do, Hjorth [has suggested](#), is partly Helga’s fault: “I can’t say that there’s nothing from reality, because she has proven it.”

If you’re thinking, *Not another autofictional trauma plot*—don’t. Hjorth’s books—especially her latest, [*Repetition*](#), now out in English—are much stranger, and more interesting, than that. As readers, we’re accustomed to being steered toward the revelation of a trauma. But what happened to the protagonist of *Repetition* is never made fully explicit. Again and again, the book returns to one long-ago November. There is knowledge here, but it is a knowledge no one wants, leaving the reader slipping around in the dark.

What the novel is working toward is not the exposure of a violation, let alone the processing of any real-life event, but a recognition of the self—a self who survives the scourges of childhood, and a storytelling-self who learns that fiction can reveal otherwise unsayable truths.

As *Repetition* opens, the first-person narrator, a novelist in her 60s, sits next to an unhappy teenager and her parents at the symphony one night. She’s reminded vividly of events in her own 16th year. The novel in store appears to be about an adolescent girl’s first sexual experience. She meets a boy; alone in her room, she practices French kissing by pushing her tongue

against the mirror; they dance at a party, and another party; she drinks a beer, and another beer; the boy leads her upstairs.

But the boyfriend quickly proves to be a marginal figure compared with the girl's parents, particularly her compulsively vigilant mother. She is always lurking, waiting for her daughter to come home so that she can inspect her for traces of rebellion—"fingering my clothes and sniffing me, my hair, my breath," asking her where she's been and with whom. The book, like many of Hjorth's, is full of questions, which add up to a deeper one: "Why then this feeling of dread?" Even if you don't know that Hjorth has written about a violated child before, you come to suspect that this is not the girl's first sexual experience.

At the center of the novel is a diary. Now that the girl has a boyfriend, the act that has obsessed her for years, the thing she fears she'll never be able to do right, that she can never manage to joke about the way her friends do, can happen: sex. She promises the diary that she "will write about it here, on these blank pages."

But the night is a failure. The boy is too nervous or inept to do his part. How can she disappoint "the expectant, hungry, hopeful diary"? She has to write something. So she makes it up: "I invented what I had imagined in explicit detail."

The entry starts like a bad romance novel, the boy "brazen and swollen like hardened steel." But soon the language becomes fast and frank: "On paper I did everything I would never have dared to do." She puts the words down "eagerly and with a liberating lack of inhibition and a comforting tenderness for myself." She goes on: "I wrote and I wrote, I filled my enormous void with words." Writing is so powerful that the words themselves become a sex act.

And then her parents find the diary. Their grief and rage are terrifying. But she has discovered something she'll never forget: that "fiction can have a greater impact than the truth, and be more truthful." What she means, in part, is that her made-up story elicited a reaction—her father's despair, her mother's rejection—that she will truly understand only later, when the girl knows the family's secret.

All of this is agonizing, but Hjorth also writes sublimely about the wonder and subjugation of life as a teenager—what it feels like to be a girl with friends, to live in a place that’s lovely even in the cold and the dark. And she can be very funny. The girl “might be capable of doing *anything* should the opportunity present itself, except”—so relatable—“it didn’t.” Consider the sexless sex scene: The boy climbs on top of her and thrusts and groans. But he’s not inside her. She tries pointing out the problem: “You’re not inside me.” When he stands up, the condom falls right off his flaccid penis. Later, smug and swaggering, he whispers in her ear, “Now I’ve made a woman of you.”

The story isn’t funny in the end, because it’s replaced by the diary version, which causes so much damage. But it’s funny while you’re reading it.

Repetition is a powerful sliver of a book—it really doesn’t have enough pages to contain as much life as it does. It transcends the trauma plot by, counterintuitively, immersing us completely in the past: not in one devastating event, but in the whole past, of moment after moment. Terrible things happen in families, in history, Hjorth seems to be saying, but that’s not so remarkable. What’s remarkable is that these people, who used to be us, existed—that, day after day, they actually lived like this:

I went to the kitchen and sat down in my usual seat, fishcakes in white sauce and potatoes with chopped parsley, I will never forget it. It really did happen, it is strange to remember it now and it seems unreal that this family would sit around a kitchen table and have dinner together almost every night all year round, it’s mind-blowing, but that is how it was, and the strangest thing of all is that it was the most natural thing in the world.

“Will you never let it go?” the narrator of *Repetition* demands. “No. I repeat and recall and relive and retell.” Of Hjorth’s six novels that have been translated into English, all by Charlotte Barslund, four have at their core a broken childhood and buried secrets. Hjorth and her protagonists know that retreading this territory can feel claustrophobic. *Will and Testament*—made up of thoughts and second thoughts, attacks and counterattacks—is about the narrator’s battle to make her family listen to what her father did. When nobody does (“Shame on you”; “What nonsense”; “Liar, Mum hissed”), she

has no choice: She repeats herself. But don't think for a second that anyone is more fed up than she is. Put it in her epitaph, she thinks: "All because of my stupid childhood."

Release from remembering would be bliss, but even if that were possible, it's not Hjorth's goal. Repetition is needed to know oneself, and to make oneself known. Hjorth's protagonists also turn that obsessive attention outward—to try to understand others. In [*Is Mother Dead*](#), which was longlisted for the 2023 International Booker Prize, the narrator struggles to approach her estranged mother by imagining over and over what could have made her the way she is. What must she have suffered that left her incapable of caring for her child? The result is a colossal, and failed, feat of empathy: A mother can be forgiven many mistakes, but not for giving up on loving her daughter. It is the saddest story about a parent, and the saddest story about the limits of storytelling, I think I have ever read.

The narrator of *Repetition* is different from these earlier protagonists because she knows that her art grows out of her repetitions. She is no longer trying to explain herself to anyone, but fixing in memory that which threatens to slip away. The book emerges from the tension between what the narrator expects to be "unforgettable"—the night with the boy—and the originating event that everyone has tried so hard to forget. She writes to return to the past, to the bewildered girl she used to be—to save her from "the mute darkness."

More than four decades ago, Hjorth published her first book: a children's picture book about a boy in a yellow apartment building. She has written [fiction and nonfiction about politics, philosophy, drinking](#). [*Long Live the Post Horn!*](#), published in the United States in 2020, is very different from *Repetition* (it's about a consultant tasked with writing PR materials opposing a European Union policy on postal rates that ... Actually, don't worry about it). Yet it's also concerned with the power of language, and children's capacity to wield that power. It begins in despair—"the silence on the Metro and the chill, the sick and the fear of getting sick"—before brightening into hope.

Deep in the book comes a story: A postman recounts how he has spent months tracking down an old woman named Helga Brun so that he can

deliver her a letter. Her tale, he warns, is “shocking” and “dreadful” yet (how very Hjorth) “enjoyable.” Helga arrives on an island in 1967. She has come to teach at the island’s school for the summer, so that working parents have somewhere to send their children while the ordinary instructors have a vacation. (Americans: This is not magical realism; it’s just Scandinavia.) She teaches the children geography and takes them outdoors to learn the names of birds. Parents smile “at the sight of this cheerful group, the island’s future.”

But then she assigns an essay. What is it about? The children won’t say, but something sinister is going on. They brood and can’t sleep until one night they start frantically writing, and when they’re done, instead of leaving the papers on their desks where the parents can read them, the children run outside, all the way to Helga’s house, to deliver the essays straight into her hands.

The next day, their eyes are “eerily dark,” and the parents shudder to look at them. Now we’re in a horror movie, and all the adults of the island, “led by the vicar and the doctor,” gather at the school—missing only pitchforks to complete the scene—and storm inside to demand that Helga tell them “the title of the essay.” When Helga answers, the parents leap forward to seize the essays; the children scream. Everyone, young and old, grabs

at the delicate papers which were torn to shreds between fearful, frantic fingers, the children stuffed the scraps into their mouths and swallowed them, in less than a minute the pile was pulverised from the shared desire of everyone involved, a desire for annihilation.

Helga is sent away. The children will forget, the parents say, but the children don’t. Forty years later, one of them writes that letter the postman is determined to deliver, thanking Helga for asking the one thing their parents couldn’t stand to know, the thing the children had suffered over, alone and in silence: “Why am I unhappy?”

One reason I love this parable is that it’s such a long way from autofiction. But all of Hjorth’s themes are here. The children know that what they wrote is so powerful, it has to be destroyed. Would they have told the parents eventually, if only they’d been patient and gentle? I don’t know.

The narrator of *Repetition* tears up her diary and flushes the pages down the toilet. For many years, she doesn't write. Then one day she publishes a children's book. *That's okay*, her parents must have felt. *That's no threat*. She keeps going. She imagines her parents anxiously leafing through her books—their relief, at first, “when they didn't find what they were looking for,” their worry growing as the books come closer to the truth. Pity them, those “poor, long-suffering parents always on tenterhooks.” Since she was a child, she has never understood why they were afraid of her. Now that she's a writer, she knows why.

Even in *Repetition*, however, so much remains unsaid—not to protect the parents, but to protect the self. The girl “would not have survived remembering and reliving” all that has happened. “It could have killed her, I know this because I, her mature self, don't have the strength” to relive it either. I wonder if Hjorth will ever write a character who does. But even if that were possible, I can't imagine her project ever being finished. The memories of childhood return because they need “to tell you something,” the narrator says on the first page of *Repetition*. On the last page, she has a vision. She opens the door to find the girl she used to be: “I put my arms around her, she lets herself be held and our embrace suspends time.”

This article appears in the [April 2026](#) print edition with the headline “Vigdis Hjorth's Family Secrets.”

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The College-Educated Working Class

**Can a generation of graduates
frustrated by their economic
prospects change American labor
politics?**

by George Packer



This article was featured in the One Story to Read Today newsletter. [Sign up for it here.](#)

This is an age of mutinies. For more than a decade in America, they've come so thick and fast that they trip over one another: the Tea Party, Occupy, Black Lives Matter, the Resistance, the anti-lockdown protests, the

insurrection, the anti-ICE protests. The ur-mutiny, encompassing some of these, provoking and provoked by others, is MAGA. Even in full authoritarian control of the federal government, it still acts like a rioter laying dynamite at the foundation of a decayed establishment.

We understand these revolts in terms of the dominant political fact of our time, the forever war between red and blue. The mutinies are staged by one side or the other, and every high-profile trial, incendiary speech, and shooting caught on camera divides Americans instantly and predictably into two opposing camps, with apparently irreconcilable visions of what is true and of what the country is and should be: multicultural America versus heritage America. The former is inclusive, outward- and forward-looking; the latter is exclusive, inward-looking, and nostalgic for a past that it tries to recapture by tearing up traditions, norms, and the Constitution itself.

The obvious precedent for an age of mutinies is the decade before the Civil War—the years of *Uncle Tom's Cabin*, Bleeding Kansas, *Dred Scott*, and John Brown—when pressure built up until it exploded in what future Secretary of State William H. Seward labeled “the irrepressible conflict.” The roll call of the present goes through the coronavirus pandemic, George Floyd, January 6, Project 2025, Charlie Kirk, Renee Good, and Alex Pretti. Now that President Trump's masked militias are battling residents in the streets of blue cities, our own conflict seems to be coming to a head.

But if we unfasten our gaze long enough from the riveting prospect of another civil war, a different historical period comes to mind. The fundamental sources of our troubles, going back half a century, are economic inequality, political paralysis, corruption, mass immigration, and cultural and technological upheavals. These were exactly the country's great problems at the start of the previous century. In 1914, Walter Lippmann wrote in his manifesto, [*Drift and Mastery*](#): “No mariner ever enters upon a more uncharted sea than does the average human being born into the twentieth century.” Several decades of populism, progressivism, and reaction led to the emergence of a new order with the New Deal.

What is life like for someone born in the 21st century? Your everyday reality is disorienting change—but not the kind that freed Lippmann and his generation to shape their era. Instead, your overwhelming feeling is that the

game is rigged against you. You see the old as at best indifferent, if not outright predatory, and lacking the ability or the desire to solve the problems they've inflicted on you. The electronic air you breathe crackles with vituperation. Political and media elites hoard status and wealth by keeping you in a perpetual fever of resentment and fury. Meanwhile, tech giants addict you from toddlerhood to devices that alienate you from other people and the natural world, trapping you in a hall of mirrors, until you give up on the idea that truth is even knowable and surrender to the wildest images of unreality. Your sense of your own existence grows fragile, and your job prospects are as precarious as your mental health. Whatever your race or gender, it feels like a liability. The system is a conspiracy against your chance at a decent life.

Anger and helplessness drive some young people to [Nick Fuentes](#), others to [Hasan Piker](#), and others still to fentanyl or 20-hour days of *Fortnite*. They might revile one another, but they exist in the same frame, where they suffer many of the same afflictions. From this perspective, the culture wars momentarily recede. Perhaps the most important arena of struggle isn't the internet, where the wars are fought and nothing is achieved except division, but the physical world, where certain problems are common to all ordinary people. Perhaps the deepest conflict is not between red and blue, but between power and powerlessness.

[Michael Podhorzer: The paradox of the American labor movement](#)

Compared with a vicious online duel, this conflict is hard to dramatize. It seldom becomes the focus of politics, except in grand rhetorical gestures or small fixes for the deterioration of everyday life. A congresswoman denounces monopolistic oligarchy; a senator rails against Big Tech; another congresswoman drafts legislation against the nuisance of overly bright headlights and for the “[right to repair](#)” your own truck or washing machine. A movement of 20-somethings embraces [dumb phones](#). And even now, amid the head-spinning events of Trump's second term, there's a sense that nothing fundamental changes. In Lippmann's time, the relations among citizens, corporations, and government underwent a historic transformation; in our time, new laws and civic reforms hardly ever arise. We spend our energy on the mostly online battles of the red-blue war, stumbling down the

path of the 1850s, while the powerful entities that control our lives grow bigger and more corrupt.

The subtitle of Noam Scheiber's [*Mutiny: The Rise and Revolt of the College-Educated Working Class*](#) points to an unexpected group of young people who are toiling against concentrated wealth and power. A college-educated working class sounds like an oxymoron because socioeconomic status is generally defined by education and believed to rise with each academic degree. In recent years, a college education has become one of the most reliable indicators of both economic well-being and voting behavior. Americans with a college degree tend to make [75 percent more](#) money over their lifetime than those without, and in the past three presidential elections, these better-educated, wealthier voters have moved steadily to the Democratic Party. In 2024, they voted for Kamala Harris over Donald Trump by 16 percentage points. As if according to some law of political dynamics, non-college-educated Americans have gone for Trump and the Republican Party by similar margins. The political alignment of the 20th century, when workers tended to favor Democrats and professionals Republicans, has been reversed in the 21st. The education divide is the most significant factor in American politics—sharpest among white voters, and increasing among Latino voters as well.

These trends are so glaring that the term *working class* is now used to describe both those without a college degree and the MAGA base. So in reporting on the college-educated working class, Scheiber, who covers labor for *The New York Times*, is like a zoologist whose fieldwork has revealed the existence of an animal that contradicts some long-standing theory of speciation.

His subjects, in their 20s or early 30s, came out of college with heavy debts and unrealistic expectations. A Grinnell grad, recipient of a prestigious postcollege fellowship, takes a job at a Chicago Starbucks to support himself while he tries to break into theater, only to find years later that the theater dream has died and he's still making lattes, hectored by managers, hard up enough to apply for food stamps. After college, an "Apple fangirl" in Maryland is encouraged by a local Apple Store to think of her job in terms of passion and human potential. Hired to do one-on-one tech tutorials, she hopes to move up to designing the curriculum; instead, the company's

relentless focus on profit traps her as a glorified saleswoman in a retail mall, and she fails to keep up with her bills. Corporate America seduces these ambitious young people with exalted titles that bear scant relation to the reality of the work: Apple Store “creatives” and “geniuses” who have to wheedle customers into buying a \$3,500 Vision Pro headset, Starbucks “partners” who prepare venti iced caramel macchiatos all day, Amazon “associates” whose moves around the warehouse are tracked to the minute, [adjunct “professors”](#) who earn sub-median pay with little hope of a career in their field.

It would be easy for an older, more comfortable reader, or a more truly impoverished one, to dismiss the grievances of Scheiber’s subjects. How sorry can you feel for an underemployed Hollywood scriptwriter who makes ends meet through a “sugar dating” app, as a companion for wealthy older men? These young graduates start out naive about the heartlessness of the corporate world and harbor illusory hopes for success in unforgiving professions. Culturally, they have little in common with meat packers or home health aides who never expect to do more than get by—who are toiling for their children’s futures, not their own. The college-educated are trained to expect that the world will make room for them, and when it doesn’t—when they suffer the indignities of wage work, with its unpredictable schedules and disrespectful bosses, and can see no way up or out—the blow isn’t just economic; it’s psychological. “They were often bourgeois in their tastes,” Scheiber writes. “They cradled sleek smartphones and expensive cups of coffee. They watched prestige TV on demand. But the previous decade and a half had bequeathed them the bank accounts—and the politics—of the proletariat.”



The individual stories Scheiber tells sometimes feel like cases of bad luck or poor decision making, but he's writing more broadly about a generation of graduates whose prospects have unquestionably dimmed. The price of a college degree is soaring while its comparative benefit is shrinking. The pay gap between college and high-school grads has [stopped growing](#) over the past two decades, partly because of the Great Recession and the pandemic. The number of jobs in some of the most desirable careers has dropped, creating intense competition due to what the scholar Peter Turchin calls "[elite overproduction](#)." Or, as Scheiber puts it, "too many people with expensive credentials chased too few jobs requiring those credentials." When expectation and reality part ways for a cohort that's been raised on the assumption of upward mobility—when elites start to sink, and reform is blocked—the political waters get very rough, often leading to social disintegration and unrest. Turchin's historical examples include prerevolutionary France, Russia, and Iran; another is the United States in this decade.

Scheiber's main interest is the development of a radical political consciousness in a generation of phone addicts and Netflix junkies. *Mutiny* follows a dozen or so employees at Starbucks, Apple, Amazon, Hollywood studios, and research universities who all come to the same epiphany: "They saw themselves as members of the rank and file. They grumbled about their supervisors and cursed their corporate overlords." This new awareness, whether or not it qualifies them as bona fide members of the working class, leads them to join union-organizing drives, publicize corporate abuses, go on strike, and gradually find more purpose in labor activism than in their thwarted professional ambitions.

We remember the pandemic as a boiling point in the culture wars. The continuous battles over lockdowns, masking, police violence, expertise, conspiracy theories, and the outcome of the 2020 election have never really subsided. But the pandemic also exposed the grotesque unfairness of our economy and society in deeply personal ways, cutting across the red-blue divide. In the pandemic's early days, before the crisis became completely subsumed by the cultural civil war, a memorable phrase appeared: *essential workers*, people whose livelihood required them to show up at work and risk their health. The difference between the fates of essential and nonessential workers was a profound injustice, and a healthy country would have made it

a focus of public attention and policy. Jeff Bezos's fortune increased by \$24 billion in the pandemic's first month. Meanwhile, his company's treatment of its essential workers, and the firing of Chris Smalls, an outspoken employee in a Staten Island warehouse, triggered the creation of the first Amazon union—a milestone in the recent surge of labor activism in America.

[Steven Greenhouse: Is organized labor making a comeback?](#)

But Amazon turned out to be a more difficult case for labor organizing in the early 2020s than Starbucks, Apple, or Disney. Disagreements over tactics and strategy led to a power struggle that divided the union, damaging the cause of labor at Amazon. Smalls, the union's first president, framed the division along lines of race and class; his leadership faction claimed to speak for the warehouse's Black and brown workers who never went to college (though Scheiber points out that the opposition to Smalls also included nonwhite, non-college-educated workers). In his forthcoming memoir, [When the Revolution Comes](#), Smalls accuses white college-educated organizers at the Staten Island warehouse of trying to take power away from the authentic working class. He insists that the Amazon union must be led by workers of color—only they have the experience of hardship to understand and speak for the rank and file. “If there is any mistake I made, any regret I have,” Smalls writes, “it’s the fact that early on we let people who didn’t see the importance of race and culture the way we did get into positions of power within our movement.”

In a way, Smalls is challenging the thesis of *Mutiny*. He's implying that there's something inauthentic, maybe flatly contradictory, about a college-educated working class, especially a white one. He's saying that “race and culture” matter more than an hourly wage. The fracturing of the Amazon union at the Staten Island warehouse plays a relatively small part in *Mutiny*. Though Scheiber occasionally questions the wisdom of his protagonists, he's plainly on their side. He considers their oppression real, their struggles just, and their activism the best way to achieve more stable, dignified lives. But he isn't sufficiently aware of the insularity and fragility of their project.

Mutiny includes no college grads in dead-end jobs whose grievances have turned them toward MAGA rather than union activism—young men and

women recruited by Turning Point USA while still in college. Instead, most of the book's protagonists would feel at home at a Democratic Socialists of America convention. They're the kind of progressive Zoomers and Millennials who use gender-neutral pronouns and post online about Palestine. Within two days of October 7, a Starbucks organizer called on X for "solidarity with Palestine!," and even though the post was soon taken down, Gaza created such controversy for Starbucks that the company and union sued each other over [social-media posts about the war](#). Joe Biden's efforts to be the most pro-labor president in history didn't spare him the wrath of young Starbucks employees who accused him of complicity in genocide. The war galvanized them in a way that haggling over wages and hours no longer did.

The point isn't that the Starbucks union should have taken a different position on Gaza, or that Smalls was wrong to insist on the centrality of "race and culture" at the Amazon warehouse. But these episodes show how easily the culture war can insert itself into a righteous cause. At the Apple Store in Maryland, Black and white workers in the union maintained cohesion and were able to negotiate a decent contract by focusing on corporate greed, which required a delicate balance between acknowledging the differences in their life experiences and resisting the centrifugal pull of identity.

This decade has seen [more union activism](#) than any other in almost half a century. The overweening power of corporations and plutocrats has turned much of the country in favor of labor, and Scheiber believes that it doesn't matter whether workers assemble automobiles, make upscale coffee drinks, or write television scripts. He seems sanguine that the college divide is fading as more and more Americans experience the whip hand of a heartless economic order. Scheiber cites polls that show college graduates drawing closer to the more conservative views of the working class on immigration and crime, and he takes this as evidence that "there may be a basis for an alliance between the two groups after all."

But other polls suggest real disagreements between those with and without a college degree. For example, on whether to deport all immigrants in the country illegally, one poll found that the gap is almost 20 percentage points among non-Hispanic white people. In general, I'm more skeptical than

Scheiber is that progressive baristas—let alone newly unionized doctors and architects—are going to be eagerly embraced by their working-class brothers and sisters. Plenty of Americans will dislike the attitudes and styles of *Mutiny*'s activists. There are important cultural differences between an internist struggling to treat patients in a private-equity conglomerate and a John Deere machinist on strike because of layoffs. That both belong to a union might matter less than that one voted for Harris, the other for Trump, and each has some reason to fear and loathe the other. The culture war is burning too hot for a class war to snuff it out anytime soon.

The radicalization of college-educated Americans who have begun to live the unpleasant realities of their less privileged compatriots—who can hardly afford rent, much less to buy a house and start a family—is an encouraging turn. They could form part of a broader social movement that finally addresses our deepest problems instead of dissolving them in electronic bile. A professional class that identifies with America's multitudes of have-nots and votes on that basis would be a powerful force for greater equality and opportunity.

[From the November 2025 issue: George Packer doesn't want to stop believing in America's decency.](#)

But to succeed, such a movement has to be aware of the fault lines that could make it fail, and take care not to widen them. Tread lightly around the identity traits no one chose and the beliefs no one will give up; instead, emphasize [a common economic fate](#). The ground that unites the powerless against the powerful is always about to collapse. Our irrepressible red-blue conflict is always ready to set Americans against Americans in every conceivable way: education, race, religion, age, gender, region, even views of foreign wars. It's better to be honest about these differences, and try not to rub them raw until they destroy the chance for a better country, than to assume that they don't matter or wish them out of existence.

This article appears in the [April 2026](#) print edition with the headline "The College-Educated Working Class."

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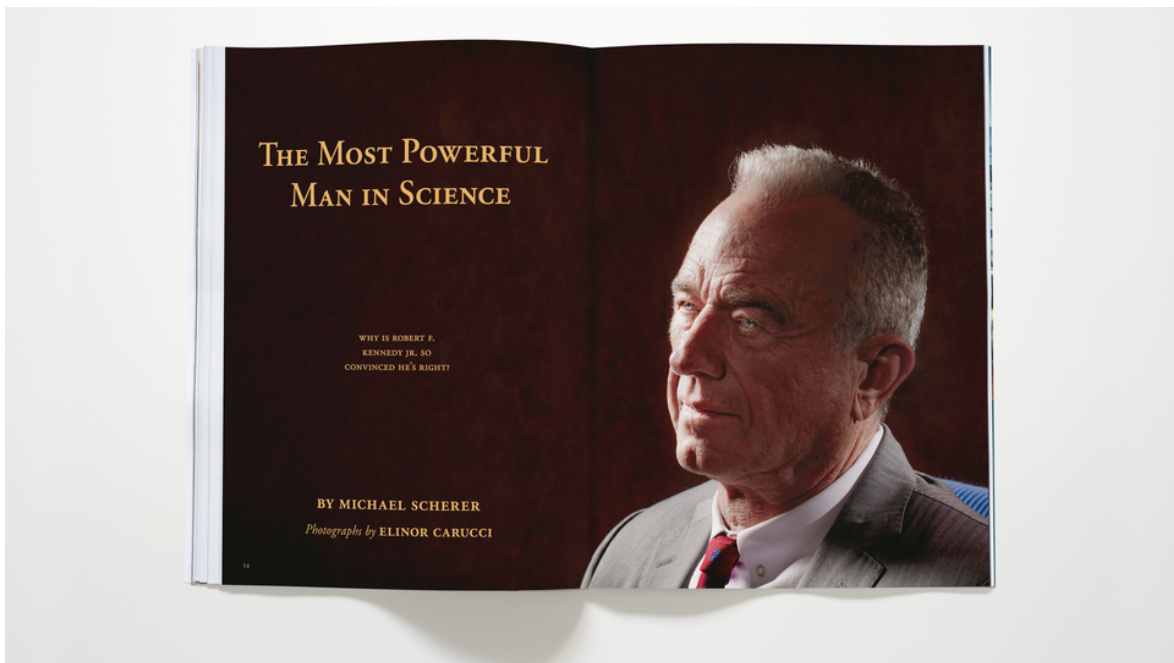
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I Remember a World Without Vaccines

Readers respond to our January 2026 cover story.



The Most Powerful Man in Science

In the January issue, [Michael Scherer considered](#) why Robert F. Kennedy Jr. is so convinced he's right.

I am a pediatrician who witnessed the rise of vaccine and science skepticism during the coronavirus pandemic, and I'm terrified by Robert F. Kennedy Jr.'s decimation of the Department of Health and Human Services, the CDC,

and the National Institutes of Health. Michael Scherer's article resonated with me. I am open-minded; I believe in integrative practices, and I agree that the medical establishment can be arrogant and unduly influenced by the pharmaceutical industry, which now funds so much of medical research. But I fully understand Scherer's frustration with his interminable discussions with Kennedy about scientific articles. I, too, have read articles about the benefits of weird diets or the dangers of vaccines, and tried to reason with my patients' parents about them—parents who didn't understand the meaning of statistical significance, or any of the scientific jargon used in the articles they would bring me.

But after reading about RFK Jr.'s 14-year battle with drug addiction, his daily Alcoholics Anonymous meetings, and his admitting that he has had to "completely commit" himself "to a way of life" in AA, I was struck by his final words to the author: "Good health does not just come in a syringe." Very bad things happened to him and those around him due to the contents of syringes. I understand if he has a deep-seated skepticism of anything delivered through a needle. But even if his skepticism is understandable, as the head of the largest and most important civilian agency in the federal government, he must rely on facts, not fear.

David Gottsegen, M.D.
Belchertown, Mass.

Francis Collins, a former director of the National Institutes of Health, had advice for dealing with people like Robert F. Kennedy Jr.: Try to understand the backstory of someone you don't agree with, in order to convince them that you have given them a fair hearing without trying to change their mind. I admire that Michael Scherer appears to have followed his advice.

RFK Jr. has raised many questions about the way the government has handled the problems of public health, and those questions deserve answers. But he has stubbornly and falsely alleged that no one has contradicted his research or his supposed "evidence." At a certain point, he has no right to be taken seriously by anyone who truly cares about public health.

Kirk S. Ray
Little Rock, Ark.

I am a retired infectious-disease physician. In his interviews with Michael Scherer, Robert F. Kennedy Jr. seemed to demand absolute certainty that all risk has been removed from a given treatment before a doctor can recommend it. If this were the case, we would be unable to recommend treatment for any disease. Certainty is impossible in medicine—that's why physicians speak in terms of risks and benefits. Even good old penicillin has its risks.

As for Kennedy's investigation into whether vaccines cause autism: He is directing millions of dollars toward one line of inquiry while neglecting other possible factors. We do epidemiological studies to test hypotheses. If there isn't a "signal" suggesting a link between two things, then why keep searching for one? Resources aren't limitless.

RFK Jr. isn't trained to think like a scientist or a physician. Ultimately, this isn't a battle of viewpoints or ideologies. It's a question of data—and we have reams of them, interpreted by credentialed statisticians.

Barbara McGovern, M.D.
Needham, Mass.

Upon finishing Michael Scherer's profile of Robert F. Kennedy Jr., I realized that he and Donald Trump are not strange bedfellows after all, despite their initial differences in political affiliation. Both searched for issues that could lead them to the pinnacle of national power, and both found the same target: America's highly educated, cosmopolitan elite, which had written them off as unserious. The rest of us are watching their revenge play out on a grand scale.

John Yochelson
Bethesda, Md.

In April 1980, as a radio reporter with one year of experience, I interviewed Robert F. Kennedy Jr. in North Carolina. He was in the state campaigning for his uncle Ted Kennedy, who was running in the Democratic presidential primary. I remember RFK Jr., then only 26, as irascible—especially after I asked how he thought his uncle would explain the events of Chappaquiddick and the death of Mary Jo Kopechne to voters. He yelled at me and the interview ended abruptly. It was through that lens that I read Scherer's profile.

Forty-five years later, it seems that RFK Jr. has not changed. He still can't reflect. He is still irascible in his responses. His fixed belief remains: He is absolutely right about vaccines causing autism. He shows little understanding of what one can and cannot conclude from scientific research. It was his cousin Caroline who labeled him a predator. "I would not contest it that much," Kennedy said, when reminded of his cousin's comments by Scherer. "Addiction is kind of narcissistic." His narcissistic personality persists, even beyond his addiction, and it's causing him to prey on parents desperately seeking answers about autism and chronic disease.

Sue Ferrara

Hamilton, N.J.

My childhood friend Susan, stricken with polio, was in an iron lung in 1946 when I was finally permitted to visit her. We were both 13. I remember being terrified at the sight, though we had desperately wanted to see each other. I was allowed to visit because she was not expected to live. Another friend of mine, Jack, was carefully isolated at home during a whooping-cough epidemic the next summer because he had rheumatic fever. He still contracted that severe and highly contagious bacterial infection. Susan was released from the iron lung after three months and lived to adulthood, though with physical disabilities; Jack died of heart failure at 19.

I'm sorry that Robert F. Kennedy Jr., who was born in 1954, the year I turned 21, cannot envision those days. Or imagine the excruciating fear that enveloped my family in 1939, when my older sister Jane had measles. She was kept in a room with the shades and curtains tightly drawn to shut out

any ray of light; similar cases were leaving children sightless. Jane recovered and lived into her 70s without vision problems; she was a painter.

These diseases that shadowed my childhood were all but eradicated as vaccines were developed—and now the secretary of health and human services seems to want to bring them back. Because he lives in some alternate reality that refuses to acknowledge what science and history have so clearly proved, 13-year-olds today will suffer needless disability and early death. Why our own health and humanity should have to be sacrificed at the altar of RFK Jr.'s stubborn misconceptions is beyond comprehension.

Fran Moreland Johns
San Francisco, Calif.

Behind the Cover

In this month's cover story, "Sucker," McKay Coppins writes about his foray into sports gambling. Coppins wagered on games throughout the 2025–26 NFL season. He describes how betting changed his relationship to football—and his family—and considers the social costs of having casinos in our pockets, in the form of now-ubiquitous betting apps. For our cover image, we inverted the magazine's "A" logo to create an ace of spades, a symbol of a quainter era of gambling, when the vice was still largely confined to remote desert cities.

— **Colin Hunter**, *Art Director*

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YEAR AS A
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GAMBLER

By McKay Coppins

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Correction

“The Man Who Broke Physics” (March) stated that no other figure skater besides Ilia Malinin has landed more than three quadruple jumps in competition. In fact, no one besides Malinin has landed more than four.

This article appears in the [April 2026](#) print edition with the headline “The Commons.”

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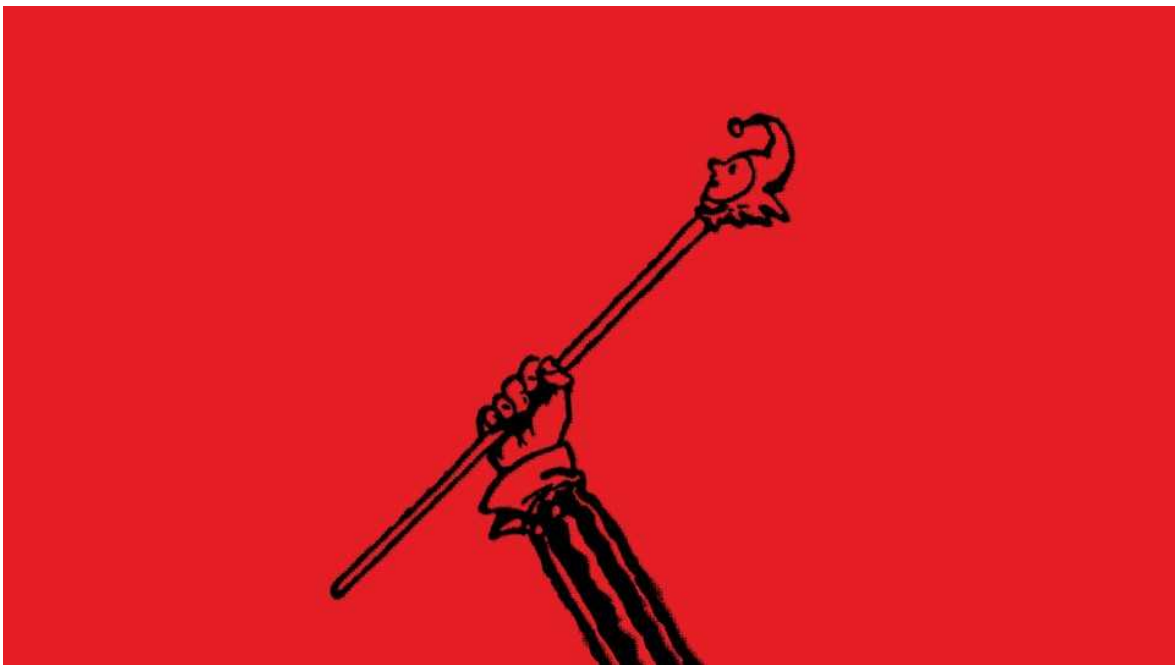
Poetry

- [**Misrule Music**](#)

Misrule Music

A poem

by Robert Pinsky



When charismatic indecency carries the day
There's not much comfort in the ancient cult
That says the dance of misrule always prances
At its one frantic ball—seems like forever
Until the music stops, the flags come down,
And ordinary corruption comes back, refreshed
In laughter. "Hitler has only got one ball."
Misrule, ha ha. But tell it to the victims:
Millions at the time and millions more today
And everyone ever since, forever, a victim?

Long-ago bumper sticker, my naive, glib
Heart in the right place: Resist Authority.
The charismatic indecency that carries
The day this year this time is not the antic
Indecency of Harpo with scissors to snip
My necktie if I am Simon the Pharisee
Who invited Jesus to supper, when Jesus favored
The sinner who brought expensive perfume to wash
His feet—and Simon wondered, was it proper?
Excuse the prig, bless Harpo, bless the sinner.

God knows what's in our nature, she used her hair.
He squeezed a horn and chased a squealing woman
Across the movie set. We laughed. The horse
At the feast of Saturn rode the master's back.
Bless the anonymous indecent Carnival lyrics
To the "Colonel Bogey March," and all the better
Knowing there never was a Colonel Bogey:
"Himmler had something similar." Prisoners of war
Whistle the tune in *Bridge on the River Kwai*,
"And Goebbels had no balls at all," but no—No,

This time, the very opposites themselves
Reverse the cult of misrule itself undone
Down to the altar. The European tribes
Crowned for one day a fool a goat a chicken,
To give the finger to a horned or strutting god.
Sometimes the blond brutes even ate the chicken.
Even the parody of order is all balled up.
And if it has happened before, all the less reason
Or more to wonder or shrug at whatever charisma
Of darker or dumber indecency carries the day.

This poem appears in the [April 2026](#) print edition.

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